

HOMER

THE ILIAD

Complete provisional interior architecture proof

7 x 10 inch hardcover / 80# coated paper target

Translation status: first-pass draft; Greek-fidelity and editorial gates remain open.

BOOK I

First-pass working translation

Sing, goddess, of the wrath of Peleus' son Achilles,
the ruinous wrath that brought unnumbered grief
upon the Achaeans, and sent many brave souls
before their time into the house of Hades,
making their bodies prey for dogs and every bird—
while Zeus's will was brought toward fulfillment—
from that first hour when Atreus' son, the king
of men, and godlike Achilles stood at odds.
Who, then, among the gods joined them in strife?
The son of Leto and of Zeus. For he,
angered against the king, sent through the host
a deadly plague; and the people perished,
because Agamemnon had dishonored Chryses,
the priest, who came before the swift ships,
to ransom his dear daughter, bearing gifts
beyond all measure, and in his hands the wreath
and golden staff of far-darting Apollo;
he prayed to all the Achaeans, but most of all
to Atreus' sons, the marshals of the people.
The priest came then to the shore, and prayed to Apollo,
the lord who bears the silver bow, and called upon him:
“Hear me, you of the fair hair, you who keep Chryse
and holy Cilla, and who rule Tenedos in power;
if ever I have built you a pleasing temple,
or burned for you the rich thigh-pieces of bulls
and goats, grant this desire: let the Danaans pay
for my tears beneath your arrows.” So he prayed,
and Phoebus Apollo heard him. Down from Olympus
he came, his heart full of anger, carrying his bow
and covered quiver. The arrows rang upon his shoulder
as the god moved; and he sat apart from the ships,
then loosed a shaft. First the mules and swift hounds
he struck; afterward he turned his bitter arrows

against the men. Through all the camp the pyres
 burned without rest.
 For nine days the shafts of the god went forth.
 On the tenth, Achilles called the people to assembly.
 Hera of the white arms had put the thought within him,
 grieving for the Danaans as she watched them perish.
 When they had gathered, Achilles rose among them:
 “Son of Atreus, soon we shall be driven back again,
 wandering among the waves, if any man remains alive.
 Come, let us ask a seer, or priest, or interpreter
 of dreams—for dreams are also from Zeus—to tell us
 why Phoebus is so bitter, whether he blames our vows
 or hecatombs, and whether he might meet us again
 and ward the ruin off by the savor of lambs
 and goats made perfect in sacrifice.”
 He sat, and Calchas rose among them, Thestor's son,
 the best of augurs, who knew what is, what was, and what will be,
 and who had led the Achaean ships to Ilium
 by that prophetic art Apollo gave to him.
 With thoughtful speech he answered them and said:
 “Achilles, dear to Zeus, you ask me to declare
 the wrath of Apollo, lord of the far-shooting bow.
 I will speak it;
 but swear to stand beside me, and be ready in word
 and hand. For I think that man
 will soon be angered against me, the one who rules
 the Argives, and whose word the army must obey.
 No light thing is a king's resentment; stronger
 is a king when angered against a lesser man. If he hides
 his anger for a day, it grows and waits for payment.”
 Achilles answered him: “Speak freely. No one here,
 while I draw breath and look upon the light of day,
 shall lift a hand against you—not Agamemnon,
 though he names himself the greatest of the Greeks.”
 Then the blameless seer took courage and spoke:
 “No vow, no hecatomb, no offering is lacking.
 The god's wrath is for Chryses and his daughter,

whom Agamemnon will not release. Send her home,
 without a price or ransom; sacrifice at Chryse.
 Then the god may turn from us and end the plague.”
 He finished. Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
 rose in anger. His dark heart filled with shadow:
 “Prophet of evil, never have you spoken good to me.
 You love to tell the army what will bring it sorrow;
 you have not once announced a thing accomplished.
 Now for the girl: I will give her back, if that is best.
 But bring me another prize at once, lest I alone
 among the Argives go without honor.”
 Agamemnon, anger still black around his heart,
 rose and spoke to Calchas first:
 “Prophet of evil, never have you spoken good to me.
 You love to prophesy what brings the army sorrow;
 you have never spoken a good word or brought it to pass.
 And now among the Danaans you declare that the far-shooter
 deals them pain because I would not accept the shining ransom
 for Chryseis, because I desired to keep her in my house.
 I prefer her even to Clytemnestra, my wedded wife;
 she is not less than Clytemnestra in form, in stature,
 in mind, or in the work of her hands. Still, I will give her back,
 if that is better. I would rather keep my people safe than see them die.
 But make ready another prize for me at once, so that I alone
 among the Argives do not go without my honor—you all see
 that my prize is being carried elsewhere.”
 Achilles, swift of foot, looked at him darkly and answered:
 “Son of Atreus, most glorious and most greedy of all men,
 how shall the great-hearted Achaeans give you a prize?
 We know of no common stores lying in abundance here:
 the spoils from the cities we took have been divided,
 and it would not be fitting to gather the people together
 and make them give those portions back. Send this girl
 to the god now; and when we take Troy's well-built city,
 we shall pay you three and four times over, if Zeus grants it.”
 Agamemnon, king of men, replied:
 “Do not, godlike Achilles, though you are good, hide your thought

and try to deceive me; you will not slip past me or persuade me.
Do you want to keep your own prize while I sit here without one,
and command me to give this girl away? If the great-hearted Achaeans
give me a prize, making it fit my desire, so be it. But if they do not,
I myself will take one—yours, Ajax's, or Odysseus's—and carry it away.
The man I visit will be angry; we shall settle that another time.
For now, haul the black ship down to the shining sea,
gather rowers in proper number, put the hecatomb aboard,
and send fair-cheeked Chryseis. Let one of the counselors lead:
Ajax, Idomeneus, godlike Odysseus—or you, son of Peleus,
most terrible of men—so that you may appease the far-shooter
by performing the holy rites.”

Achilles, looking darkly at him, answered:

“Ah, clothed in shamelessness and bent on gain—who among the Achaeans
will follow you freely, whether to march or fight in battle?

I did not come here to fight the spear-famed Trojans for my own sake:
they have never wronged me. They never drove off my cattle or my horses;
they never in Phthia, rich in soil and men, destroyed my harvest—
there are shadowed mountains and the sounding sea between us.

No: we followed you, great shameless one, to win honor for Menelaus
and for you, dog-face, from the Trojans—though you neither notice nor care.
And now you threaten to take from me the prize for which I labored,
which the sons of the Achaeans gave me. I never receive a prize equal to yours
when the Achaeans sack a well-inhabited Trojan city;
my hands bear the greater burden of the furious war.

But when the division comes, your prize is far larger,
while I carry a small but cherished portion to my ships,
after I have grown weary fighting. Now I will go to Phthia:
it is far better to sail home in my curved ships
than to remain here dishonored and heap up wealth and treasure for you.”

“Go, then, if your heart urges you; I do not beg you to stay for my sake.

There are others here who will honor me, and Zeus above all,
the counselor. You are the most hateful of the kings he nourishes.

Strife, wars, and battles are always dear to you.

If you are mighty, some god has given you that gift.

Go home with your ships and companions, rule your Myrmidons;

I care nothing for your wrath, nor do I count it as a threat.

But this I tell you: as Phoebus Apollo takes Chryseis from me,
I will send her away in my ship with my companions;
then I myself will go to your hut and take fair-cheeked Briseis,
your prize, so that you may know how much stronger I am than you,
and that every other man may fear to call himself my equal.”
Then grief and anger gathered in Achilles' chest.
He weighed two thoughts: to draw his sword from his thigh
and scatter the assembly, or to master his heart and endure.
As he drew the great blade, Athena came down from heaven,
sent by the white-armed goddess Hera, who loved both men.
She stood behind him, visible to him alone, and caught his hair.
Achilles turned and said: “Why have you come, child of Zeus?
To watch the insolence of Agamemnon? I tell you this:
his life, I think, will soon pay for what he has done.”
The goddess of flashing eyes answered him:
“I came to restrain you. Put away the sword.
Speak against him as fiercely as you will, but do not strike.
One day, for this dishonor, gifts three times over
will be set before you. Hold your hand and obey.”
Achilles answered: “A man must obey you, goddess,
though anger burns. It is better so. Whoever obeys the gods,
the gods hear him in return.” He drove the blade back
into its sheath, and Athena rose again to Olympus.
Then he faced the son of Atreus and spoke once more:
“You who wear a dog's eyes and carry a deer's heart,
never do you arm with the people for battle,
never go with the best into an ambush or the line.
That would be death to you. It is easier to walk the camp
and strip a man of his prize. You rule men who obey you,
because you are a king who feeds upon his own people.
Otherwise, son of Atreus, this would be your last outrage.
But I swear a great oath: by this staff, which will never again
put forth leaf or branch, since bronze cut it from the mountain
and stripped its bark, and now judges carry it in their hands,
judges who keep the laws that come from Zeus—
so surely shall a day come when all the Achaeans
will long for Achilles. Then, though you suffer, you cannot help them,

when Hector, breaker of ranks, kills men beside their ships.
You will tear your heart for the champion you dishonored.”
He flung the gold-studded staff upon the ground and sat.
Across from him Agamemnon still raged. But Nestor rose,
the clear-speaking elder from Pylos, whose tongue flowed sweeter
than honey. Two generations of mortal men had passed before him,
and now he ruled among the third. He addressed them:
“What sorrow has come upon the Achaean land!
The Trojans would rejoice, and Priam’s sons, and all the rest,
if they could hear you. End this quarrel. You are both younger
than I, and I have stood beside men greater than you.
Yet they listened when I spoke, and followed my counsel.
Listen now. You, Agamemnon, do not take the girl;
let her remain. And you, Achilles, do not contend
with the king, since no other scepter-bearing man
has honor equal to his. If you are the stronger, still he is greater
in rank, and more men obey him.”
Achilles cut him off: “No coward would endure your words.
Let others take your commands; do not command me:
I do not think I shall obey you any longer. And mark this well:
I will not fight you with my hands for the girl’s sake,
nor you, nor any other man, since you have taken her from me.
But of all the other things I have beside my swift black ship,
you shall carry off none against my will. Come—try it,
so that these men may see: your black blood will run around my spear.”
They broke the assembly. Achilles went to his ships
with Patroclus and his companions. Agamemnon hauled a swift ship
down to the sea, chose twenty rowers, and put aboard
the hecatomb for the god. He led fair-cheeked Chryseis aboard,
and set wise Odysseus as captain. They climbed in and sailed
the wet roads of the sea; meanwhile Agamemnon ordered the army
to cleanse itself. They washed and cast the filth into the sea,
then sacrificed perfect hecatombs of bulls and goats to Apollo
beside the shore of the barren sea; the smoke curled upward to heaven.
But the king did not cease from the quarrel he had first threatened.
He called Talthybius and Eurybates, his heralds and eager servants:
“Go to the hut of Achilles, son of Peleus; take fair-cheeked Briseis

by the hand and lead her here. If he will not give her, I myself will come with more men and take her—and that will be worse for him.”

They went unwillingly along the barren shore and came to the huts and ships of the Myrmidons. They found Achilles sitting beside his hut and black ship. He was not glad to see them. They stood, afraid and ashamed before the king, and said nothing.

Achilles knew why they had come and spoke first:

“Hail, heralds, messengers of Zeus and of men. Come nearer.

You are not to blame; Agamemnon is to blame, who sent you for the girl. Patroclus, beloved companion, bring her out and give her to them. Let these two be witnesses before the blessed gods, before mortal men, and before the harsh king himself, if ever again there is need of me to ward disgraceful death from the others.

For he sacrifices with a mind bent on destruction; he does not know how to think at once of what is before him and what is behind, so that the Achaeans beside the ships might fight in safety.”

Patroclus obeyed his beloved companion. He led fair-cheeked Briseis from the hut and gave her to the heralds, who returned to the Achaean ships.

The woman went unwillingly. Achilles sat apart from his companions, weeping, on the shore of the gray sea, and looked out across the boundless water. He stretched both hands toward his dear mother and prayed:

“Mother, since you bore me though I was doomed to a short life, at least Olympian Zeus, the high-thundering one, should have granted me honor; but now he has honored me not even a little. Agamemnon, son of Atreus, wide-ruling, has dishonored me: he has taken my prize, and keeps it for himself.”

His mother heard him from the depths of the sea, seated beside her old father.

Swiftly she rose from the gray sea like a mist, sat before her weeping son, caressed him with her hand, and called him by name:

“Child, why do you weep? What grief has come into your heart?

Speak out; do not hide it within you. Let us both know.”

With a heavy groan Achilles answered:

“You know it. Why should I tell it all to you, who know it already?

We went to sacred Thebes, the city of Eetion; we sacked it and brought everything here. The sons of the Achaeans divided it fairly among themselves, but they chose fair-cheeked Chryseis for Agamemnon.

Then Chryses, priest of far-darting Apollo, came to the swift ships

of the bronze-clad Achaeans to ransom his daughter, bringing
immeasurable gifts and holding in his hands the wreath and golden staff
of the far-shooting god. He begged all the Achaeans,
and above all the two sons of Atreus, commanders of the people.
All the other Achaeans approved: they urged reverence for the priest
and acceptance of the shining ransom. But Agamemnon's heart did not consent;
he sent the old man away harshly and laid a strong command upon him.
The old man went back in anger, and Apollo heard his prayer,
for he loved him dearly. He shot a deadly arrow among the Argives,
and the people died one after another as the god's shafts moved everywhere
through the wide camp of the Achaeans. Then the prophet who knew the god's will
spoke among us. I was the first to order that the god be appeased.
But anger seized the son of Atreus; he rose at once and threatened me—
and the threat is now fulfilled. The Achaeans are sending Chryseis
to Chryse in the swift ship, with gifts for the lord;
and heralds have just taken from my hut Briseis,
the girl the sons of the Achaeans gave me. Now, if you can,
protect your son: go to Olympus and supplicate Zeus. If ever
you helped his heart by word or deed—for many times in my father's house
I heard you boast that you alone among the immortals saved the dark-clouded
son of Cronus from disgrace, when Hera, Poseidon, and Athena
wanted to bind him. You came and loosed him, goddess,
quickly calling to high Olympus the Hundred-Handed One,
whom the gods call Briareus and men Aegaeon, stronger even than his father;
he sat beside the son of Cronus in glory, and the blessed gods feared him
and did not bind Zeus. Remind him of this, sit beside him, and clasp his knees,
if he will somehow help the Trojans, drive the Achaeans back to their ships
and the sea, and let them be cut down, so that all may profit by their king;
so that Agamemnon may learn what madness he committed when he dishonored
the best of the Achaeans.”

Thetis answered him, weeping:

“Ah, my child, why did I raise you, bearing such bitter grief?

Would that you could sit beside the ships without tears and without pain,
since your portion of life is short and not long at all.

But now you are short-lived and more miserable than all men;

for an evil destiny I bore you in my halls. I will go myself

to Olympus, to Zeus who delights in thunder, and tell him these things,

to see if he will listen. But for now sit beside your swift ships,
hold your wrath against the Achaeans, and withdraw altogether from war.
For Zeus went yesterday to Ocean and the blameless Ethiopians to feast,
and all the gods went with him. On the twelfth day he will return to Olympus;
then I will go to his bronze-floored house, clasp his knees,
and I think I shall persuade him.”

Meanwhile Odysseus reached sacred Chryse,
bringing the holy hecatomb. When they entered the deep harbor,
they furled the sails, laid them in the black ship,
lowered the mast into its rest, and rowed swiftly to anchorage.
They cast out the anchors and made fast the stern-lines;
then they stepped ashore through the breakers,
and brought out the hecatomb for the far-shooting god.
Chryseis too came down from the seafaring ship.
Wise Odysseus led her to the altar, placed her in her dear father's hands,
and spoke: “Chryses, Agamemnon, king of men, sent me
to bring your child and sacrifice this holy hecatomb to Phoebus
for the Danaans, so that we may appease the lord
who has brought such grievous sorrows upon the Argives.”
He placed her in her father's hands, and the old man received his child
with joy. The Achaeans then set the well-built hecatomb
around the altar of the far-shooter, washed their hands,
and lifted the barley for the rite. Chryses prayed aloud,
his hands raised to heaven:

“Hear me, god of the silver bow, who guard Chryse,
holy Cilla, and rule Tenedos in strength.
You heard me before when I prayed; you honored me
and struck the Achaean people with a great blow.
Grant me this wish once more: defend the Danaans now
from their shameful plague.”

So he prayed, and Phoebus Apollo heard him.
When they had prayed and scattered the barley, they drew back the heads,
cut the throats, flayed the victims, and cut out the thighs.
They wrapped them in fat, laid raw flesh upon them,
and the old man burned them on split wood, pouring bright wine over them;
young men stood beside him with five-pronged forks in their hands.
When the thighs had burned and they had tasted the inward parts,

they cut the rest into pieces, pierced it on spits,
roasted it carefully, and drew all the meat away.
When the work was finished and the feast prepared,
they ate, and no man's heart lacked an equal portion.
When they had satisfied hunger and thirst, the young men filled the mixing bowls,
and poured the wine into every cup, beginning on the right.
All day the young Achaeans appeased the god with song,
singing the beautiful paean and praising the far-shooter;
and he rejoiced to hear them.
When the sun had set and darkness came, they slept beside the ship.
When rose the early-born, rosy-fingered Dawn,
they sailed back toward the wide Achaean camp.
The far-shooter sent them a fair wind. They raised the mast,
spread the white sails, and the wind filled the middle canvas.
The purple wave roared around the speeding ship's stern,
and she ran across the sea, cutting her road through the water.
When they reached the broad camp of the Achaeans,
they hauled the black ship high upon the mainland sand,
set long props beneath it, and scattered to their huts and ships.
But godlike Achilles, swift of foot, remained beside his swift ships,
holding his wrath. He never went to the assembly that brings men glory,
never went out to battle; his dear heart wasted where he sat,
longing for the battle-cry and the war.
When the twelfth dawn had appeared, all the everlasting gods
went together to Olympus, with Zeus leading them.
Thetis did not forget her son's command. She rose from the sea
and climbed like mist through the great heavens to Olympus.
She found the wide-seeing son of Cronus sitting apart from the others
on the highest peak of many-ridged Olympus. She sat before him,
clasped his knees with her left hand, touched his chin with her right,
and supplicated Zeus, the son of Cronus:
"Father Zeus, if ever among the immortals I helped you
by word or deed, fulfill this wish for me.
Honor my son, who is doomed to die before all others.
Agamemnon, king of men, has dishonored him;
he took his prize and keeps it for himself.
But honor him, Olympian Zeus, counselor of the gods;

give the Trojans strength until the Achaeans honor my son
and increase his standing.”

She spoke. Zeus, gatherer of clouds, did not answer.

He sat long in silence. Thetis held fast to his knees
and asked him once more:

“Give me an unfailing promise and incline your head,
or refuse me—there is no fear in you—so I may know
how utterly I am dishonored among the gods.”

Zeus groaned heavily and answered:

“Ah, what a difficult task you set me: Hera will quarrel with me
when she taunts me with reproachful words.

Even without this, she is always scolding me before the immortals,
and says that I aid the Trojans in battle.

Go back now, before Hera notices. I will remember this
and bring it to fulfillment. To make you trust me,

I will nod with my head; there is no greater sign among the immortals.

What I confirm with a nod cannot be revoked, denied,
or left unfulfilled.”

The son of Cronus bent his dark brows and nodded.

His immortal hair streamed forward from his head,
and he shook great Olympus beneath him.

So they took counsel and parted. Thetis plunged into the deep sea
from bright Olympus, while Zeus went to his own house.

All the gods rose from their seats together when their father approached;
none dared remain seated to meet him.

Hera of the white arms had not failed to see him. She knew
that the silver-footed Thetis, daughter of the old man of the sea,
had shared his counsels. At once she spoke with taunting words:

“Who was it now, crafty one, who shared your secret counsel?

You always love to think in secret, apart from me,
and never willingly tell me what you have decided.”

The father of gods and men answered her:

“Hera, do not hope to know all my thoughts.

They will be difficult for you, though you are my wife.

No one else, god or man, will learn first the thought
that I wish to keep apart from everyone.”

Ox-eyed, revered Hera answered:

“Most terrible son of Cronus, what have you said?
I neither ask you nor question you; sit quietly and think
whatever you wish. But I fear terribly that silver-footed Thetis,
daughter of the old man of the sea, came to you at dawn,
sat beside you, and clasped your knees.
I think you promised her truly to honor Achilles
and destroy many Achaeans beside their ships.”
Zeus, gatherer of clouds, answered:
“Strange one, you are always thinking and never escape my notice.
Yet you will accomplish nothing; you will only become farther from my heart.
And that will be worse for you. Sit down in silence and obey my word,
lest all the gods on Olympus fail to help you when I stretch
my invincible hands against you.”
Hera fell silent, afraid, and sat with her heart subdued.
The heavenly gods within Zeus's house were troubled.
Then Hephaestus, famous for his craft, rose to speak,
bringing comfort to his dear, white-armed mother:
“This will be a disastrous and unbearable thing
if you two quarrel so over mortal men,
and bring disorder among the gods. There will be no joy
in the good feast, because the worse thing has prevailed.
I urge my mother—and she knows this herself—to bring comfort
to our dear father Zeus, so that he will not scold her again
and disturb our feast.”
He leapt up and placed a beautiful double cup
in his mother's hands, and spoke again:
“Endure, my mother, and bear it, though you love me dearly,
lest I see you struck before my eyes and be unable to help you.
It is hard to stand against the Olympian. Once before,
when I came eager to defend you, he seized me by the foot
and hurled me from the threshold of heaven.
All day I fell, and at sunset I landed in Lemnos,
with little life remaining. There the Sintian men cared for me at once.”
He spoke, and the white-armed goddess Hera smiled,
smiling, she accepted the cup from her son's hand.
He poured sweet nectar for all the other gods in turn,
drawing it from the mixing bowl. Unquenchable laughter rose

among the blessed gods when they saw Hephaestus bustling through the hall.
So they feasted all day until the sun went down,
and no heart lacked its equal portion—not Apollo's beautiful lyre,
nor the Muses' lovely answering song.
When the sun's bright light had set, each god went to his own house,
where famous, lame-footed Hephaestus had built a dwelling
with his knowing mind. Zeus, Olympian lord of the thunderbolt,
went to the bed where he had slept before whenever sweet sleep came upon him.
He climbed into it and slept; beside him lay Hera of the golden throne.

Source range: Book 1. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 2

First-pass working translation

When the other gods and the armed men had slept
through the dark night, Zeus who gathers clouds kept wake.
He thought how he might honor Achilles, and bring
the Achaeans to destruction beside their ships.
At last he found the counsel best: send a false dream
to Agamemnon, son of Atreus, king of men.
He called the Dream, and spoke with winged words:
“Go now, deceptive Dream, and stand beside the bed
of Agamemnon, in the likeness of old Nestor,
who is most trusted by the king. Tell him every word
as I command. Say: ‘Arm all the long-haired Achaeans.
Now you may take the city of broad-streeted Troy.
The gods who hold Olympus no longer disagree;
Hera has persuaded them, and ruin hangs above the Trojans.’”
So he spoke, and the Dream went swiftly on its errand.
It stood above the king's head, and took the likeness
of Nestor, who spoke to him in sleep:
“Son of Atreus, do you sleep? It is not right for a man
who bears the cares of armies to lie awake no longer.
Zeus has sent me to say that the gods are now united;
though he is far away, he cares for you and takes pity on you.
He commands you to arm the Achaeans without delay.
You will take wide-wayed Troy. Do not let the message
escape your mind when sweet sleep has released you.”
The Dream withdrew, leaving him to cherish in his heart
the thoughts it had planted—thoughts that were never to be fulfilled.
He thought the immortal voice had spoken truth,
not knowing what Zeus had devised, and that on that very day
he would take Priam's city. He did not know what the son of Cronus
was still preparing: more pain and groaning for Trojans and Danaans
through the violence of battle.
and rose at once, putting on his soft wool tunic.
Over it he threw a great cloak, and bound beneath his feet

his shining sandals. Then he slung the silver-studded sword
 across his shoulders, and took the scepter of his fathers,
 imperishable, with which he went among the Achaeans.
 When Dawn, the goddess, climbed high Olympus
 to announce the light to Zeus and the other immortals,
 he first called the heralds, clear-voiced men,
 to summon the long-haired Achaeans to assembly.
 They called, and the people gathered swiftly.
 First Agamemnon summoned the council of the great-hearted elders
 beside Nestor's ship, and made his careful plan:
 "Friends, a divine dream came to me through the ambrosial night.
 It looked most like Nestor in form, size, and stature;
 it stood above my head and spoke: 'Do you sleep, son of Atreus?
 It is not right for a counselor, with peoples entrusted to him,
 to sleep all night. Listen quickly: I am a messenger of Zeus,
 who, though he is far away, cares greatly for you and pities you.
 He commands you to arm the long-haired Achaeans at once.
 Now you might take broad-wayed Troy, for the immortals who dwell
 in Olympus no longer deliberate apart: Hera has bent them all,
 and grief hangs over the Trojans by Zeus's will.'
 So it spoke and flew away, and sweet sleep released me.
 Come now, if we can, let us arm the sons of the Achaeans.
 First I will test them with words, as custom allows,
 and order them to flee with their many-oared ships;
 you must hold them back, each man speaking from his place."
 He sat, and Nestor, king of sandy Pylos, answered:
 "If another Achaean had told us of this dream,
 we would call it false and urge a stronger flight.
 But the man who claims to be the greatest of the Achaeans
 saw it. Come, let us arm the sons of the Achaeans."
 So he spoke, and the council rose and obeyed the shepherd of the people.
 As bees stream from a hollow rock in endless clusters,
 when spring flowers open across the field,
 and some fly in a cloud while others settle in the meadow—
 so the many tribes of the Achaeans came from ships and shelters,
 filing before the deep shore into assembly.
 Rumor, Zeus's messenger, burned among them and urged them forward.

The gathering roared, the earth groaned beneath the seated people,
 and nine heralds shouted until they could quiet the noise enough
 for the god-nourished kings to be heard. The people sat in haste,
 and the clamor ceased. Agamemnon rose, holding the scepter
 that Hephaestus made and gave to Zeus, and Zeus to Hermes,
 the messenger who slays Argus; Hermes gave it to Pelops,
 the horse-driving king; Pelops left it to Atreus, shepherd of the people,
 and dying Atreus left it to Thyestes, rich in flocks;
 Thyestes left it to Agamemnon to carry, that he might rule
 over many islands and all Argos. Leaning upon it, he spoke:
 “Friends, heroes, Danaans, servants of Ares, Zeus the son of Cronus
 has bound me in a great and ruinous delusion—cruel Zeus,
 who once promised and nodded that I would return after sacking
 well-built Ilium, but now has devised a wicked deception
 and commands me to return to Argos without glory,
 having lost so many people. So, it seems, it pleases mighty Zeus,
 who has destroyed the crowns of many cities and will destroy more:
 his power is greatest. It would be shameful for those yet unborn
 to hear that we, so many, fought an unprofitable war
 against fewer men and never reached its end.
 If Achaeans and Trojans were counted under a faithful truce,
 if the Trojans gathered all who live within their city,
 and we Achaeans were arranged in tens, each ten choosing a Trojan
 to pour the wine, many tens of us would still lack a cupbearer:
 so much greater, I say, is our number than theirs.
 But allies from many cities stand beside them, spear-bearing men,
 who keep me from taking the well-inhabited city of Ilium.
 Nine years of great Zeus have already passed;
 the timbers of our ships have rotted and the rigging has slackened.
 Our wives and little children sit at home awaiting us,
 while our work here remains unfinished, for which we came.
 Come now, let us all obey what I say: let us flee in our ships
 to our dear fatherland. We shall never take broad-wayed Troy.”
 So he spoke, and stirred the hearts of all those who had not heard
 the council. The assembly moved like the long waves of the Icarian Sea,
 when East and South leap upon them from the clouds of Father Zeus;
 or as when the West Wind comes upon a deep field of grain,

driving violently over the ears and bowing the standing corn.
The assembly broke. They surged toward the ships,
shouting like waves that the south wind drives upon a beach,
when a deep sea runs in beneath the open shore.
But Hera, who watched the Achaeans scatter, said to Athena:
“Daughter of Zeus, will the Argives leave this land,
and give the glory of Helen to Priam and his sons?
Go now among them, and hold each man in place.”
Athena went down through the crowd. She found Odysseus,
whose mind was equal to the gods, still standing by his scepter.
He did not touch a ship, nor prepare to flee.
She stood beside him and said: “Son of Laertes,
why do you run as though every man were rushing home?
Sit here, and let the others sit as well. The king's speech
was a test, not an order to abandon the war.”
Odysseus turned, and went among the men, taking the scepter
from any noble who held it. To a king he spoke with courtesy:
“It is not fitting for you to stand like a coward.
Sit and listen. Others will hear you later.”
But when he found a common man shouting, he struck him
with the scepter and rebuked him:
“Friend, stay quiet and listen to those who have greater honor.
You are weak in war, and weak in counsel. No one man
can rule us all. There must be one king.”
The people returned from the ships. The gathering became
like a high wave breaking, then settling in its bed.
Only Thersites remained, still pouring out his unmeasured words.
He knew many shameful things, but knew no order in his speech;
he loved to quarrel with kings and say whatever seemed laughable
to the Argives. He was the ugliest man who came to Ilium:
bandy-legged, lame in one foot, his shoulders hunched together
over his chest, and above them his pointed head was thinly covered
with down. Achilles and Odysseus hated him most of all,
for he was always abusing them. Now he shrilled against Agamemnon,
and the Achaeans grew angry and resented him in their hearts.
He shouted loudly and reproached the shepherd of the people:
“Son of Atreus, what are you blaming now, and what do you lack?

Your huts are full of bronze, and many women are there,
 chosen out for you first whenever we take a city.
 Do you still lack gold, some ransom a horse-taming Trojan
 will bring from Ilium for his son, whom I or another Achaean
 has bound and led away? Or a young woman, to join with her in love,
 whom you alone keep apart from the others? It is not fitting
 that the leader of our troubles should heap more trouble upon us.
 Soft, shameful Achaeans, no longer men—let us sail home
 with our ships and leave this man here in Troy to consume his prizes,
 so that he may see whether we are of any use to him or not—
 the man who has dishonored Achilles, a far better man than he,
 and taken his prize for himself. Yet Achilles is not angry enough;
 otherwise, son of Atreus, this would be your last outrage.”
 So Thersites mocked Agamemnon, shepherd of the people.
 At once godlike Odysseus stood beside him and looked him down:
 “Thersites, reckless speaker, hold your tongue. Do not try alone
 to quarrel with kings. I say there is no worse mortal than you
 among all who came with the sons of Atreus to Ilium.
 Therefore do not carry the kings' names in your mouth,
 or heap insults upon them, or urge the people home.
 We do not yet know how these matters will end,
 whether we Achaeans will return well or badly.
 You sit here abusing Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
 because the heroes of the Danaans give him many gifts,
 and you speak by taunting. But I tell you—and this shall be fulfilled:
 if I find you raving again as now, let Odysseus have no head on his shoulders,
 and let me no longer be called Telemachus's father,
 if I do not strip your cloak and tunic, the garments that cover your shame,
 and send you weeping to the swift ships, beaten with disgraceful blows.”
 He struck his back and shoulders with the golden scepter.
 Thersites bent, tears fell thickly, and a bloody welt rose beneath the scepter.
 He sat trembling, wiped away the tear, and looked helplessly around.
 The army, though grieved for him, laughed aloud, and one man said to another:
 “Odysseus has done countless good things, leading counsel and arming war;
 but this is the best he has done among the Argives:
 he has stopped this abusive loudmouth from insulting kings.”
 So the multitude spoke. Then city-sacking Odysseus rose,

holding the scepter; beside him bright-eyed Athena,
in the likeness of a herald, ordered the people to be silent,
so that the first and last of the Achaeans might hear
and understand the counsel. Odysseus spoke thoughtfully:
“Son of Atreus, the Achaeans now want to make you,
their king, the most disgraced of all mortal men.
They do not fulfill the promise they made when they left Argos:
that they would return after taking well-built Ilium.
They groan like young children and widowed women,
each longing to go home. It is painful to stay and return
after a single month away from one's wife on a many-benched ship,
when winter winds and the troubled sea hold a man in place.
But we have spent nine turning years here; I do not blame
the Achaeans for grieving beside their curved ships.
Yet it is shameful to remain long and return empty-handed.
Endure, friends, and stay a little longer, until we learn
whether Calchas truly prophesies or not. We know this well,
and you are all witnesses who escaped the fate of death:
when the Achaean ships gathered at Aulis, carrying slaughter
to Priam and the Trojans, we sacrificed perfect hecatombs
beside the spring, under a beautiful plane tree where clear water ran.
There a great sign appeared. A red-backed, terrible serpent,
sent into the light by Zeus himself, darted from beneath the altar
and rushed to the plane tree. There were eight sparrow nestlings,
young chicks huddled beneath the leaves on the highest branch;
their mother was the ninth, who had hatched them.
The serpent ate them as they chirped pitifully;
the mother flew around mourning her dear young,
but the serpent seized her by the wing as she cried out.
When it had eaten the chicks and their mother, the god who showed it
made the serpent conspicuous, turning it to stone.
We stood astonished at what Zeus had done.
Then Calchas spoke among us, interpreting the omen:
‘Why are you silent, long-haired Achaeans? Mighty Zeus
has shown us this great sign, late in appearing but late to fulfill,
whose glory shall never die. As the serpent ate the eight chicks
and their mother, the ninth, so shall we fight here for nine years;

in the tenth we shall take the broad-wayed city.
 That is what he said, and now all is being fulfilled.
 Stay here, well-greaved Achaeans, until we take Priam's great city."
 He spoke, and the Argives shouted loudly; the ships roared terribly
 under the Achaeans' cry, praising godlike Odysseus.
 Then Gerenian Nestor, the horseman, spoke:
 "Shame on you—you speak like children, like infants
 who know nothing of the work of war. Where are our agreements
 and oaths now? Let our counsels and plans, our libations
 and right hands pledged in trust, burn in fire.
 We quarrel with words and find no remedy, though we have been here long.
 Agamemnon, hold the unbending counsel you had before
 and lead the Argives through the harsh battle.
 Let those who plan apart from the Achaeans wither, one or two at a time;
 their plan will not succeed. Before we return to Argos,
 we must learn whether the promise of Zeus who bears the aegis
 was false or not. For I say that mighty Cronus's son nodded
 on the day we boarded our swift ships, carrying death to Troy,
 showing favorable signs with lightning on our right.
 Let no one hurry home before he has slept beside a Trojan wife
 and taken vengeance for Helen's striving and groaning.
 If anyone still fiercely desires to go home, let him touch
 his black, well-benched ship, so that he may meet death and fate
 before the others. And you, king, plan well and listen to another word:
 sort the men by tribes and clans, Agamemnon,
 so clan may help clan and tribe may help tribe.
 If you do this and the Achaeans obey, you will know
 which leader is bad and which is good, and which common man is brave:
 they will fight in their own divisions. You will know too
 whether you will fail to take the city because of your men's weakness
 or because of their lack of knowledge in war."
 Agamemnon answered him:
 "Old man, you win the assembly again. If only Zeus the father,
 Athena, and Apollo would give me ten counselors such as you among the Achaeans,
 Priam's city would soon bow and be sacked beneath our hands.
 But Zeus, son of Cronus, has given me grief: he throws me into
 useless quarrels and disputes. Achilles and I fought over a girl,

and I began it in anger. If we ever agree in one counsel again,
 Troy's suffering will no longer be delayed, not even for a little.
 Now go to dinner, so that we may join battle.
 Let each man sharpen his spear well, set his shield well,
 feed his swift-footed horses well, and inspect his chariot carefully,
 so that all day we may be tested in hateful Ares.
 There will be no pause, not even for a little, unless night comes
 to divide the force of men. The shield-strap will sweat
 around the chest of one man, his hand will grow weary on the spear;
 another's horse will sweat as he strains the polished chariot.
 But whoever I see willingly lingering apart from battle
 beside the curved ships will not escape the dogs and birds."
 The Argives shouted loudly, like waves breaking upon a high shore
 when the South Wind rises and drives them against a projecting rock;
 the waves never leave it, whatever wind blows from this side or that.
 They rose, scattered among the ships, and kindled fires in the huts;
 each man sacrificed to the everlasting gods, praying to escape death
 and the labor of Ares. Agamemnon sacrificed a five-year-old, fat ox
 to mighty Zeus, and called the oldest and best of the Pan-Achaeans:
 Nestor first, then King Idomeneus; the two Ajaxes, then Tydeus's son,
 and sixth Odysseus, whose mind was equal to Zeus's.
 Menelaus came of his own accord, for he knew in his heart
 how his brother labored. They stood around the ox, lifted the barley,
 and Agamemnon prayed:
 "Most glorious and greatest Zeus, dark-clouded lord of the sky,
 let not the sun go down and darkness come before I cast
 the smoky roof of Priam's house upon its face and burn its doors
 with hostile fire, and tear Hector's shirt across his breast
 with bronze, while many of his companions fall around him
 face-first in the dust and bite the earth."
 So he prayed, but the son of Cronus did not grant his prayer;
 he accepted the sacrifice, but increased the labor without end.
 When they had prayed and scattered the barley, they drew back the heads,
 cut the throats and flayed the victim, then cut out the thighs,
 wrapped them in fat, and laid the raw flesh upon them.
 They burned these on leafless sticks over the fire,
 and held the inward parts above the flame. When the thighs were burned

and they had tasted the inward parts, they cut the rest into pieces,
 pierced them on spits, roasted them carefully, and drew away the meat.
 When the labor was finished and the feast prepared, they ate;
 no man's heart lacked an equal portion.
 When they had satisfied hunger and thirst, Gerenian Nestor, the horseman,
 spoke first:
 "Most glorious son of Atreus, king of men, let us no longer
 keep speaking here or delay the work the god places in our hands.
 Let the heralds summon the bronze-clad Achaeans and gather them by the ships;
 we will go together through the broad army and awaken sharp Ares."
 So he spoke, and Agamemnon did not disobey. At once he ordered
 the clear-voiced heralds to proclaim battle and gather the long-haired Achaeans.
 They called, and the people assembled swiftly. Around Agamemnon
 the god-nourished kings rushed to their places, and with them went bright-eyed
 Athena, bearing the precious, ageless, deathless aegis;
 from it hung a hundred golden tassels, each worth a hundred oxen.
 With it she flashed through the Achaean ranks, urging them forward,
 and put an unwearied strength into every heart to fight and make war.
 Then battle became sweeter to them than sailing home
 in their hollow ships to their dear fatherland.
 As a ruinous fire blazes through an immense forest on a mountain's crest,
 and its light is seen from far away, so from the bronze of the advancing host
 a light rose through the air and reached heaven.
 As the many tribes of winged birds—geese, cranes, or long-necked swans—
 fly here and there on the Asian meadow beside the streams of Cayster,
 settling joyfully on their wings with clamor that rings across the meadow,
 so the many tribes poured from ships and huts onto the Scamandrian plain.
 The earth beneath their feet and horses thundered terribly.
 They stood on the flowering Scamandrian plain, countless as leaves and flowers
 that come in their season. As countless swarms of flies wander through
 the shepherds' fold in spring, when milk drenches the pails,
 so many long-haired Achaeans stood on the plain, eager to break the Trojans.
 As goatherds easily sort wide flocks of goats after they mingle in the pasture,
 so the leaders arranged them here and there for battle.
 Agamemnon stood among them, like Zeus who delights in thunder
 in eyes and head, like Ares in his belt, like Poseidon in his chest.
 As a bull stands conspicuous above all the cattle gathered in a herd,

so Zeus made the son of Atreus conspicuous and foremost among the many heroes.

“Tell me now, Muses, who dwell in Olympian houses—
you are goddesses, present and knowing all things;
we hear only rumor and know nothing for ourselves—
who were the leaders and commanders of the Danaans?
I could not name the multitude or tell its number,
not if I had ten tongues and ten mouths, an unbreakable voice,
and a bronze heart within me, unless the Olympian Muses,
daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus, remembered all who came to Ilium.
I will tell the leaders of the ships and all the ships themselves.”

First came the Boeotians. Peneleus and Leitus led them,
Arcesilaus, Prothoenor, Clonius beside them—
men of Hyria, rocky Aulis, Schoenus, and Scolus,
of Eteon, Thespia, Graia, and broad Mycalessus,
of Harma, Eileision, Erythrae, and Eleon,
of Hyle, Peteon, Ocalea, and well-built Medeon,
of Copae, Eutresis, deep-rifted Thisbe,
of Coronea, grassy Haliartus, Plataea,
and Glisas; of lower Thebes, well built,
of holy Onchestus, Poseidon’s shining grove,
of vine-rich Arne, Mideia, sacred Nisa,
and Anthedon, at the world’s far edge.

Fifty ships came from them, and in each ship
one hundred and twenty young Boeotians embarked.
Aspledon and Minyan Orchomenos sent their people,
under Ascalaphus and Ialmenus, sons of Ares,
whom Astyoche, daughter of Actor, bore to the god—
the modest maiden had climbed to her upper room,
and the strong god lay with her in secret.

Thirty hollow ships marched behind them.
The Phocians were led by Schedius and Epistrophus,
sons of great-hearted Iphitus, Naubolus’ son;
they held Cyparissus, rocky Pytho, sacred Crisa,
Daulis, Panopeus, Anemoria, and Hyampolis,
the dwellers beside divine Cephissus,
and those who held Lilaea by the springs of Cephissus.
Forty black ships followed them. The Phocians formed

their ranks beside the Boeotians, on the left.
Ajax, swift son of Oileus, led the Locrians—
the lesser Ajax, not so great as Telamonian Ajax,
but much smaller, lightly armored, a little man;
yet with his spear he surpassed all Panhellenes
and Achaeans. His men held Cynus, Opus, Calliarus,
Bessa, Scarphe, lovely Augeia, Tarphe, and Thronium,
around the streams of Boagrius. Forty black ships
followed the Locrians, who live beyond holy Euboea.
The Abantes held Euboea, breathless for battle:
Chalcis, Eretria, vine-rich Histiaea, Cerinthus,
the sea-cliff city of Dios, Carystus, and Styra.
Elephenor, son of Chalcodon, led them,
great-hearted chief of the Abantes. Behind him came
the swift-haired spearmen, eager with ashwood lances
to break the corslets on their enemies' chests.
Forty black ships followed them.
Those who held Athens, the city well built,
the people of great-hearted Erechtheus—whom Athena,
daughter of Zeus, once raised, and the grain-giving earth
bore, then set within her rich temple in Athens,
where Athenian youths appease him with bulls and lambs
as the years turn—were led by Menestheus, son of Peteus.
No man on earth could equal him in ordering
horses and shielded men for battle; only Nestor,
older by birth, contended with him. Fifty black ships
followed. Ajax brought twelve from Salamis
and stationed them beside the Athenian ranks.
The men of Argos held Tiryns with its walls,
Hermione and Asine deep in their bay,
Troezene, Epidaurus thick with vines,
Ægina, Mases, and the Achaean shore.
Diomedes, strong in battle, led them,
with Sthenelus, beloved son of famous Capaneus,
and Euryalus, godlike, son of king Mecisteus,
son of Talaus. Diomedes led them all.
Eighty black ships followed.

The men of Mycenae, the well-built city, came too,
 of wealthy Corinth and well-built Cleonae,
 of Orneia, lovely Aretbyrea, and Sicyon,
 where Adrastus first reigned, and of Hyperesia,
 high Gonoessa, Pellene, Ægium, and the shore
 all along Aegialus, around broad Helice.
 Agamemnon, son of Atreus, led one hundred ships;
 with him came the most numerous and best of the people.
 He himself put on the flashing bronze and shone,
 conspicuous among the heroes, since he was best
 and led a people far more numerous than the rest.
 The men of hollow Lacedaemon came, of Pharis,
 Sparta, Messa, Bryseiae, lovely Augeiae,
 Amyclae, Helos, the city by the sea,
 Laas, and Oetylus. Menelaus, his brother,
 led them—strong in battle—with sixty ships.
 They formed apart; he went among them trusting
 his own courage, urging the war, for most of all
 his heart desired to avenge Helen's distress and tears.
 The Pylian people held Pylos and lovely Arene,
 Thryon at the ford of Alpheius, well-built Epi,
 Cyparisseis, Amphigenia, Pteleos, Helos, and Dorion,
 where the Muses met Thamyris the Thracian,
 coming from Oechalia, from Eurytus of Oechalia;
 he boasted that he would defeat the Muses themselves
 if they, the daughters of Zeus who bears the aegis,
 should sing. Angered, they blinded him and stripped him
 of his wondrous song, making him forget the lyre.
 Gerenian horseman Nestor led them; ninety hollow ships
 marched in his wake.
 The Arcadians held the steep mountain under Cyllene,
 by the tomb of Aepytus, where men fight at close quarters;
 Pheneus, many-sheeped Orchomenos, Ripe, Stratia,
 windy Enispe, Tegea, lovely Mantinea,
 Stympthalus, and Parrhasia. Agapenor, son of Ancaeus,
 led them in sixty ships. Agamemnon himself,
 son of Atreus, supplied the strong-benched vessels,

for the Arcadians knew nothing of the sea;
they embarked in them to cross the wine-dark water,
many Arcadian men in every ship, skilled in war.
The men of Buprasium and divine Elis inhabited
the land from Hyrmine to Myrsinus at its edge,
from the Olenian rock to Alesium enclosed within.
Four leaders held them; ten swift ships followed each,
and many Epeans embarked. Amphinachus and Thalpius
led two divisions, sons respectively of Cteatus and Eurytus,
the Actorian pair; mighty Diores, son of Amarynceus,
led the third, and godlike Polyxenus, son of Agasthenes,
son of Augeias, led the fourth.

From Dulichium and the sacred Echinades islands,
which lie beyond the sea opposite Elis, came the people.
Meges, equal to Ares, led them—son of Phyleus,
beloved of Zeus, the horseman. Phyleus had once left
Dulichium in anger with his father. Forty black ships
followed Meges.

Odysseus led the great-hearted Cephallenians,
who held Ithaca, forest-shaking Neritum,
rough Ægilipa, Zacynthus, Crocylea,
and Asteria, and who held the mainland opposite.
Odysseus, equal to Zeus in counsel, commanded them;
twelve red-cheeked ships followed.

Thoas, son of Andraemon, led the Aetolians.
They held Pleuron, Olenus, Pylenè, sea-near Chalcis,
and rocky Calydon. The sons of great Oeneus were gone,
and Oeneus himself was gone; blond Meleager had died.
So Thoas had been charged to rule all the Aetolians.
Forty black ships followed him.

Idomeneus, famous with the spear, led the Cretans.
They held Cnossus, well-walled Gortyna, Lyctus,
Miletus, bright Lycastus, Phaestus, and Rhytium,
well-inhabited cities, and all who held Crete,
the land of a hundred cities. Idomeneus led them.
Meriones, equal to Enyalios the slayer, stood beside him;
eighty black ships followed the Cretan leaders.

Tlepolemus, Heracles' tall and noble son,
 brought nine ships from Rhodes. The Rhodians lived
 in three divisions—Lindus, Ialysus, and shining Camirus.
 Tlepolemus, famous with the spear, was born to Heracles
 and Astyoche, whom Heracles brought from Ephyra,
 after sacking the cities of the god-reared people.
 When Tlepolemus had grown in his great house,
 he killed his father's aged maternal uncle, Licymnius,
 an offshoot of Ares. He built ships at once,
 gathered a great people, and fled across the sea,
 for Heracles' other sons and grandsons threatened him.
 After suffering much, he reached Rhodes, and settled there
 in three tribes; Zeus, lord of gods and men, loved them
 and poured great wealth upon them.
 Nireus brought three equal ships from Syme—
 Nireus, son of Aglaia and King Charopus,
 the fairest man to come beneath Ilium after Peleus' son;
 but he was weak, and few followed him.
 The men of Nisyros, Crapathus, Casus, and Cos,
 the city of Eurypylus, and the Calydnian islands,
 were led by Pheidippus and Antiphus, two sons
 of Thessalus, Heracles' royal son. Thirty hollow ships
 marched behind them.
 Those who held Pelasgian Argos—Alos, Alope, and Trachis,
 Phthia and lovely Hellas—were called Myrmidons,
 Hellenes, and Achaeans. Achilles led their fifty ships,
 but they did not remember the harsh battle: no one was there
 to lead them into line. Swift-footed, godlike Achilles lay
 beside the ships, angry over fair-haired Briseis,
 whom he had taken from Lyrnessus after much toil,
 when he sacked Lyrnessus and the walls of Thebes,
 and killed Mynes and Epistrophus, spear-famed sons
 of King Evenus, Selepius' son. There he lay in grief,
 but soon he would rise.
 Those who held Phylace, flowery Pyrasus, Demeter's precinct,
 Iton, mother of sheep, Antron by the sea, and meadowed Pteleon,
 were led by warlike Protesilaus while he lived;

now the black earth held him. His wife, tearing her cheeks,
 was left in Phylace, and his house stood unfinished:
 a Dardanian killed him as he leapt first from his ship.
 Nor were his people leaderless, though they longed for him;
 Podarces, son of Iphiclus, rich in sheep, led them,
 Protesilaus' own brother, younger by birth. Yet Protesilaus
 had been first and better. Forty black ships followed.
 Those who held Pherae beside Lake Boebe, Boebe, Glaphyrae,
 and well-built Iolcus were led by Eumelus, dear son of Admetus,
 whom Alcestis, fairest of Pelias' daughters, bore to Admetus.
 Eleven ships followed him.
 Those who held Methone, Thaumacia, Meliboea,
 and rough Olizon were led by Philoctetes,
 skilled with the bow, in seven ships; fifty oarsmen,
 skilled in war, embarked in each. But Philoctetes lay
 on Lemnos, suffering cruel pain from a deadly serpent's wound,
 where the sons of the Achaeans had left him. There he lay
 in anguish; soon the Argives by the ships would remember
 their lord Philoctetes. Nor were his men leaderless:
 Medon, Oileus' bastard son, whom Rhene bore to the sacker
 of cities, arranged them. Seven ships followed.
 Those who held Tricca, rocky Ithome, and Oechalia,
 the city of Eurytus of Oechalia, were led by the two sons
 of Asclepius, good physicians, Podalirius and Machaon.
 Thirty hollow ships followed. Those who held Ormenius,
 the spring of Hypereia, Asteria, and the white peaks
 of Titanus were led by Euryphylus, glorious son of Euaemon,
 in forty black ships.
 Those who held Argissa, Gyrtone, Orthe, Elone,
 and white Oloosson were led by city-sacker Polypoetes,
 son of Pirithous, whom immortal Zeus fathered through
 Hippodameia on the day the Lapiths punished the shaggy Centaurs
 and drove them from Pelion among the Aethices. With him came
 Leonteus, an offshoot of Ares, son of the great-hearted
 Coronus, son of Caeneus. Forty black ships followed.
 Guneus brought twenty-two ships from Cyphus;
 the warlike Enienes and Perrhaebians followed him,

those who made their homes around wintry Dodona,
and those who worked beside lovely Titaresius,
whose clear water runs to Peneius but never mingles with him—
it flows above him like oil, for it is a branch of Styx's oath.
Prothous, son of Tenthredon, led the Magnetes,
who lived beside Peneius and forest-shaking Pelion.
Swift Prothous commanded them; forty black ships followed.
These were the leaders and lords of the Danaans. Now, Muse,
tell me who among them was best—the men themselves and the horses
that followed the sons of Atreus. The best horses were those
of Eumelus, swift as birds, alike in age and color,
mares whom Apollo of the silver bow had bred in Pieria,
carrying the terror of Ares. Of men, Telamonian Ajax was best
while Achilles nursed his anger—for Achilles was far better,
and his were the horses that bore the blameless son of Peleus.
But Achilles lay in his sea-going ships, angry with Agamemnon;
his people played beside the water with discus, javelins, and bows,
while the horses stood by their chariots grazing lotus and marsh celery.
The chariots lay covered in the tents, and the men, longing for their
war-loving leader, wandered through the camp and did not fight.
They moved like a fire sweeping across the whole earth;
the ground groaned beneath their feet, as when thunder-loving Zeus,
angry at Typhoeus, lashes the earth around Arima, where they say
Typhoeus has his bed. So the earth groaned beneath their feet,
and they crossed the plain swiftly.
Swift-footed Iris came to the Trojans as a messenger
from Zeus who bears the aegis, carrying a grievous message.
They were speaking in assembly at Priam's gates,
young and old gathered together. Iris stood near,
took the voice of Polites, Priam's son—the swift scout
who sat atop old Aesyetes' highest tomb, watching
for the Achaeans to depart from their ships—and spoke:
"Old man, your speeches are always dear to you,
as in peacetime; but war without respite has risen.
I have entered many battles, yet never saw
such a people, so many, moving across the plain,
like leaves or grains of sand, to fight before the city.

Hector, I charge you above all: do this.
Many allies dwell throughout Priam's great city,
and many tongues belong to these scattered peoples.
Let each commander signal those he rules,
and marshal his own citizens and lead them out."
So she spoke, and Hector understood the goddess.
He swiftly dissolved the assembly. The gates opened wide;
the people poured out, footmen and horsemen, and a great tumult rose.
Before the city stood a steep, isolated, rounded hill,
which men called Batieia, but immortals knew as the tomb
of leaping Myrine. There the Trojans and their allies formed apart.
Great Hector, crested in bronze, led the Trojans;
with him, by far the greatest and best of the armed people,
eager with their spears. Aeneas, noble son of Anchises,
led the Dardanians—Aphrodite bore him to Anchises
in the folds of Ida, when the goddess lay with a mortal.
He was not alone: Antenor's two sons, Archelochus
and Acamas, who knew every art of war, stood beside him.
The Trojans of Zeleia, rich and drinking the dark water
of the Aesepus beneath Ida's lowest foot, followed Pandarus,
glorious son of Lycaon, to whom Apollo himself gave the bow.
Adrastus and Amphius, lightly armored sons of Merops
of Percote, led those who held Adrasteia, Apaesus,
Pityeia, and steep Mount Tereia. Merops knew prophecy
better than any man and forbade his sons to enter
the death-bringing war, but the black Fates drove them on.
Those who held Percote, Practius, Sestus, Abydos,
and divine Arisba were led by Asius, son of Hyrtacides—
Asius whom great, fiery horses brought from Arisba,
beside the stream of Selleis.
Hippothous and Pyleus, offshoots of Ares and sons
of Pelasgian Lethus, led the spear-famed Pelasgians
who dwelt in deep-soiled Larisa. Acamas and hero Pirous
led the Thracians held within the rushing Hellespont;
Euphemus, son of Troezenus and of Ceyx, led the spearmen
of the Cicones. Pirechmes brought the Paeonians,
their crooked bows, from distant Amydon beside broad Axios,

whose fairest water spreads across the land.
Great-hearted Pylaemenes led the Paphlagonians from Eneti,
where the race of wild asses is born; from Cytorus and Sesamus,
from their houses beside the Parthenius, from Cromna,
Aegialus, and the high Erythini. Odius and Epistrophus
led the Halizonians from distant Alybe, birthplace of silver.
Chromis and Ennomus the augur led the Mysians;
but augury could not save Ennomus from black death:
swift-footed Aeacides struck him down in the river,
where Achilles was slaughtering Trojans and their allies.
Phorcys and godlike Ascanius led the Phrygians,
come from far-off Ascania, eager for battle.
Mesthles and Antiphus, sons of Talaemenes,
whom the Gygaean lake bore, led the Maionians
born beneath Tmolus. Nastes led the Carians,
barbarous-speaking men from Miletus, Mount Phthira,
the banks of Maeander, and the steep peaks of Mycale.
Amphimachus and Nastes, splendid sons of Nomion,
led them. Nastes went to war wearing gold, like a girl,
a foolishness that could not ward off his grievous death;
swift-footed Aeacides killed him in the river,
and discerning Achilles carried off his gold.
Sarpedon and blameless Glaucus led the Lycians,
come from far Lycia, from the whirling Xanthus.

Source range: Book 2. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 3

First-pass working translation

When each army had taken its place beside its leaders,
the Trojans advanced with clamor and cries, like cranes
that fly before the sky, when they have escaped winter
and measureless rain, crying over the Ocean's streams,
carrying slaughter and death to the small Pygmy men;
high in the air they bring their evil quarrel.

The Achaeans moved in silence, breathing courage,
resolved in their hearts to defend one another.

As when the South Wind pours mist over a mountain's peaks—
unwelcome to shepherds, but better than night to a thief,
whose sight reaches no farther than a stone's throw—
so a storm of dust rose beneath their feet,
and they crossed the plain swiftly.

When they had come close to one another, godlike Alexander
stood before the Trojan ranks, wearing a leopard's skin,
curved bow, and sword; he brandished two bronze-tipped spears
and challenged every Argive champion to meet him face to face.

When war-loving Menelaus saw him striding before the host,
he rejoiced as a lion rejoices when he finds a great carcass—
a horned stag or wild goat—and hunger drives him to eat it,
though swift hounds and vigorous young hunters chase him.

So Menelaus rejoiced when his godlike enemy appeared;
he thought he would punish the man who had wronged him.

At once he leapt from his chariot in his armor.

But when godlike Alexander saw him among the champions,
his heart was struck with fear, and he withdrew into his people,
avoiding death. As when a man sees a serpent in a mountain ravine
and steps backward, trembling seizes his limbs, and pallor spreads
across his cheeks, so he sank again among the proud Trojans,
afraid of Atreus' son. Hector saw him and rebuked him:

“Paris, handsome beyond measure, mad for women, deceiver—
would that you had never been born, or died unmarried!

That would be my prayer, and far better than to be a disgrace,

a reproach to others. Surely the long-haired Achaeans laugh,
 thinking you a champion because your appearance is beautiful,
 though there is no strength in your heart, no courage.
 Was it as such a man that you crossed the sea in your ships,
 gathered loyal companions, mingled with foreign people,
 and carried a beautiful woman from a distant land,
 your father's great grief, your city's, and all the people's—
 a joy to the enemy, but shame to you? Will you not stand
 before war-loving Menelaus, so that you may know the man
 whose young wife you keep? Your lyre will not help you,
 nor Aphrodite's gifts, nor your hair nor your looks,
 when you lie in the dust. The Trojans are too fearful;
 you would already wear a stone tunic for all the evil you have done.”
 Godlike Alexander answered him: “Hector, since you have rebuked me
 with justice, not beyond it—your heart is hard and tireless,
 like an axe driven through a ship's timber by a skilled man,
 adding force to the man's stroke. So your mind within your breast
 is fearless. Do not throw up against me the lovely gifts
 of golden Aphrodite: the glorious gifts the gods give
 cannot be thrown away, and no man chooses them at will.
 If you wish me to fight, sit down the other Trojans and Achaeans;
 set Menelaus and me in the midst to fight over Helen
 and all her possessions. Let the better man, the stronger,
 take the woman and the goods and lead them home;
 the rest of you shall cut a faithful covenant,
 and dwell in fertile Troy, while they return to horse-breeding Argos
 and lovely Achaea.”
 Hector rejoiced to hear this great speech. He went into the midst
 and halted the Trojan ranks, gripping his spear by the middle.
 The long-haired Achaeans bent their bows and aimed stones,
 but Agamemnon cried aloud: “Hold, Argives! Do not shoot,
 young Achaeans. Crested Hector claims he will speak.”
 They stopped fighting and fell silent. Hector spoke between them:
 “Hear me, Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans, and hear
 the word of Alexander, for whose sake this quarrel rose.
 Let the others lay their beautiful armor on the earth;
 let him and war-loving Menelaus alone fight in the midst

over Helen and all her possessions. Whoever wins and proves stronger,
 let him take all the goods and the woman home;
 the rest of us shall cut a covenant of friendship.”
 He spoke, and all were silent. Menelaus answered:
 “Hear me now as well. Most of all the pain reaches my heart.
 I think the Argives and Trojans should be separated now,
 since you have suffered much for my quarrel and Alexander’s beginning.
 Let the one for whom death and fate are made die;
 let the rest be parted quickly. Bring two lambs,
 one white and one black, for Earth and Sun, and another for Zeus.
 Bring mighty Priam, that he himself may cut the oath,
 for his sons are insolent and faithless, lest any man’s transgression
 destroy Zeus’s covenant. The minds of younger men are always shifting;
 an elder sees both before and behind, so that his counsel may be best
 for either side.”
 The Trojans and Achaeans rejoiced, hoping to end the wretched war.
 They drew back their horses, dismounted, stripped off their armor,
 and set it on the ground close together, leaving little space between.
 Hector sent two heralds toward the city to fetch lambs
 and call Priam, while Agamemnon sent Talthybius to the hollow ships
 to bring a lamb. Talthybius did not disobey the godlike king.
 Iris then came as a messenger to white-armed Helen,
 in the likeness of the wife of Antenor’s son, Helicaon,
 Laodice, fairest of Priam’s daughters. She found Helen
 in the chamber, weaving a great double-folded purple cloth,
 and embroidering upon it the many labors of the horse-taming
 Trojans and bronze-clad Achaeans—the sufferings they endured
 for her at the hands of Ares. Standing near, swift-footed Iris said:
 “Come, dear bride, and see the wondrous deeds of the horse-taming
 Trojans and bronze-clad Achaeans, those who once carried
 tearful Ares against one another in the hateful field,
 greedy for war. Now they sit in silence, leaning on their shields;
 their long spears stand planted beside them. Alexander and
 war-loving Menelaus will fight over you with their long spears;
 the victor will call you beloved wife.”
 So the goddess stirred in Helen’s heart a sweet desire
 for her former husband, her city, and her parents. At once,

veiling herself in bright white linen, she left the chamber,
shedding tender tears; she was not alone, for two attendants
followed her, Aethra, daughter of Pittheus, and ox-eyed Clymene.
Soon they reached the Scaean Gates.

Around Priam sat Panthous, Thymoetes, Lampus, Clytius,
Hicetaon, an offshoot of Ares, Ucalegon, and wise Antenor—
the city's elders, long since released from war by age,
but excellent speakers, like cicadas in the forest,
perched in trees and sending out their lily-clear voices.
Such were the Trojan leaders seated on the tower.

When they saw Helen coming onto the wall, they murmured softly:

"There is no blame if Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans
suffer long for such a woman. Terribly she resembles
an immortal goddess. Yet even so, let her return in the ships;
let her not remain here as a grief to us and our children."

Priam called Helen by name: "Come here, dear child, sit before me,
so that you may show me your former husband, your kinsmen, and friends.
You are not to blame in my eyes; the gods are to blame,
who brought this tearful war upon the Achaeans. Name for me this man,
that enormous Achaean, so strong and tall. There are others taller
in head, but I have never seen one so stately; he looks like a king."

Helen, divine among women, answered: "You are worthy of honor
and dreadful to me, dear father-in-law. Would that evil death
had pleased me when I followed your son here, leaving my chamber,
my kin, my darling child, and my beloved companions. It did not;
therefore I waste away in tears. I will tell you whom you ask about.

That is Atreus' son, wide-ruling Agamemnon, both a good king
and a strong spearman; once, if ever, he was my brother-in-law."

The old man admired him: "Happy Atreus' son, born under good fate,
blessed! Many sons of the Achaeans obey you. Once I entered
vine-rich Phrygia and saw the greatest number of Phrygian men,
with their dappled horses, the armies of Otreus and godlike Mygdon,
camped beside the banks of Sangarius. I too was numbered among
their allies, on the day the man-like Amazons came; but even they
were not as many as the bright-eyed Achaeans."

Then the old man saw Odysseus: "Tell me of this man, dear child.
He is shorter in head than Atreus' son, but broader in shoulders

and chest. His armor lies on the earth, while he moves through the ranks like a ram among a great flock of white sheep.”

Helen, daughter of Zeus, answered: “That is Laertes’ son, many-counseled Odysseus, raised in rocky Ithaca and skilled in every kind of trick and close-woven counsel.”

Wise Antenor replied: “Woman, your word is wholly true.

Once divine Odysseus came here with war-loving Menelaus as your embassy. I welcomed them in my house and entertained them; I learned the nature and the close counsel of both. When they stood among the gathered Trojans, Menelaus surpassed him in broad shoulders; but when both sat, Odysseus was the more majestic. When they wove speeches and plans before all, Menelaus spoke swiftly, few words, but very clear, since he was not a man of many words and was younger. When many-counseled Odysseus rose, he stood with eyes fixed on the ground, holding the scepter neither forward nor backward, but stiffly, like a man ignorant of the world—you might have called him angry and foolish. Yet when he sent his great voice from his chest, and words like winter snow, no mortal could contend with Odysseus; we no longer marveled at his appearance.”

The old man saw Ajax and asked: “Who is that other Achaeon, so strong and tall, the foremost of the Argives in head and broad shoulders?”

Helen, trailing her robe, answered: “That is towering Ajax, the bulwark of the Achaeans. On the other side stands Idomeneus among the Cretans, like a god; around him gather the Cretan leaders. Often war-loving Menelaus welcomed him in our house when he came from Crete. I see all the other bright-eyed Achaeans, whom I could recognize and name, but I cannot see the two commanders of the people, Castor, breaker of horses, and Polydeuces, good with the fists, my own brothers, born from the same mother as I. Either they did not come with the lovely Lacedaemonian army, or they came here in the ships, but now will not enter the battle, fearing the shame and many reproaches that are mine.”

So she spoke, but the life-giving earth already held them in Lacedaemon, in their dear native land.

At last Idaeus brought the victims from the city. Priam climbed down, and Agamemnon met him between the lines. The heralds gathered the oath-gifts of the gods; they mixed the wine in the bowl

and poured water over the hands of the kings. Agamemnon drew the knife that hung beside his great sword and cut hairs from the lambs' heads; Trojan and Achaean heralds distributed them to the best men. Atreus' son raised his hands and prayed:

"Father Zeus, most glorious and greatest, lord of Ida; Sun, who see and hear all things; rivers and earth; and you beneath, who punish the dead when anyone swears falsely—be witnesses, guard this faithful oath. If Alexander kills Menelaus, let him keep Helen and all her possessions, and let us return in our seafaring ships. If golden-haired Menelaus kills Alexander, let the Trojans return Helen and all her possessions, and pay the Argives the honor that is due, an honor remembered among men yet to come. If Priam and Priam's sons refuse to pay me the honor owed when Alexander has fallen, then I will remain here and fight on for compensation until I reach the war's end."

He cut the lambs' throats with pitiless bronze, and laid them on the earth, gasping as the metal took their strength. They drew wine from the bowl into cups and poured it out, praying to the everlasting gods. Someone among Trojans and Achaeans said:

"Father Zeus, greatest and most glorious, and all you other gods—whichever side first harms this oath, may their brains spill upon the ground as this wine does, their own and their children's; may their wives be taken by others."

So they spoke, but Cronus' son did not yet fulfill the prayer. Dardanian Priam addressed them: "Hear me, Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans. I am going back to windy Ilium; I cannot bear with my own eyes to see my dear son fight war-loving Menelaus. Zeus and the other immortals know which of the two has been assigned the end of death."

He set the lambs in the chariot, mounted, and drew the reins back; Antenor climbed beside him, and they drove toward Ilium. Hector, Priam's son, and brilliant Odysseus first measured the ground. Then they shook lots in a bronze-studded helmet to decide who should cast his bronze spear first. The people prayed, raising their hands to the gods:

"Father Zeus, lord of Ida, most glorious and greatest, grant that the one who brought these deeds upon both peoples may die and enter the house of Hades, while friendship and faithful oaths

become ours.”

Hector shook the helmet and looked back; Paris's lot leapt out first.
The men sat in their ranks where each man's horses and bright armor lay.
Godlike Alexander, husband of fair-haired Helen, put on his armor:
first the beautiful greaves with silver ankle-clasps;
then the breastplate of his brother Lycaon, fitted to his body;
around his shoulders he hung the bronze sword with silver studs,
then the great, heavy shield. On his head he set the well-made horsehair
helmet, its crest nodding terribly above him, and took the strong spear
that fitted his palm. Menelaus armed himself in the same way.
They came from either side into the space between the armies,
looking terribly at one another; wonder seized the Trojans and Achaeans.
They stood close, measuring the ground, shaking their spears in anger.
Paris cast his long-shadowed spear first, striking Atreus' son's shield,
but the bronze did not break through; its point bent in the strong shield.
Menelaus, son of Atreus, prayed and cast his own:

“Father Zeus, grant that I may punish godlike Alexander,
who first wronged me; subdue him beneath my hands,
so that a man yet unborn may tremble to do evil to a host,
to one who offers friendship as a guest-friend.”

He hurled the long-shadowed spear. It struck Priam's son's shield,
passed through the shining metal, and lodged in the elaborate corselet;
it tore the tunic beside his flank, but Paris bent aside and escaped
the black Fates. Atreus' son drew his silver-studded sword,
raised it, and struck the helmet's crest. Around the helmet
the blade broke into three and four pieces and fell from his hand.
He groaned and looked into the broad sky:

“Father Zeus, no god is more destructive than you. I thought
I would punish Alexander for his evil, but now the sword has shattered
in my hands, and the spear flew uselessly from my palm.”

He sprang forward, seized the horsehair of Paris's helmet,
and dragged him around toward the well-greaved Achaeans.
The embroidered chin-strap beneath his throat strangled him,
and he would have dragged him away and won immeasurable glory,
but Aphrodite, Zeus's daughter, saw it and broke the strap
with the force of an ox slaughtered for sacrifice. The empty helmet
followed Menelaus' strong hand. The hero whirled it and threw it

among the well-greaved Achaeans; his loyal companions carried it off. Menelaus rushed again, eager to kill him with bronze, but Aphrodite, easily as a goddess, snatched Paris away, wrapped him in dense mist, and set him down in his fragrant, incense-filled chamber.

Aphrodite went again to call white-armed Helen. She found her on the high tower, surrounded by many Trojan women. Taking the form of an old woman, a spinner who had lived beside Helen in Lacedaemon and whom she loved, the goddess shook her fragrant robe and spoke: “Come here. Alexander calls you home. He lies in his chamber, on the turned bed, shining in beauty and dress. You would not think he had come from fighting a man, but from a dance, or from sitting down after the dance.”

The goddess stirred Helen’s heart. When Helen saw her lovely throat, desiring breast, and flashing eyes, she marveled and named her: “Strange woman, why do you long to deceive me? Will you carry me farther, to one of the well-inhabited cities—Phrygia or lovely Maeonia—if there is another mortal man dear to you there? Menelaus has defeated godlike Alexander and wants to lead hateful me home. Is that why you stand here, weaving deceit? Go sit beside him yourself; leave the gods’ road, and do not turn your feet toward Olympus again. Worry over him always, until he makes you his wife—or his slave. I will not go there; it would be shameful to tend his bed. Every Trojan woman would reproach me; I carry unnumbered griefs within my heart.”

Golden Aphrodite answered in anger: “Do not provoke me, wretched woman, lest I abandon you in my anger. I will make you hated as terribly as I have loved you, and set hateful enmity between Trojans and Danaans; you will perish in an evil fate.”

Helen, daughter of Zeus, was afraid. She went silently, veiled in bright linen, unseen by all the Trojan women, and the goddess led her. When they reached Alexander’s beautiful house, the attendants turned quickly to work; Helen went into the high-roofed chamber. Smiling Aphrodite brought a chair and set it opposite Alexander. Helen sat, turned her eyes away, and rebuked her husband:

“You have come from war. Would that you had perished there, conquered by the strong man who was once my husband! You boasted before that you were better than war-loving Menelaus in strength, hands, and spear. Go now and challenge him again;

but I tell you: stop fighting him face to face, foolishly,
lest soon his spear bring you down.”

Paris answered: “Do not wound my heart with harsh reproaches.

Menelaus defeated me with Athena beside him; I will defeat him another time,
for we have gods with us. Come, let us turn to love and lie together.

Never before has desire so enveloped my mind—not even when I first
carried you away from lovely Lacedaemon in seafaring ships,
and joined with you in love and bed on Cranae’s island.

So now I love you, and sweet longing takes hold of me.”

He went first to the bed, and his wife followed. They slept in the bed’s
perforated frame, while Atreus’ son prowled through the host like a wild beast,
searching for Alexander; no Trojan or famous ally could point him out.

No one hid him from love—he was hateful to them all,
as hateful as black death. Agamemnon called across the ranks:

“Hear me, Trojans, Dardanians, and allies: victory plainly belongs
to war-loving Menelaus. Give up Argive Helen and the possessions with her,
and pay the honor that is due, an honor that will remain among men to come.”

So Atreus’ son spoke, and the other Achaeans applauded him.

Source range: Book 3. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 4

First-pass working translation

The gods sat beside Zeus, speaking in council on the golden floor;
among them royal Hebe poured nectar, and they received it in golden cups,
looking toward Priam's city. The son of Cronus tried to provoke Hera,
speaking with cutting words: "Two goddesses have aided Menelaus—
Argive Hera and Athena of Alalcomenae. They sit apart and rejoice,
but smiling Aphrodite always stands close to him and wards off the Fates;
even now she saved him when he thought he would die. Yet the victory
belongs to war-loving Menelaus. Let us consider what shall be done:
shall we stir dreadful war again, or place friendship between both peoples?
If this were pleasing to all, Priam's city might still be inhabited,
and Menelaus might lead Argive Helen home."

Athena and Hera muttered; seated close together, they planned evil for Troy.
Athena was silent, angry with her father, and fierce resentment held her.
Hera could not contain her anger: "Most terrible son of Cronus,
what have you said? Do you want to make my labor fruitless,
the sweat I spent in toil, while my horses were worn out gathering
the people for Priam and his sons? Do it—but none of the other gods
will praise you."

Cloud-gathering Zeus answered in deep displeasure: "Strange woman,
what have Priam and his sons done to you, that you rage without rest
to destroy well-built Ilium? If you could enter through the gates
and walls and devour Priam, his sons, and the other Trojans raw,
then your anger might be healed. Do as you wish; let this quarrel
between us not become a great dispute later. I say this also:
when I desire to destroy a city where your beloved people live,
do not delay my anger, but let me act. For I gave way to you,
though unwillingly; of all the cities beneath the sun and starry sky,
holy Ilium, Priam, and his well-speared people were most dear to me.
Never did my altar lack its equal feast, libation, or savor of sacrifice;
that honor was our portion."

Ox-eyed Hera replied: "Three cities are most dear to me—Argos,
Sparta, and broad-wayed Mycenae. Destroy them when they anger you;
I will not stand before you or begrudge it. But my labor must not be

made fruitless. I too am a goddess, born from the same source as you; Cronus of crooked counsel bore me eldest, and I am called your wife, while you rule among all the immortals. Let us yield to one another, you to me and I to you; the other gods will follow. Now command Athena to go quickly into the grievous battle of Trojans and Achaeans, and see whether the Trojans will first harm the illustrious Achaeans, in violation of the oaths.”

Her father and the father of gods did not disobey. He spoke winged words to Athena: “Go quickly among Trojans and Achaeans. See whether the Trojans will first harm the illustrious Achaeans in violation of the oaths.”

So he urged Athena, already eager; she shot down from Olympus’ peaks, like the bright star that Cronus’ son sends as a sign to sailors or a great army, from which many sparks leap. In its likeness Pallas Athena rushed to earth and leapt into the midst; wonder seized the horse-taming Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans. Each man said to the one beside him: “Will dreadful war rise again, or will Zeus establish friendship between them?”

Athena entered the Trojan crowd in the likeness of Laodocus, son of Antenor, a strong spearman, seeking godlike Pandarus.

She found Lycaon’s blameless, powerful son standing among the dense ranks of shield-bearing men who had followed him from the streams of Aesepus.

Standing near, she spoke: “Would you obey me, Lycaon’s son?

Would you dare shoot a swift arrow at Menelaus? You would win favor and glory from all the Trojans, above all from King Alexander.

He would be the first to give you shining gifts if he saw Menelaus, son of Atreus, struck by your arrow and climbing onto the grievous pyre.

Shoot glorious Menelaus; vow to Apollo, famous archer of Lycia, that when you return to sacred Zeleia you will sacrifice a splendid hecatomb of first-born lambs.”

The goddess persuaded the foolish man. He took down his polished bow, made from the horns of a wild goat that he himself had struck beneath the breast as it sprang from rock; the animal fell backward upon the stone.

Its horns grew sixteen palms; a horn-worker joined and polished them, and set a golden tip upon them. Pandarus laid the bow carefully, and his excellent companions held their shields before him, lest the warlike sons of the Achaeans leap forward before Menelaus was struck.

He opened the lid of his quiver and drew an arrow not yet shot, the source of black pain. Quickly he fitted the bitter arrow to the string,

and vowed again to Apollo. He drew together the notch and ox-hide string; the great bow bent in a circle, twanged, the string cried loudly, and the sharp arrow leapt through the host eager to fly.

Yet the blessed gods had not forgotten you, Menelaus. First Athena, the spoil-taking daughter of Zeus, stood before you and turned away the deadly arrow, as a mother brushes a fly from her child asleep. She guided it to the place where the golden clasps of the belt held fast, where the double breastplate met. The bitter arrow struck the fitted belt, passed through the decorated belt and elaborate corselet, and pierced the guard that protected the skin from spears—the guard that saved him most, though the arrow passed beyond it and grazed his flesh. Dark blood immediately ran from the wound. As a Maeonian or Carian woman stains ivory with purple to adorn a horse's cheek—kept in a chamber, desired by many riders, an ornament and glory for horse and charioteer—so your well-formed thighs and beautiful legs, Menelaus, were stained with blood. When Agamemnon saw the dark blood running from the wound, he trembled; war-loving Menelaus trembled too, but when he saw the sinew and arrow-barbs outside, his heart gathered itself again. Agamemnon groaned heavily, holding Menelaus' hand, while his companions lamented:

“Dear brother, I cut the oath that set you alone before the Achaeans to fight the Trojans, and the Trojans have struck you and trampled the faithful oath. Yet the oath, the blood of lambs, the unmixed libations, and the right hands we trusted will not be in vain. Even if Olympus' lord does not fulfill it at once, he will fulfill it later, and they will pay dearly, with their heads, wives, and children. I know this in my heart: the day will come when holy Ilium, Priam, and Priam's well-speared people are destroyed, when Zeus himself, dwelling in the upper air, shakes his dark aegis over them in anger at this deceit. These things will not fail; but my grief for you, Menelaus, will be terrible if you die and fulfill the appointed end of life.”

Menelaus answered: “Take heart, and do not alarm the army. The wound is not deadly; the arrow's sharp point did not remain, and the belt and corselet held it back.”

Agamemnon summoned Talthybius: “Call Machaon, son of Asclepius, the blameless healer, to see whether he can heal Menelaus.”

Talthybius went through the ranks and found Machaon, a good physician, standing among the shield-bearing men who had followed him from Tricca.

He brought him before Menelaus. Machaon cut away the shining belt, the corselet, and the guard; he drew the clotted blood from the wound and laid soothing medicines upon it—medicines given by Cheiron to his father, Asclepius, long ago.

When the Trojans' ranks came on again, no one could have seen divine Agamemnon sleeping, shrinking, or refusing the fight; he hurried into the battle that gives men glory. He left his horses and bronze-decorated chariot apart, in the care of Eurymedon, son of Ptolemy's son Peiraeus, charging him to bring them near when weariness seized his limbs after commanding so many.

On foot he moved among the ranks. Whoever he saw eager, he stood beside and encouraged:

"Argives, do not let your fierce courage slacken. Father Zeus will not help a lie; those who first harmed the oath will have their tender flesh eaten by vultures, while we will carry their wives and little children aboard the ships when we take the city."

But those he saw shrinking from the hateful war he rebuked:

"Argives, soft with arrows, objects of shame—do you not respect yourselves? Why stand amazed like fawns that, after running over a great plain, stand still, their courage gone? Will you wait for the Trojans to come close to the ships drawn stern-first beside the gray sea, to see whether Cronus' son will extend his hand over you?"

So he went through the ranks, and came among the Cretans.

They armed around wise Idomeneus: Idomeneus stood in the front ranks, like a boar in strength, while Meriones urged the rearward lines.

Agamemnon rejoiced to see them and spoke gently to Idomeneus:

"Idomeneus, I honor you above the swift Achaeans, in war, in every other work, and at the feast, when the best of the Argives mix the bright wine in the bowl. Though the other long-haired Achaeans drink their measured portion, your cup always stands full, as mine does, to drink whenever your heart commands. Rise to war as you have always claimed to be."

The Cretan leader answered: "Atreus' son, I will remain your faithful companion, as I first promised and nodded. Urge the other long-haired Achaeans on, so that we may fight at once; the Trojans have spilled the oaths, and death and grief will follow them, since they first damaged the covenant."

Agamemnon passed on gladly and came to the two Ajaxes.
 They armed themselves, and a dense cloud of footmen followed.
 As when a goatherd sees from a watchpoint a cloud coming over the sea
 under the West Wind's sound—black as pitch from far away,
 bringing a mighty storm, and he shudders and drives the sheep
 into a cave—so the dark, shield-and-spear-bristling ranks moved
 with the divinely reared young men beside the Ajaxes into war.
 Agamemnon rejoiced and addressed them: "Ajaxes, leaders of the Argives,
 you need no urging; I do not command you. You yourselves drive
 your people to fight with all their strength. Would that Zeus,
 Athena, and Apollo gave every heart such courage! Then Priam's city
 would soon bow to our hands, taken and sacked."
 He left them and found Nestor, the clear-voiced speaker of the Pylians,
 arranging and urging his companions to fight: great Pelagon, Alastor,
 Chromius, Haimon, lord Bias, and shepherd of the people. He placed
 the horsemen first with horses and chariots, and many excellent footmen
 behind them as a wall of war; the cowards he drove into the middle,
 so that even unwilling men would fight under compulsion.
 To the horsemen he first gave orders: keep your horses in check,
 do not let them plunge into the crowd, do not trust in horsemanship
 and courage to rush alone before the others or fall back—your line
 will be weaker. When a man reaches another chariot from his own,
 let him reach with his spear; thus the older warriors destroyed cities
 and walls, holding this thought and courage in their breasts.
 Agamemnon rejoiced to see the old man: "Elder, would that your knees
 followed the spirit in your dear breast and your strength remained firm!
 But age wears you down. Would that another man had your years,
 and you could belong among the younger."
 Gerenian horseman Nestor replied: "Atreus' son, I too would wish
 to be as I was when I killed godlike Ereuthalion. But the gods
 do not give everything to men at once. If I were young then,
 or if strength were still firm in my limbs, I would stand
 among the horsemen and lead them. Now you should urge the young men;
 I will follow with my counsel, and they will obey as is right."
 The son of Atreus went on, rejoicing in his heart. He found
 Peteus' son Menestheus standing, and around him the Athenians,
 masters of the war-cry. Nearby stood many-counseled Odysseus,

and around him the unshaken ranks of the Cephallenians.

Their people had not yet heard the battle-cry; their newly gathered phalanxes waited, watching for another Trojan tower to advance and begin the fight. Agamemnon rebuked them:

“Son of Peteus, Zeus-nourished king, clever in evil tricks, why shrink back and wait for others? You should stand among the first, meet the burning encounter, and hear my feasts announced first, when we prepare a feast for the elders. There you gladly eat roasted meat and drink honey-sweet wine as long as you wish; now you would gladly see ten Achaean towers fighting before you.” Many-counseled Odysseus looked darkly at him: “Atreus’ son, what word escaped the fence of your teeth? How can you say we slacken war when we stir sharp Ares against the horse-taming Trojans? You will see, if you wish, and if it matters to you, Telemachus’ dear father mingling with the front ranks of the horse-taming Trojans. Your words are wind.”

Agamemnon smiled, knowing the man was angry, and took back his speech: “God-born son of Laertes, many in counsel, I do not rebuke or command you. I know your heart thinks gentle plans, the same plans I do. Let those words be healed later, if any harm was spoken; may the gods make all of it wind.” He left them and found Tydeus’ high-hearted son Diomedes standing among his horses and close-fitted chariots, with Sthenelus beside him, son of Capaneus. Agamemnon rebuked him:

“Son of Tydeus, why shrink back, why watch the bridges of battle? It was not dear to Tydeus to shrink so, but to fight far before his friends, as those who saw him labor said. I never met him, but so they tell me. He entered Mycenae as a guest with godlike Polynices, gathering a people, when they campaigned against the sacred walls of seven-gated Thebes. They begged us for famous allies, and we agreed; but Zeus turned us back, showing signs against our will. When they had gone and reached deep-reeded Asopus, the Achaeans sent Tydeus as messenger. He went and found many Cadmeans feasting in the house of mighty Eteocles. Though a guest and alone among many Cadmeans, horseman Tydeus was not afraid; he challenged them to contests and won them all easily—for Athena helped him.

The angry Cadmeans set an ambush on his return, fifty young men led by two: Maeon, like an immortal, and Polyphontes, son of Autophonus.

Tydeus gave them all a shameful death, sending Maeon home alone,

because he trusted the gods' signs. Such was Tydeus, the Aetolian;
 but he fathered a son worse than himself in war, though better in council."
 Strong Diomedes said nothing, ashamed before the honored king.
 But Sthenelus, glorious son of Capaneus, answered: "Son of Atreus,
 do not lie when you know the truth. We boast that we are better than our fathers.
 We took seven-gated Thebes with fewer men, bringing an army beneath its wall,
 trusting the gods' signs and Zeus's help; our fathers perished through their folly.
 Do not place our fathers' honor on the same scale as ours."
 Diomedes looked beneath his brows: "Friend, sit silent and obey my word.
 I do not resent Agamemnon, shepherd of the people, for urging the well-greaved
 Achaeans to fight. Glory will follow him if the Achaeans sack the Trojans
 and take sacred Ilium; great grief will follow him if the Achaeans are destroyed.
 Come, then, let us remember our fierce courage."
 He leapt from his chariot in his armor; the bronze rang terribly on the king's
 chest, and fear would have seized even the steadfast.
 When the two hosts came together, the ranks advanced without pause.
 Each commander gave orders, but the rest moved silently; you would not think
 so many people possessed voices, for they feared their officers' commands,
 while the variegated armor flashed as they marched.
 The Trojans raised a cry like sheep in the courtyard of a rich man,
 thousands standing to be milked and bleating without cease
 as they hear the lambs' voices. So a confused clamor rose through the Trojan host;
 their sound was not one voice or one language, but a mixture of tongues,
 men called from many lands. Ares stirred some, bright-eyed Athena others,
 and Deimos, Phobos, and unwearied Strife—the sister and companion
 of man-slaying Ares. At first Strife's head is small, but soon she plants it
 in heaven while her feet walk upon the earth; she too then cast mutual hatred
 among them, increasing the groan of men as she moved through the ranks.
 When they reached one place, hide struck hide, spears and the strength
 of bronze-clad men struck together, and bossed shields crashed upon shields.
 A great tumult rose: there were groans and shouts of triumph from men
 killing and being killed, and the ground ran with blood.
 As when two winter torrents rushing down the mountains pour their mighty
 waters together into a hollow ravine from great springs, and a shepherd
 hears their thunder far away in the hills, so from the armies' meeting
 came clamor and pain.
 Antilochus was first to kill a Trojan champion, Echeplus,

son of Thalysius. He struck the horsehair crest of his helmet first; the bronze point fixed in his forehead and passed through the bone, and darkness covered his eyes. He fell like a tower in fierce battle. Elephenor, son of Chalcodon and great-hearted leader of the Abantes, seized the fallen man by the feet and dragged him out of the missiles, eager to strip his armor; but his effort was brief. Agenor saw him, and as he bent beside the shield, Agenor stabbed the ribs exposed beneath it with his bronze spear and loosed his limbs. So Elephenor's spirit left him, and the Trojans and Achaeans fought terribly over his body, rushing together like wolves, while man struck man.

Telamonian Ajax struck Simoeisus, the flourishing son of Anthemion, whom his mother bore beside the banks of Simoeis as she came down from Ida with her parents to see the flocks. Therefore they named him Simoeisus. He never repaid his dear parents for their upbringing; his life was short, and Ajax's great-hearted spear brought him down. Ajax struck him in the chest, beside the right nipple; the bronze spear came out through the shoulder, and he fell in the dust like a smooth poplar grown in a broad wet meadow, its branches high at the crown, cut by a chariot-builder with shining iron to bend it into a beautiful chariot-rim, and left lying beside the river.

Antiphus, Priam's son, cast his sharp spear at Ajax but missed, and struck Leucus, Odysseus' excellent companion, as he dragged a corpse aside; the dead man fell from his hands and Leucus fell over him.

Odysseus grew fiercely angry at his companion's death. Helmeted in bright bronze, he advanced through the champions, stood near, and cast his shining spear.

The Trojans shrank from him, but his shot was not in vain: he struck Democoon, Priam's bastard son, who had come from Abydos beside the swift horses.

Odysseus struck him at the temple; the bronze point passed through the other side, darkness covered his eyes, and his armor clattered as he fell.

The champions and radiant Hector withdrew; the Argives gave a great shout, dragged away the dead, and advanced much farther. Apollo, looking down from Pergamos,

was angered and called to the Trojans: "Rise, horse-taming Trojans; do not yield to the Achaeans. Their flesh is not stone or iron, able to withstand the bronze that cuts the flesh. Nor does Achilles, son of fair-haired Thetis, fight; he nurses his heart-paining anger beside the ships."

The terrible god spoke from the city, while Athena, glorious daughter of Zeus,

stirred the Achaeans wherever she saw them slacken. There Fate caught Diores,
son of Amarynceus: a jagged stone struck him beside the ankle,
crushing the tendons and bones of his right leg. Peirous, son of Imbrasmus,
leader of the Thracians who came from Aenus, had thrown it.
Diores fell backward in the dust, stretching both hands to his companions,
breathing out his spirit. Peirous, who had struck him, rushed forward;
Thoas the Aetolian stabbed him above the nipple, and the bronze lodged in his lung.
Thoas came close, pulled the great spear from his chest, drew his sharp sword,
and struck his belly, taking away his life. He could not strip the armor:
the Thracians with long spears stood around him, and though he was great,
strong, and splendid, they drove Thoas back. So the two leaders lay stretched
beside each other in the dust, one leader of Thracians, one of bronze-clad Epeans,
and many others were killed around them.
Then no man could blame a person for moving through the middle of battle,
still unstruck and unwounded by sharp bronze, if Pallas Athena took him by the hand
and turned the missiles aside; for that day many Trojans and Achaeans lay face-down
in the dust beside one another.

Source range: Book 4. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 5

First-pass working translation

Then Pallas Athena gave courage and strength to Tydeus' son Diomedes,
so that he might be conspicuous among the Argives and win good fame.
She kindled from his helmet and shield an unwearied fire,
like the star of autumn that shines most brightly after bathing in Ocean;
such a fire she lit from his head and shoulders and drove him into the midst,
where the greatest number were pressed together.
There was among the Trojans a rich and blameless man, Dares,
priest of Hephaestus. He had two sons, Phegeus and Idaios,
skilled in every art of war. They drove directly against Diomedes—
one from the chariot, the other on foot. When they came near,
Phegeus cast his long-shadowed spear first; its point passed over
Diomedes' left shoulder and missed him. The son of Tydeus cast next,
and his spear did not fly vainly: it struck Phegeus in the chest
between the nipples and thrust him from his horses. Idaios sprang away,
leaving the beautiful chariot; he could not endure to stand over his brother,
and would not have escaped the black Fate himself, but Hephaestus saved him,
covering him in night, that the old priest might not be left wholly childless.
Tydeus' son drove the horses to his companions to lead them to the hollow ships.
When the great-hearted Trojans saw one son fleeing and the other killed
beside the chariot, their hearts were all shaken. Bright-eyed Athena took Ares
by the hand and spoke: "Ares, Ares, destroyer of mortals, wall-breaker,
let us leave Trojans and Achaeans to fight, and withdraw, avoiding Zeus's anger;
whichever side he grants glory, let that side have it." So she led fierce Ares
from the battle and seated him beside the sandy Scamander. The Danaans turned
the Trojans back, and each commander killed a man. First Agamemnon struck down
great Odios, leader of the Halizonians, driving his spear between his shoulders
as he turned; the point passed through his chest, and his armor clattered.
Idomeneus killed Phaestus, son of Maeon's son Borus, who had come from deep-soiled
Tarne; Idomeneus struck him in the right shoulder as he mounted his horses,
and hateful darkness took him. His attendants stripped his armor.
Menelaus killed Scamandrius, son of Strophius, a skilled hunter whom Artemis
herself had taught to strike every wild creature the forest raises; but Artemis,
mistress of the bow, did not help him then. Menelaus struck him in the back

as he fled, and the spear passed between his shoulders through the chest. Meriones killed Phereclus, son of Tecton's son Harmonides, who knew how to make all intricate things with his hands, beloved of Athena; he had built for Alexander the equal ships that brought evil on Troy and on Paris, since he did not know the gods' decrees. Meriones pursued and struck his right buttock; the point passed through beneath the bone and came out at the bladder. He fell on his knees, crying out, and death covered him.

Meges killed Pedaeus, Antenor's bastard son, whom noble Theano had raised as tenderly as her own children for her husband's sake. Phyleus' famous son came close and struck him at the nape; the sharp spear passed under the tongue between the teeth, and the cold bronze took his spirit.

Eurypylus, son of Euaemon, killed Hypsenor, the godlike son of Dolopion, priest of Scamander, honored among the people like a god. As Hypsenor fled, Eurypylus overtook him and cut away his heavy arm at the shoulder; the bloodied hand fell on the plain, and purple death seized him.

So they labored through the strong battle. You could not have recognized whether Diomedes stood among Trojans or Achaeans: he swept over the plain like a winter torrent that quickly breaks bridges; neither bridges nor fences of flowering orchards restrain it when Zeus' rain descends in force, and many fine works of young men fall before it. So beneath Diomedes' hands the Trojan ranks were scattered, and even their many numbers could not stand. When Lycaon's glorious son saw him rushing and driving the ranks before him, he bent his curved bow at once and struck Diomedes in the right shoulder, where the corselet swelled; the bitter arrow passed through and blood stained his armor. Pandarus cried aloud: "Rise, great-hearted Trojans, drivers of horses! The best of the Achaeans is wounded; surely he will not long endure the strong arrow, if the son of Zeus truly sent me from Lycia."

But the swift arrow did not subdue Diomedes. He withdrew before his horses and chariot, and spoke to Sthenelus, son of Capaneus: "Rise, dear friend, leap from the chariot and draw the bitter arrow from my shoulder."

Sthenelus sprang down and pulled the arrow straight through; blood spurted through the twisted tunic. Then Diomedes prayed: "Hear me, daughter of Zeus who bears the aegis, unwearied one.

If ever you stood kindly beside my father in fierce war,
now be kind to me, Athena. Grant me to kill the man who struck me,
who shot first and boasts that I shall not see the sun's bright light long."
He prayed, and Pallas Athena heard. She made his limbs light,

his hands and feet above; standing near, she spoke winged words:
 “Now take heart, Diomedes, and fight the Trojans. I have set in your breast
 your father’s courage, the fearless force Tydeus carried behind his shield.
 I have taken the mist from your eyes that lay there before,
 so that you may recognize god and man. If any god comes here to test you,
 do not fight the other immortals face to face; but if Aphrodite,
 daughter of Zeus, enters battle, wound her with sharp bronze.”
 So bright-eyed Athena withdrew. Diomedes returned to the front ranks,
 already eager to fight the Trojans; now his courage was threefold,
 as when a shepherd wounds a lion leaping over the sheepfold but cannot tame it,
 and the wounded beast’s strength rises while the shepherd will not defend it—
 the sheep huddle together, and the lion leaps from the deep fold.
 So the mighty son of Tydeus entered the Trojans’ midst.
 He killed Astynous, shepherd of the people, with bronze above the nipple,
 and Hypeiron with his great sword at the collarbone, separating shoulder,
 neck, and back. He left them and pursued Abas and Polyidus,
 sons of old Eurydamas, a dream-reader who did not interpret their returning dream;
 strong Diomedes stripped them of their arms. Then he went against Xanthus and
 Thoon,
 both beloved sons of Phaenops, whom grievous old age wore down;
 he had no other son to leave his possessions. Diomedes killed both,
 leaving their father grief and bitter mourning, since he would not receive them alive;
 their relatives divided the inheritance.
 Then he seized two sons of Priam, Echemmon and Chromius, in one chariot.
 As a lion springs among cattle and breaks the neck of a calf or heifer,
 so Tydeus’ son hurled both unwilling from their horses and stripped their armor;
 he gave the horses to his companions to drive to the ships.
 When Aeneas saw Diomedes scattering the ranks, he crossed the battle
 seeking Pandarus. He found Lycaon’s son among the dense shield-wall
 of men who had followed him from Aesepus. Aeneas asked where his bow was,
 and urged him to shoot the man who had done such harm to Troy.
 Pandarus answered that he recognized Diomedes by shield, helmet, and horses,
 but suspected a god stood near him: the arrow he had already shot through
 Diomedes’ shoulder had not subdued him. His own horses and chariot were absent;
 at home eleven new chariots stood in Lycaon’s house, but he had come on foot,
 trusting in a bow that had already drawn blood from Tydeus’ son and Atreus’ son.
 If he returned to his native land, wife, and high-roofed house, he swore

he would break the bow in bright fire, for it had followed him uselessly.
 Aeneas told him that nothing would change until they went against Diomedes
 together. He offered his chariot and praised its Trojan horses, which knew
 how to chase and flee. Pandarus answered that Aeneas should keep the reins:
 the horses knew his voice, while Pandarus would meet the attack with his spear.
 They mounted the variegated chariot and drove at Diomedes.
 Sthenelus saw them and warned Diomedes: "Two powerful men come against you—
 Pandarus, the famous bowman, and Aeneas, son of Anchises, whose mother is
 Aphrodite.
 Let us withdraw upon the horses, lest you lose your life."
 Diomedes replied that he would not flee or crouch, for his strength remained;
 Pallas Athena forbade his fear. He ordered Sthenelus to hold their horses,
 and, if Athena granted him both deaths, to seize Aeneas' horses and drive them
 from the Trojans. They descended from the chariot and rushed at one another.
 Pandarus cast his long-shadowed spear at Diomedes' shield; the bronze passed
 through and touched the corselet. He shouted that Diomedes was wounded through
 the flank and would not long endure. Diomedes answered that Pandarus had missed,
 and that neither man would stop before one fell and satisfied Ares.
 Athena guided his spear beside Pandarus' eye; it broke his white teeth,
 cut the back of his tongue, and passed beneath his chin. He fell from the chariot,
 his bright armor clattering, while his swift horses ran loose.
 Aeneas leapt down with shield and long spear, moving around the body like a lion,
 eager to kill whoever approached. Diomedes lifted a stone, a great feat for two
 men of the present age, but swung and hurled it alone. It struck Aeneas at the hip,
 crushed the socket, and tore both tendons. Aeneas fell to his knees and propped
 himself with his broad hand; black night covered his eyes.
 Aphrodite, his mother, saw him and cast her white arms around her son,
 spreading a fold of her shining robe before him as a shield against the arrows.
 She carried him from the war. Sthenelus remembered Diomedes' command, held back
 their own horses, seized Aeneas' fine-maned horses, and drove them toward the ships,
 giving them to Deipylus, his trusted companion. Then he mounted his own horses
 and pursued Diomedes.
 Diomedes charged Aphrodite, knowing that she was a powerless goddess,
 not Athena or Enyo, who rule the wars of men. When he reached her,
 he wounded the soft top of her hand with his sharp spear. The bronze pierced
 the ambrosial robe the Graces had made; immortal ichor flowed, for the gods
 eat no grain or drink dark wine. Aphrodite cried out and dropped her son.

Iris gave Aphrodite the horses of Ares. Aphrodite climbed into the chariot,
 her heart in grief; Iris sat beside her, took the reins, and lashed the team.
 Swiftly they reached Olympus, the steep seat of the gods. Iris halted the horses,
 unharnessed them, and laid ambrosial food before them. Aphrodite fell on her knees
 before her mother Dione, who embraced and stroked her, asking which Uranian god
 had done this rash deed as though she had been caught doing evil.
 Aphrodite answered: "The high-hearted son of Tydeus, Diomedes, wounded me,
 because I was carrying my dear son Aeneas from the battle; he is dearest to me.
 This is no longer a war only between Trojans and Achaeans—the Danaans now fight
 the immortals." Dione told her to endure: many who dwell in Olympus have suffered
 hard pain from men. Ares endured when the Aloadae, Otus and Ephialtes,
 bound him in bronze bonds for thirteen months, until Hermes secretly rescued him;
 Hera endured when Amphitryon's strong son shot her in the right breast;
 Hades endured the swift arrow Heracles shot at him in Pylos, sending him
 in pain to Zeus's house, the arrow lodged in his shoulder. Paeon poured
 pain-soothing medicines upon Hades, for he was not mortal. Dione rebuked
 the violent archer who harmed the gods, and said that Athena had set Diomedes
 against Aphrodite: foolishly he did not know that a man who fights immortals
 does not return long from war, nor do children greet him at his knees.
 She wiped the ichor from Aphrodite's hand; the hand healed and the pain eased.
 Hera and Athena watched and teased Zeus with sharp words. Athena began:
 "Father Zeus, will you be angry if I speak? Cypris has surely urged one of the
 Achaean women to follow the Trojans she loves, and while caressing one of our
 well-robed Achaean women she has scratched her delicate hand upon a golden brooch."
 The father of gods and men smiled and called golden Aphrodite near:
 "My child, warlike deeds are not given to you; pursue instead the lovely works
 of marriage. Let swift Ares and Athena attend to these."
 While they spoke, Diomedes rushed again at Aeneas, knowing Apollo himself
 held his hands above the hero. Yet he did not fear the great god; he still desired
 to kill Aeneas and strip away his famous armor. Three times he charged to kill him;
 three times Apollo struck his shining shield aside. At the fourth, like a god,
 Apollo shouted: "Beware, son of Tydeus, and draw back. Do not think like the gods;
 there is no equal race between immortals and men who walk the earth."
 Diomedes withdrew a little, avoiding the anger of the far-shooter.
 Apollo set Aeneas apart in sacred Pergamus, where his temple stood;
 Leto and Artemis healed and honored him in the great sanctuary.
 Apollo made an image like Aeneas in form and armor, and around that image

Trojans and Achaeans beat one another, striking rounded ox-hide shields.
 Then Phoebus called fierce Ares:
 “Ares, destroyer of mortals, wall-breaker, will you not go into battle
 and draw this man, Diomedes, out? He would fight even father Zeus now.
 First he wounded Cypris near the wrist, then he rushed against me like a god.”
 So Apollo seated himself on the height of Pergamus, while Ares entered the crowd
 in the likeness of Acamas, leader of the Thracians, urging the Trojans.
 The Trojans’ ranks were urged forward by fierce Ares, who had taken
 the form of swift Acamas, leader of the Thracians. He called to Priam’s sons:
 “Sons of Priam, Zeus-nourished king, how long will you let the Achaeans
 kill your people? Will you wait until they fight around your well-built gates?
 Aeneas lies there, a good companion whom we honored like Hector.
 Come, let us save him from the tumult.” His words stirred every heart.
 Then divine Sarpedon rebuked Hector: “Hector, where has the courage gone
 you once possessed? You said you could hold the city without its people
 or allies, alone with brothers and sons-in-law. Now I see none of them;
 they shrink like dogs around a lion, while we fight as the allies you summoned.
 I have come from far-off Lycia beside the whirling Xanthus,
 leaving a dear wife, a little son, and many possessions behind,
 yet I urge my Lycians and myself to meet a man. Here I have nothing
 for an Achaean to carry away, but you stand idle and do not command
 the people to remain and defend their walls. Take care lest you and your people
 become prey, caught like flax in a snare, while the enemy soon sacks your city.
 You must entreat the famous allies, night and day, to stand unceasingly,
 and lay aside your harsh reproach.”
 His speech pierced Hector’s heart. Hector leapt from his chariot in armor,
 shook his sharp spears, and moved everywhere through the host,
 rousing the dreadful battle. They turned and faced the Achaeans;
 the Argives stood together and did not flee. As a wind carries chaff
 over a sacred threshing floor when men winnow grain, and the straw-heaps
 grow white beneath the wind, so the Achaeans grew white above in dust,
 as the horses’ hooves drove it up to the bronze sky and the drivers turned them.
 But fierce Ares covered the Trojans with darkness, moving everywhere
 to help them and fulfilling Apollo’s commands, who had sent him to raise
 the Trojan courage when he saw Athena withdraw, leaving the Danaans aid.
 Apollo himself brought Aeneas from the sanctuary and put strength into him.
 His companions rejoiced when they saw him alive, unhurt, and full of courage,

but did not ask what had happened: another labor was being raised by Apollo, Ares, and unwearied Strife.

The two Ajaxes, Odysseus, and Diomedes urged the Danaans to fight. They did not fear the Trojans' strength or arrows, but stood like clouds that Cronus' son holds still upon the mountain peaks until the force of Boreas and the other fierce winds sleeps. So the Danaans stood fast and did not flee.

Agamemnon moved among them, calling: "Be men, friends; take a valiant heart, and respect one another in the fierce battle. More men survive when they feel shame; among the fleeing no glory rises, nor courage."

He cast his spear and struck Deicoon, companion of Aeneas, son of Pergasus, honored like Priam's sons because he fought among the first. The spear passed through shield and belt into his lower belly; he fell, and his armor rang upon him.

Aeneas killed two excellent Achaeans, Crethon and Orsilochus, sons of Diocles, a wealthy man in well-built Pherae whose line descended from Alpheius, the broad-flowing river through Pylia land.

Diocles fathered the twins, skilled in war; when they grew, they followed the Argives to Ilium to win honor for Agamemnon and Menelaus, but the end of death covered them there. Like two lions raised by their mother in the thick forest, they ravaged cattle and sheep in men's folds until sharp bronze killed them in men's hands; so Aeneas subdued them, and they fell like tall firs.

The war-loving Menelaus pitied the fallen pair, and, helmeted in flashing bronze, went through the foremost ranks, brandishing his spear. Ares, thinking to bring him down beneath Aeneas' hands, stirred his courage. Antilochus, Nestor's great-hearted son, saw him and hurried through the battle, fearing for the shepherd of the people lest the labor of the day be lost. The two stood face to face, eager to fight, while Antilochus held close beside Menelaus.

Aeneas, though swift in war, would not wait when he saw the two champions standing together. They dragged the dead back among the Achaeans, laid the fallen in the hands of their companions, and turned again into the foremost line. There they slew Pylæmenes, leader of the great shield-bearing Paphlagonians; Menelaus struck him beneath the collarbone, and Antilochus felled Mydon, his charioteer, striking the elbow that held the reins. The ivory-white reins dropped in the dust; Antilochus sprang upon him with the sword and drove him from the well-built car, face and shoulders buried in the sand, until the horses were seized and led away among the Achaean ranks.

Hector saw them and came against them shouting, with the Trojan battalions behind him. Ares led the way, and shameless Enyo carried the tumult of war; Ares swung his enormous spear, now before Hector, now behind him. Diomedes, seeing the god, shuddered like a helpless traveler who, standing above a river pouring foaming into the sea, beholds the flood and runs backward. He called to his friends: “Look how we marvel at noble Hector, both spearman and daring warrior! Yet some god always stands beside him, warding off destruction; and now that god is Ares, made like a mortal man. Face the Trojans, and give ground ever backward. Do not desire to fight the gods by force.”

The Trojans came close. Hector killed Menesthes and Anchialus, two companions in one chariot. Great Telamonian Ajax pitied them, stood near, and cast his bright spear at Amphius, son of Selagus, a wealthy man who dwelt in Paesus among fields of grain, but fate had led him to fight beside Priam and his sons. Ajax struck him beneath the belt; the long shadowing spear fixed in his belly, and he fell with a crash. Ajax ran to strip his armor, but Trojan spears poured around him, and his shield received them all. He tore the bronze from the dead, yet could not take away the beautiful armor: the press of the many and the brave drove him back, and he staggered beneath their charge.

Then fate, strong and pitiless, raised against godlike Sarpedon the tall and excellent Tlepolemus, son of Heracles. When they had drawn near—son and grandson of Zeus who gathers the clouds—Tlepolemus first addressed the Lycian captain: “Sarpedon, counselor of the Lycians, what compels you to crouch here before the battle, a man unpracticed in war? They lie who call you son of aegis-bearing Zeus, for you fall far short of the men said to have sprung from him in earlier days. My father Heracles was brave and lion-hearted. He came here once for the horses of Laomedon with six ships and few men, and laid Ilium waste, making its streets bereaved. But your spirit is poor, and your people waste away. You will be no defense to Troy, though you have come from Lycia; beneath my spear you shall be subdued and pass through the gates of Hades.”

Sarpedon answered: “Tlepolemus, that man did destroy sacred Ilium through the blindness of proud Laomedon, who repaid his good service with an evil word and would not give him the horses for which he came from far away. But here, I say, you shall find death and the black fate: slain beneath my spear, you shall give glory to me, and your spirit to Hades, the lord of the famous horses.”

They raised their spears. Both shafts flew wide; then Sarpedon struck the neck of Tlepolemus, and the grievous point passed through. Black night covered his eyes. Tlepolemus struck Sarpedon's left thigh; the spear drove through and lodged

against the bone, yet Zeus' son was not wholly overcome. Sarpedon's dear companions carried him from the battle, and the long spear dragged after him, for no one thought how to draw the ash from his thigh while they hurried under that burden. The well-greaved Achaeans bore Tlepolemus away. Odysseus saw him, and his brave heart burned. He wondered whether to pursue Zeus' son or take the lives of many Lycians, but it was not his portion to kill the mighty son of Zeus. Athena turned his spirit toward the Lycian multitude, and he slew Coeranus, Alastor, Chromius, Alcander, Halios, Noemon, and Prytanis.

He would have killed more, but Hector, the great-helmed son of Priam, perceived the danger and crossed the foremost ranks, bringing dread to the Danaans. Sarpedon, son of Zeus, rejoiced at his coming and spoke in grief: "Priam's son, do not leave me as prey for the Danaans; defend me, and then let life abandon me here in your city. I was not destined to return home and gladden my dear wife and little son." Hector gave him no answer, but rushed past, eager to thrust back the Argives and take the life of many. His companions set Sarpedon beneath Zeus' beautiful oak. There strong Pelagon, his beloved friend, drew the ash from his thigh. His spirit left him, and a mist covered his eyes; then the breath of the North Wind blew upon him, and he revived, gasping and faint.

But the Argives, once Ares and bronze-clad Hector had entered the battle, neither advanced toward the black ships nor stood to meet them; they continually gave ground when they heard that Ares was among the Trojans. Whom did Hector and bronze

Ares first and last strip of life? Teuthras, horse-driving Orestes, the spearman Trechus, Oenomaus, Helenus son of Oenops, and Oresbius with the bright belt—he who dwelt beside the Cephissian lake in Hyle, rich in goods, while the other Boeotians lived near him on their fertile land.

White-armed Hera saw the Argives falling in the hard battle and spoke to Athena: "Shame! Shall our promise to Menelaus be vain—that well-walled Ilium should fall, if we let destructive Ares rage so? Let us too put forth our strength." Athena did not refuse. Hera harnessed her swift golden-maned horses; Hebe fitted the curved eight-spoked wheels upon the iron axle, and Hera set the golden yoke and reins. Athena cast her embroidered robe at her father's feet, put on Zeus' warlike tunic, and armed herself with the tasselled aegis, crowned with Fear, Strife, Strength, and the dreadful Gorgon head. She set upon her head the four-crested golden helmet, fitted for a hundred cities, mounted the flaming car, and took the great spear with which she breaks the ranks of heroes who have angered her strong father. Hera urged the horses on. Of their own accord the gates of heaven groaned—the gates

held by the Hours, who open and close the dense cloud between Olympus and the sky. They found Zeus sitting apart from the other gods on the highest peak. Hera loosed the horses at the meeting of Simoeis and Scamander, hid them in deep mist, and the river raised ambrosia for them to eat. Hera and Athena went on like shy doves toward the place where the best of the Argives stood around horse-taming Diomedes, gathered like lions or boars whose strength is not easily broken. Hera cried in the voice of Stentor, whose bronze voice equaled the voices of fifty men: “Shame, Argives—cowards in beautiful bodies! While noble Achilles walked among you, the Trojans never dared to leave the Dardanian gates, so greatly they feared his terrible spear. Now they fight far from the city beside the hollow ships.” Her cry awakened the courage of all. Athena found Diomedes beside his horses and chariot, cooling the wound Pandarus had made with his arrow. Sweat tormented him beneath the broad shield-strap, and his arm grew weary as he wiped the dark blood away. The goddess touched the yoke and said: “Little did Tydeus beget a son like himself! Tydeus was small in body, but a fighter. When I forbade him to fight or to burst into the tumult, and he came as messenger to Thebes among the Cadmeans, I told him to feast quietly in the halls. Yet his strong spirit challenged the young men and defeated them all, for I stood beside him. I stand beside and guard you too. Fight the Trojans freely. Has long weariness weakened your limbs, or does fear hold you? You are no son of Tydeus, the battle-wise Oeneid.”

Diomedes answered: “I know you, goddess, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, and will hide nothing. Neither fear nor cowardice holds me; I remember still the commands you gave me—not to fight the blessed gods openly. But if Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus, comes into the battle, I may wound her with the sharp bronze. Therefore I withdraw and bid the other Argives gather here: I know Ares rules the fight.”

Athena replied: “Diomedes, dear to my heart, fear neither Ares nor any other immortal; I am your defense. Drive your sure-hoofed horses straight at Ares. Strike him close; do not dread that mad, shifting god, who lately boasted to Hera and me that he would fight for the Trojans and aid the Argives, but now mingles with the Trojans and has forgotten his promise.” She thrust Sthenelus from the chariot and drew him back with her hand; he sprang away. The goddess mounted beside Diomedes, and the beech axle groaned beneath the weight of a god and a great man. Pallas Athena took the reins and drove first against Ares.

Ares was stripping the armor from huge Periphas, best of the Aetolians, when Athena put on the helmet of Hades that the mighty god might not see her. As soon as Ares, the bane of mortals, saw Diomedes, he left Periphas where he had first slain him and came straight against the horse-tamer. Ares thrust over the yoke and reins, eager to take the mortal's life; Athena caught the spear and drove it aside, so that it flew

in vain. Diomedes then thrust with his bronze spear; Athena guided it beneath the belly, where the belt was fastened. He struck Ares, tore the beautiful flesh, and withdrew the spear. The brazen god cried as loudly as nine or ten thousand men cry when war's quarrel brings them together. A shudder seized Achaeans and Trojans alike. As dark air appears from clouds when a hot wind rises from a stormy quarter, so bronze Ares appeared to Diomedes, rising among the clouds toward the broad heaven. Swiftly he reached Olympus, sat beside Zeus, and showed the immortal blood running from his wound. "Father Zeus," he lamented, "do you not see these violent deeds? We gods suffer always from one another's will, bringing favor to mortal men. We all fight because you begot this senseless, ruinous daughter, whose mind is forever set on lawless deeds. The other gods in Olympus obey you and bow beneath your will, but you restrain her neither in word nor deed because you yourself fathered this destructive child. She has now driven arrogant Diomedes against the immortals: first he wounded Cypris at the wrist, and then rushed upon me like a god. My swift feet saved me; else I should have suffered long among the dreadful dead, or lived powerless beneath the blows of bronze."

Zeus looked at him darkly: "Do not sit beside me and whimper, you turncoat. You are the god I hate most among those who hold Olympus. Strife, war, and battle are always dear to you. You have your mother's unyielding, unmanageable temper—Hera's; even I can scarcely master her with words. I think her counsels have brought you this pain. Yet I will not endure your suffering long, for you are my child, and your mother bore you to me. Had you been born from another god, destructive one, you would long ago have been lower than the sons of Heaven."

He commanded Paeon to heal him. Paeon spread pain-soothing medicines upon the wound, and it closed at once, for Ares was not fashioned mortal. As curdling fig-juice quickly thickens white milk when stirred, so quickly the medicine healed the furious god. Hebe washed him and dressed him in shining garments; he sat beside Zeus in glory. Hera of Argos and Athena of Alalcomenae returned to the great house of Zeus, having stopped murderous Ares from his slaughter of men.

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BOOK 6

First-pass working translation

The battle rolled on, terrible, between the Trojans and the Achaeans; their bronze-shod spears drove straight against one another between the streams of Simoeis and Xanthus. Great Telamonian Ajax, the rampart of the Achaeans, broke the Trojan line first and brought light to his friends. He struck Acamas, son of Eussorus, the best and tallest of the Thracians; the bronze point pierced the horse-haired crest, entered his forehead, and darkness covered his eyes. Diomedes slew Axylus, son of Teuthras, a rich man who dwelt in well-built Arisbe and loved all men: his house stood beside the road, and every traveler found welcome there. Yet no one could stand before Diomedes and save him from the fatal day; he took both Axylus and his charioteer Calesius, and the two went down together in dust. Euryalus stripped Dresus and Opheltius, then went on against Aesepus and Pedasus, twin sons whom the water-nymph Abarbarea bore to noble Bucolion. Bucolion was the eldest son of proud Laomedon, but his mother bore him in secret. While he tended sheep he lay with the nymph, who conceived and brought forth the twins; now the son of Mecisteus broke their strength and took the shining armor from their shoulders. War-loving Polypoetes slew Astyalus; Odysseus struck down Percosius with bronze, and Teucer felled Aretaon. Antilochus, Nestor's son, killed Ablerus with his bright spear; Agamemnon, lord of men, killed Elatus, who dwelt beside the fair-flowing Satnioeis near steep Pedasus. Leitus took Phylacus as he fled, and Eurypylus stripped Melanthius of life.

Menelaus seized Adrastus alive. His frightened horses, startled across the plain, broke the curved chariot's pole against a tamarisk branch; they ran toward the city where the others fled, while Adrastus rolled headlong from the car and fell face-first in the dust. Menelaus stood above him with his long-shadowed spear. Adrastus clasped the Atrid's knees and pleaded: "Take me alive, son of Atreus, and accept a ransom worthy of me. My wealthy father has bronze, gold, and much-worked iron stored in his house; he would give you measureless gifts if he heard that I was alive among the Achaean ships." His words moved Menelaus' heart, and he was already about to send Adrastus to the swift ships, into the hands of a servant, when Agamemnon came running and called aloud: "My good Menelaus, why do you care so for these men? Have

the Trojans treated your house so well? Let none escape the steep death from our hands—not even the unborn child carried in its mother's womb. Let all of Ilium perish, unburied and unseen.” His brother's words turned Menelaus' mind; he thrust Adrastus away, and Agamemnon struck him beneath the ribs. As he fell, the Attid planted his foot upon his chest and tore the ash spear free.

Then Nestor cried to the Argives: “Friends, Danaan heroes, servants of Ares, let no one linger now beside the spoils, loading his hands with armor to carry back to the ships. Let us kill the men; afterward, when you stand untroubled, you may strip the dead across the field.” His shout awakened every heart.

The Trojans would have fled into Ilium beneath the Achaeans, had not Helenus, Priam's son, best of all augurs, come to Aeneas and Hector and said: “Aeneas and Hector, on you above all Trojans and Lycians the labor rests, because you are best in counsel and battle. Stand here, and hold the people before the gates, moving everywhere through the ranks, before they fall in flight into women's hands and become a joy to the enemy. When you have roused every battalion, we will remain and fight the Danaans here, though we are sorely worn, for need drives us. Hector, go through the city; tell your mother and mine to gather the elders, open the temple of gray-eyed Athena on the city's height, and lay upon the goddess' knees the robe she believes most beautiful and most large, the one she loves best in the house. Promise twelve yearling heifers, never yet broken to the goad, if she will pity the city, the wives of Troy, and their little children, and keep the fierce spear of Tydeus' son, the strong deviser of flight, from sacred Ilium. I call him the strongest of all the Achaeans; not even Achilles, they say, though born of a goddess, was ever so feared. This man rages beyond measure, and no one can equal his strength.”

Hector did not disobey his brother. He leapt from his chariot in his armor, shook his sharp spears, and went everywhere through the army, urging the battle and waking the dreadful tumult. The Trojans turned and stood against the Achaeans; the Argives gave ground and stopped their slaughter, believing that some immortal had descended from the starry heaven to defend the Trojans. Hector called aloud: “Trojans, men of high spirit, and far-famed allies, be men, my friends, and remember your furious courage while I go into Ilium and tell the elders and our wives to pray to the gods and promise hecatombs.” Thus he spoke and went away, and the shield's rim, running lowest around its boss, struck his ankles and the dark skin of his neck. Glaucus, son of Hippolochus, and Tydeus' son Diomedes came together between the armies, both eager to fight. When they had drawn near, Diomedes spoke first, his voice strong in battle:

“Who are you, best of mortal men? I have never seen you before
 in the glory-making war; yet now you have gone far beyond all others
 in daring, to wait for my long-shadowed spear. The sons of the unhappy
 who meet my strength do not live long. If you have come down from heaven,
 I will not fight the gods who dwell above; even mighty Lycurgus, son of Dryas,
 did not live long when he quarreled with the immortals. He once drove the nurses
 of raging Dionysus down the holy slopes of Nysa; they scattered the fennel wands
 while man-slaying Lycurgus beat them with his ox-goad. Dionysus, afraid, plunged
 beneath the sea, and Thetis received him trembling in her lap; the man’s shout
 had filled him with terror. The gods who live easily were angered at Lycurgus,
 and the son of Cronus blinded him; nor did he live long, hated by every god.
 I would not fight the blessed ones. But if you are one of those mortals who eat
 the fruit of the earth, come nearer, that you may sooner reach the boundary of death.”
 The shining son of Hippolochus answered: “Great-hearted son of Tydeus, why ask
 my lineage? Like the leaves, so is the race of men. The wind scatters one year’s
 leaves upon the ground, and the forest, breaking into flower, grows others when
 spring returns. So one generation of men comes forth, and another passes away.
 Yet, if you wish to know this too, that you may know it well, many men know my house.
 “There is a city called Ephyre, in the heart of horse-breeding Argos. There lived
 Sisyphus, most cunning of men, Sisyphus son of Aeolus; his son was Glaucus, and
 Glaucus fathered blameless Bellerophon. The gods gave Bellerophon beauty and
 lovely courage. But Proetus devised evil against him, and drove him from the people
 of Argos, for he was much stronger than they; Zeus had placed them beneath Proetus’
 scepter. Then the wife of Proetus, divine Anteia, was seized with desire to lie
 secretly with him, but Bellerophon would not yield, for his thoughts were good.
 She lied to King Proetus: ‘Die, Proetus, or kill Bellerophon, who sought to lie
 with me against my will.’ The king was angered, yet feared to kill him, and sent
 him to Lycia with a folded tablet bearing many signs of death, commanding that
 he be destroyed by the man who received it.
 “Bellerophon went under the gods’ good escort. When he reached broad Lycia and
 the flowing Xanthus, the king welcomed and honored him, feasting him nine days
 and sacrificing nine oxen. On the tenth dawn he asked to see the sign that Proetus’
 son-in-law had sent. When he had received the deadly tablet, he first commanded
 Bellerophon to kill the unconquerable Chimera, a creature of divine stock:
 in front a lion, behind a serpent, and in the middle a goat, breathing the terrible
 strength of burning fire. Bellerophon killed her, trusting the omens of the gods.
 Then he fought the glorious Solymi, saying that this was the hardest battle among

men; and third he slew the man-like Amazons. When he returned, the king wove another

close snare, choosing the best men from broad Lycia and setting them in ambush. None returned home; blameless Bellerophon killed them all. At last, knowing that he was the dear son of a god, the king held him there, gave him his daughter, and granted him half the royal honor. The Lycians cut out for him a beautiful estate, rich in orchard and plowland, that he might possess it.

“His wife bore three children to brave Bellerophon: Isander, Hippolochus, and Laodameia. Zeus who counsels all lay with Laodameia, and she bore godlike Sarpedon, armed in bronze. But when Bellerophon became hated by all the gods, he wandered alone across the Aleian plain, eating his heart and shunning the paths of men. Ares, insatiable in war, killed his son Isander as he fought the glorious Solymi; Artemis of the golden reins, angered, killed Laodameia. Hippolochus fathered me, and from him I say that I was born. He sent me to Troy with many commands: always to be best and excel all others, never to shame the blood of my fathers, who were the greatest in Ephyre and in broad Lycia. Of this lineage and blood I boast.”

Diomedes rejoiced when he heard him, planted his spear in the earth, and answered the shepherd of the people with gentle words: “Then you are an ancient guest-friend of my father's house. Noble Oeneus once entertained blameless Bellerophon in his halls for twenty days, and they exchanged beautiful guest-gifts: Oeneus gave a bright purple belt, and Bellerophon a golden, two-handled cup. I left that cup at home when I came here. I do not remember Tydeus, for I was still a child when the Achaeans perished at Thebes. So now I am your guest-friend in Argos, and you mine in Lycia, if ever I come among that people. Let us avoid each other's spears in the crowd; there are Trojans and famous allies enough for me to kill, whom some god may place in my path, and Achaeans enough for you to kill, if you can. Let us exchange armor, so that these men may know that we boast of being our fathers' guest-friends.” They spoke, leapt down from their chariots, clasped one another's hands, and pledged their faith. But Zeus, son of Cronus, stole Glaucus' understanding: he exchanged golden armor for bronze, the price of a hundred cattle for the price of nine.

Hector reached the Scaean gates and the beech tree, and the wives and daughters of the Trojans ran around him, asking after their children, brothers, friends, and husbands. He told them all to pray to the gods, for sorrow had fallen heavily upon them. When he came to Priam's splendid house, built with polished porticoes, he found fifty chambers of hewn stone, set close together, where the king's sons slept beside their wedded wives; and across the court stood twelve roofed chambers for his daughters and their husbands. There his gentle mother met him, bringing

Laodice, the fairest of her daughters. She took his hand and called him by name: “My child, why have you left the fierce battle? Are the hateful sons of the Achaeans pressing hard around the city, and has your heart sent you here from the wall’s edge to lift your hands to Zeus? Wait, and I will bring you honey-sweet wine, that you may pour a libation first to father Zeus and the other immortals, and then refresh yourself if you drink. Wine gives great strength to a weary man, and you are weary from defending your companions.”

Great-helmed Hector answered: “Do not bring me honeyed wine, revered mother, lest you weaken my limbs and make me forget my strength. I am ashamed to pour bright wine to Zeus with unwashed hands, and it is not lawful to pray to the dark-clouded son of Cronus while stained with blood and filth. Go instead to Athena’s temple, gathering the old women of the city. Take the robe that seems to you the most beautiful and largest in the house, the one most dear to her, and lay it upon the knees of the fair-haired goddess. Promise twelve yearling heifers, never yet broken to the goad, if she will pity the city, the wives of Troy, and their children, and keep the fierce spear of Tydeus’ son from sacred Ilium. I will seek Paris and call him, if he will listen. Would that the earth might open and swallow him!

The Olympian has bred him as a great plague to Troy, to Priam, and to his sons; if I saw him going down to Hades, I think my spirit might forget its grief.”

His mother went into the perfumed chamber and called her attendants; they gathered the old women throughout the city. Hecuba descended to the chamber where lay the embroidered robes made by Sidonian women, whom godlike Alexander had brought from

Sidon across the wide sea by the same route on which he carried Helen, high-born daughter of Tyndareus. She lifted one robe, most beautiful in its pattern and the largest of all, shining like a star, and lying beneath the others. With it she went, and many aged women followed. When they reached Athena’s temple on the city’s height,

Theano, fair-cheeked daughter of Cisseus and wife of horse-taming Antenor, opened the doors; the Trojans had made her priestess of Athena. All raised their hands with the ritual cry. Theano took the robe and laid it upon the knees of the fair-haired goddess, praying: “Lady Athena, glorious among goddesses, break Diomedes’ spear, and make him fall forward before the Scaean gates. Then we will sacrifice twelve yearling heifers in your temple, if you will pity the city, the wives of Troy, and their little children.” So she prayed, but Pallas Athena turned her face away.

Hector went to the beautiful house of Paris, built by the best craftsmen of fertile Troy beside the houses of Priam and Hector. He entered with his

eleven-cubit spear in his hand, the bronze point shining before him and the golden socket running around it. Paris was there, putting on his fine armor, shield and breastplate, and bending his curved bow; Argive Helen sat among her maidservants, directing their famous work. Hector rebuked him:

“Strange man, you nurse this anger in your heart while the people perish around the steep wall. For your sake battle and war have kindled this city; you yourself would fight another if you saw him shrinking from the hateful war. Rise, before the enemy's fire consumes the town.”

Godlike Paris answered: “Hector, you have rebuked me justly, and not beyond what is just. I did not sit here from anger toward the Trojans, but because I wished to yield to grief. My wife has urged me toward the battle with gentle words, and I too think it is better. Wait a little; I will put on my armor, or go ahead, and I will soon catch you.”

Hector did not answer him. Helen spoke to Hector with gentle words:

“Brother of my husband, dog that I am, full of hateful contrivance! Would that the storm had carried me away on the day my mother bore me, to mountain or wave-beaten sea, before these deeds were born. But since the gods have appointed these evils, would that I had been the wife of a better man, one who knew the shame and many reproaches of men. This man has no steady mind now, nor will he have one later; I think he will reap what he has sown. Come in and sit upon this bench, my brother, since the labor has weighed most heavily upon your heart, because of me, hateful as I am, and because of Alexander's ruin. Zeus set this evil fate upon us, that we should be sung as a song for generations yet to come.”

Great-helmed Hector answered: “Do not ask me to sit, Helen, though you love me; you will not persuade me. My heart already urges me to defend the Trojans, who long for me while I am gone. Stir this man, and let him hurry, so that he may find me still within the city. I will go home too, to see my wife and my little son; for I do not know whether I shall return to them again, or whether the gods will bring me down beneath Achaean hands.”

He spoke and left. At once he reached his well-inhabited house, but did not find Andromache in the hall. She had gone with her child and a richly dressed attendant to the great tower, lamenting and grieving. Hector stood at the threshold and asked the servants: “Tell me truly: where has white-armed Andromache gone from the house? Has she gone to my sisters or my brothers' well-robed wives, or to Athena's temple, where the other fair-haired Trojan women seek to appease the dreadful goddess?” The busy housekeeper answered: “Since you command me to tell the truth, she has gone neither to your sisters nor to your brothers' wives, nor to Athena's temple

where the women pray. She heard that the Trojans were worn down and that the Achaeans' strength had grown great; she hurried to the wall like a mad woman, and her nurse carried the child with her."

Hector ran out of the house and back through the well-built streets. As he passed the gates, where he was about to cross into the plain, his richly gifted wife Andromache came running to meet him, daughter of great-hearted Eetion, who dwelt beneath wooded Placus in Thebe of Cilicia. She had been Hector's wife. Her attendant carried at her breast their little child, beloved Astyanax, whom Hector called Scamandrius, while all others called him Astyanax, "lord of the city," for Hector alone defended Ilium.

Hector smiled silently when he saw the child. Andromache came close, shedding tears, took his hand, and called him: "Your own strength will destroy you, pitiless man; you have no pity for your little child or for me, soon to be your widow. The Achaeans will soon kill you, all rushing upon you together. It would be better for me, if I lose you, to go beneath the earth; I shall have no other comfort once you meet your fate, only sorrow. I have no father or honored mother. Achilles killed my father, and sacked high-gated Thebe, the well-inhabited city of Cilicia. He killed Eetion, but did not strip him, for he feared to do that in his heart; he burned him in his beautiful armor and raised a mound over him, and the mountain nymphs, daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus, planted elms around it. I had seven brothers in the house; all went down to Hades on one day, for swift-footed Achilles killed them among their shambling cattle and white sheep. He carried away my mother, who ruled beneath wooded Placus, with the rest of the spoil, then released her for a measureless ransom; but Artemis of the bow struck her down in the house of my father.

"Hector, you are now my father, honored mother, brother, and strong husband. Come, then, pity me and stay here upon the tower; do not make your child an orphan and your wife a widow. Set the army beside the fig tree, where the city is easiest to climb and the wall most open to attack. Three times the best of them have tried that place, around both Ajaxes, glorious Idomeneus, the Atrids, and the brave son of Tydeus—perhaps some prophet told them, or perhaps their own courage drove them on."

Great-helmed Hector answered: "All this lies within my heart, woman. But I would be deeply ashamed before the Trojans and their trailing-robed wives if I shrank from the battle like a coward. My spirit does not allow it; I have learned to be brave and to fight always among the first Trojans, winning great glory for my father and myself. For I know this surely in my mind and heart: the day will come when sacred Ilium, Priam, and the people of Priam, strong in the spear, will all be destroyed. But the future grief of the Trojans, of Hecuba herself, of lord Priam, and of my many brave

brothers when they fall in the dust beneath hostile men does not pain me so much as yours, when some bronze-clad Achaean leads you away weeping, taking your free day from you. In Argos you will weave at another woman's loom, or carry water from Messeis or Hypereia, unwilling, and harsh necessity will lie upon you. Then someone may see you in tears and say: 'There is the wife of Hector, who was best in battle among the horse-taming Trojans when they fought around Ilium.' So he will speak, and your grief will be new, lacking such a husband to ward off the day of slavery. May the piled earth cover me dead before I hear your cry and see you dragged away." When he had spoken, glorious Hector reached toward his child; but the boy turned back toward the nurse's richly belted breast, crying, frightened by his dear father's appearance and by the bronze and the horsehair crest nodding terribly from the top of the helmet. His father and honored mother laughed. At once Hector took the helmet from his head and set it shining upon the ground. He kissed his beloved son, rocked him in his arms, and prayed to Zeus and the other gods:

"Zeus and all gods, grant that this child may become, as I am, eminent among the Trojans, strong in courage, and rule Ilium by his might. May someone one day say, 'He is far better than his father,' when he returns from battle carrying the bloody armor of an enemy he has killed; and may his mother's heart rejoice."

He placed the child in his dear wife's arms. She received him into her fragrant bosom, smiling through tears. Her husband pitied her, stroked her with his hand, and called her by name: "Dear one, do not grieve so deeply. No man can send me to Hades before my appointed portion; and no man, coward or brave, has ever escaped his fate once he was born. Go home, and tend to your own work, the loom and distaff, and command your attendants to keep at their labor. War shall be the concern of all the men born in Ilium, but most of all of me."

He spoke and lifted the horsehair helmet. His wife went home, turning often to look back and shedding tears; the attendants raised a common lament, believing Hector would not return from battle. Paris did not linger in his high house. Once he had put on his shining armor, he hurried through the city, bright as a well-fed horse that breaks its tether and runs proudly to the river. He soon found his noble brother as Hector was turning away from the place where he had spoken with his wife.

"Brother," Paris said, "I have detained you by waiting, and have not come as quickly as you commanded." Hector answered: "No decent man could despise your work in battle,

for you are strong; but you hold back by choice, and my heart aches when I hear the shame the Trojans endure because of you. Come. We shall make amends, if Zeus ever grants us to raise a mixing bowl in the halls of heaven after victory."

Source range: Book 6. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 7

First-pass working translation

Hector sprang from the gates, and Alexander followed him, both eager to fight. As when a god gives wind to sailors who have labored across the sea, their limbs worn out with toil, so the two appeared to the Trojans, longing for battle. They killed Menesthius, son of the club-bearing king Areithous, and Hector struck Eionaeus beneath the bronze rim of his helmet, loosening his knees. Glaucus, son of Hippolochus and leader of the Lycians, hit Iphinous, son of Dexias, as he leapt upon his swift horses, and brought him down with his shoulder pierced.

Gray-eyed Athena saw the Argives falling in the hard battle and rushed down from Olympus toward sacred Ilium. Apollo, watching from Pergamus and wishing victory for the Trojans, rose to meet her beside the beech tree. Apollo spoke: “Why have you come in such eagerness from Olympus, daughter of great Zeus? Do you mean to give the Danaans a victory that turns the battle? You do not pity the Trojans as they perish. If you would listen, it would be far better: let us stop the war and slaughter for today; afterward they may fight again until they find the appointed end of Ilium, since it is dear to both of us to destroy this city.”

Athena answered: “Let it be so, Far-shooter. I too came from Olympus with that purpose, between the Trojans and Achaeans. But tell me how you mean to end the fighting.”

Apollo said: “Let us rouse Hector’s strong heart, that he may challenge one of the Danaans to stand alone against him in the hateful battle. Then the bronze-greaved Achaeans, angered, will send one champion against godlike Hector.”

Athena agreed. Helenus, Priam’s beloved son, understood the counsel that pleased the gods, came to Hector, and said: “Hector, son of Priam, equal to Zeus in counsel, will you listen to me, your brother? Make all the Trojans and Achaeans sit, and call one of the Danaans, the best he can be, to fight you face to face. You are not yet fated to die; so I heard the voice of the ever-living gods.”

Hector rejoiced at the word. He went into the midst of the Trojan ranks, grasped his spear at its center, and halted the whole line. Agamemnon seated the well-greaved Achaeans; Athena and silver-bowed Apollo sat like vultures upon the high beech of aegis-bearing Zeus, delighting in the men below.

The ranks sat close in the plain, bristling with shields, helmets, and spears, like the ripples that Zephyr pours newly over the sea, darkening the water. Hector spoke between the two armies: “Hear me, Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans, while I say what my heart commands. High-seated Zeus has not made our oaths come to fulfillment; instead he devises evil for both sides, until either you take well-walled Troy, or you yourselves are overcome beside the sea-going ships. Among you are the best of all the Pan-Achaeans. Let whichever man’s heart urges him to fight Hector come here and stand before me.

“I speak this, and let Zeus be our witness. If he kills me with the long-edged bronze, let him strip my armor and carry it to the hollow ships; but let him return my body, so that the Trojans and their wives may give me the portion of fire after death. If I kill him, and Apollo gives me glory, I will strip his armor, carry it to sacred Ilium, and hang it in the temple of far-shooting Apollo; but I will give his body back to the well-benched ships, that the long-haired Achaeans may bury him and raise his mound beside the broad Hellespont. Then some man of the generations yet to come, sailing the wine-dark sea in a many-oared ship, will say: ‘This is the grave of a man who died long ago, whom glorious Hector killed when he excelled in battle.’ So men will speak, and my fame shall never die.”

All fell silent. They were ashamed to refuse, yet afraid to accept the challenge. At last Menelaus rose and rebuked them: “Ah me, Achaean women, no longer Achaeans! This will be a shame beyond measure if no Danaan now goes against Hector. May you all become water and earth, sitting here without spirit or glory; I myself will arm against him, though the ends of victory lie with the immortal gods.”

He began to put on his beautiful armor, but then his brother Agamemnon seized him by the right hand and said: “You are mad, Menelaus, beloved of Zeus. Rise, though you grieve, and do not choose to fight Hector, the son of Priam, a better man whom others hate. Even Achilles feared to meet him in the man-making battle, though he is far stronger than you. Sit now among your companions; the Achaeans will raise another champion. However fearless and tireless he is, I say that his knee will bend gladly if he escapes the enemy and the terrible fighting.”

His brother persuaded him with words that were just, and willing attendants removed the armor from his shoulders. Then Nestor rose and cried: “What grief has come upon the Achaean land! Old horseman Peleus, counselor and speaker of the Myrmidons, would groan if he heard that all the best Argives now shrink beneath Hector. I wish I were young again, as when the Pylians and spear-famed Arcadians gathered beside the walls of Phea and I fought godlike Ereuthalion, wearing the armor of King Areithous, whom

men and women called the Club-bearer because he broke the ranks with an iron club, not with bow or long spear. Lycurgus killed him by ambush in a narrow road, striking him through before the club could help him, then stripped the armor which brazen Ares had given him. In his old age Lycurgus gave it to his beloved servant Ereuthalion, who challenged every champion while wearing it. All trembled and refused, but my own heart urged me to fight; I was the youngest of them all, and Athena gave me glory. I killed that great and strongest man, and his huge body lay stretched in the dust. If only I were young again, and my strength were still firm, Hector would soon find an opponent. Yet not one of you, the best of the Pan-Achaean, comes willingly against him.”

The old man’s rebuke made all nine rise: first Agamemnon, then strong Diomedes, the two Ajaxes in their warlike strength, Idomeneus and his companion Meriones, Eurypylus, son of Euaemon, Thoas son of Andraemon, and godlike Odysseus. All wished to fight Hector. Nestor told them to cast lots straight through a helmet, for the chosen man would benefit the well-greaved Achaeans and himself, if he escaped the enemy and the dreadful battle. Each marked his lot and dropped it into Agamemnon’s helmet. The army prayed, lifting their hands to heaven: “Father Zeus, let Ajax, or the son of Tydeus, or the king of gold-rich Mycenae draw the lot.”

Nestor shook the helmet, and out sprang the lot they wanted: Ajax’s. The herald carried it through the crowd and showed it from right to left to each champion, but none knew it. When he came to Ajax, who had marked and placed it in the helmet, Ajax stretched out his hand and recognized the sign. He threw the lot at his feet and said: “Friends, the lot is mine; my heart rejoices, for I think I shall overcome godlike Hector. Bring me my warlike armor while you pray to Zeus, son of Cronus—silently, so the Trojans do not hear, or openly, for I fear no man. No one shall drive me unwillingly from the fight by strength or skill; I do not think I was born and raised so helplessly in Salamis.”

Ajax armed himself in flashing bronze. When he had clothed his body in every piece, he sprang forward like enormous Ares going to war among men whom the son of Cronus has joined in a devouring quarrel. So Ajax rose, the giant rampart of the Achaeans, smiling with a terrible face, taking long strides and shaking his long-shadowed spear. The Argives rejoiced to see him; dread seized every Trojan, and Hector’s own heart beat hard. Yet he could neither draw back nor hide among his people, for he himself had called the champion forth.

Ajax came near carrying a shield like a tower, bronze-faced and sevenfold in hide, which Tychius, best of leather-workers, had made for him in Hyle. Seven hides of well-fed bulls were sewn together, and over them he had hammered an eighth layer of bronze. Telamonian Ajax held it before his chest and stood close to Hector:

“Hector, you shall learn plainly, standing alone, what champions the Danaans have, and that there are many such even after Achilles, the lion-hearted breaker of ranks. He lies beside the curved ships in anger against Agamemnon, shepherd of the people; but we are here, many enough to meet you. Begin the battle and war.”

Great-helmed Hector answered: “Do not test me, son of Telamon, as though I were a helpless child or a woman who knows nothing of war. I know how to fight and kill; I know how to wield the hide shield to right and left, and how to leap into the tumult of swift horses. I know how to dance in the close battle of dreadful Ares. Yet I will not strike you secretly while watching my chance; I will strike openly, if I can.”

He balanced his long-shadowed spear and hurled it. It struck the terrible sevenfold shield at its highest bronze layer, the eighth surface, and the tireless metal cut through six hides before the seventh held it. Ajax then threw his long-shadowed spear and struck Priam’s son on his perfectly round shield. The mighty point passed through the bright shield and lodged in the richly wrought breastplate, tearing the tunic beside his flank; Hector bent aside and avoided black death. Both drew out their long spears and fell upon one another like lions that eat raw flesh, or boars whose strength is not easily broken.

Hector stabbed the center of Ajax’s shield, but the bronze bent at the point and did not break through. Ajax leapt and thrust; his spear passed across the shield, drove Hector backward, cut his neck, and black blood spurted. Yet Hector did not stop. He drew back and seized a great rough black stone that lay in the plain, and hurled it at the terrible shield’s central boss; the bronze rang around it. Ajax raised a still larger stone, whirled it, and drove it against Hector’s shield. The millstone-shaped rock broke the shield inward and wounded Hector’s knees; he lay stretched backward, pinned beneath it. But Apollo quickly raised him. They would have fought at close quarters with swords, had not the heralds, messengers of Zeus and of men, come between them.

At last Idaeus for the Trojans and Talthymbius for the bronze-clad Achaeans came between them, both wise heralds, and held their staffs between the champions.

Idaeus spoke: “Do not fight any longer, dear sons; do not make war. Zeus who gathers the clouds loves you both, and both are spearmen—we all know that. Night has already come; it is good to obey the night.”

Telamonian Ajax answered: “Idaeus, tell Hector to say this. He himself called all our champions forth. Let him begin, and I will gladly obey whatever he says.”

Hector replied: “Ajax, since the god has given you great size, strength, and wisdom, and you are the best of the Achaeans with the spear, let us now stop the battle

and slaughter for today. Later we shall fight again until the god separates us and gives victory to another. Night has come; it is good to obey the night. So you may make all your friends rejoice beside the ships, above all your companions and dear comrades; and I will gladden the Trojans and their trailing-robed wives in Priam's great city, who will enter the sacred contest and pray for my return. Come, then, let us give one another famous gifts, so that Achaeans and Trojans may say: "They fought in the spirit of consuming strife, yet parted after joining in friendship."

Hector gave Ajax a silver-studded sword with its sheath and a finely cut baldric; Ajax gave Hector his bright purple war-belt. They parted, one going among the Achaean people and the other into the Trojan tumult. The Trojans rejoiced when they saw Hector alive and whole, escaped from Ajax's strength and unwearied hands; they led him toward the city, no longer expecting to see him safe. The well-greaved Achaeans brought Ajax, exultant in victory, to the noble Agamemnon.

The Achaeans gathered in Agamemnon's hut, and the lord of men sacrificed a five-year-old bull to mighty Zeus. They flayed it, divided it, cut it into pieces, roasted it carefully, and laid out the meal. When their hunger and thirst were satisfied, Agamemnon honored Ajax with the long back portions. Then Nestor, whose counsel had always been best, began to weave his plan:

"Atrid and all you champions of the Pan-Achaeans, many long-haired Achaeans have died; sharp Ares has scattered their dark blood around the flowing Scamander, and their spirits have gone down to Hades. At dawn stop the battle. Let us gather the dead here with oxen and mules, burn them a little before the ships, so that each man may carry his bones home when we return to his fatherland. Let us raise one mound around a common pyre, bringing the bodies in from the plain, and quickly build high towers beside it as a defense for the ships and ourselves. Let us make doors fitted within them, that chariots may pass through, and outside dig a deep trench to hold back horses and men, lest the war of the proud Trojans press upon us."

All the kings praised his counsel. In high Ilium, meanwhile, the Trojans gathered in a rough assembly before Priam's doors. Wise Antenor spoke first:

"Hear me, Trojans, Dardanians, and allies. Let us give Helen of Argos, and the possessions she brought, to the sons of Atreus. We have broken our faithful oaths and fight for nothing; I do not expect a good end unless we do this."

He sat down. Godlike Alexander, husband of fair-haired Helen, rose and answered:

"Antenor, your words are no longer pleasing to me; you could have devised a better speech. If you truly speak this in earnest, the gods themselves have destroyed your mind. I will declare my answer to the horse-taming Trojans: I will not give back the woman, but all the possessions I brought from Argos I will give, and I will add other

treasures from my own house.”

He sat down, and Priam’s son Dardanus, equal to the gods in counsel, rose and told the Trojans: “Take your supper through the city as before, remember the watch, and stay awake, each man. At dawn let Idaeus go to the hollow ships and tell the Attrids, Agamemnon and Menelaus, Alexander’s answer—the cause of our strife. Let him also ask whether they will cease from the harsh war until we have burned the dead. Later we shall fight again, until the god separates us and gives victory to others.”

The Trojans listened and obeyed. Idaeus went at dawn to the Achaean ships and found the sons of Atreus in council. Standing among them, he declared Alexander’s offer: “He will not return Helen, but he will return all the possessions he brought from Argos and add more from his own house, if the sons of Atreus will accept them.” All sat silent, until Agamemnon answered: “No; we will not accept the possessions, nor will we accept Helen. The Trojans have suffered enough already to understand that their ruin is near.”

The Trojans took their supper through the army, and at dawn Idaeus went to the hollow ships. He found the Danaans assembled beside Agamemnon’s stern and stood among them to deliver the proposal: “Atrid and other champions of the Pan-Achaeans, Priam and the noble Trojans have ordered me to say, if it is pleasing to you, what Alexander offers, for whose sake the quarrel arose. He will give back all the goods he brought to Troy in the hollow ships—and add other possessions from his own house; but he will not return Menelaus’ wedded wife, though the Trojans urge him. They also ask whether you will cease the harsh war until we have burned the dead; afterward we shall fight again until the god separates us and gives victory to others.”

All were silent. At last Diomedes, breaker of horses, spoke: “Let no one accept Alexander’s possessions or Helen; even a child can see that the end of destruction already hangs over the Trojans.” All the Achaeans shouted approval. Agamemnon turned

to Idaeus: “You hear the answer of the Achaeans yourself. I also approve it. We do not refuse to burn the dead; no one should spare the bodies once life is gone. Let Zeus, the loud-thundering husband of Hera, witness our oaths.” He lifted his staff to all the gods, and Idaeus returned to sacred Ilium.

The Trojans and Dardanians sat gathered in assembly, waiting for Idaeus. He came and told them the answer. At once both sides armed: some went to bring in the dead, others went for wood. The sun had only just touched the fields, rising from deep-flowing Ocean, when the armies met. It was hard to recognize each man; washing away the blood with water, they lifted the dead upon the wagons, shedding hot tears. Great Priam forbade the Trojans to weep: silently, hearts grieving, they carried

their dead to the pyre, burned them, and returned to sacred Ilium. In the same way the well-greaved Achaeans carried their dead, burned them, and went back to the hollow ships.

Before dawn, while the night was still dim, the Achaeans gathered around the pyre. They raised one mound from the bodies brought in from the plain, built a wall beside it with high towers as a defense for the ships and themselves, made well-fitted gates for the chariot road, and dug a broad, deep trench outside, setting stakes within it. The long-haired Achaeans labored at the work. The gods, seated beside Zeus who delights in lightning, watched the great work of the bronze-clad men. Earth-shaking Poseidon began to speak:

“Father Zeus, is there still a mortal who will tell the gods his mind and counsel? Do you not see how the long-haired Achaeans have built a wall over their ships and dug a trench around it, giving no famous hecatombs to the gods? Its fame will spread as far as the dawn, while men will forget the wall that Phoebus Apollo and I built with labor for Laomedon.”

Zeus, deeply angered, answered: “What a thought you have spoken, wide-strength Earth-shaker! Some other god, far weaker than you in hands and strength, might fear it; but your fame will spread as far as the dawn. When the long-haired Achaeans depart with their ships for their dear fatherland, tear down the wall and pour it all into the sea; cover the broad shore again with sand, so that the Achaeans’ great wall may be wholly forgotten.”

Thus they spoke. The sun set, and the Achaeans’ work was finished. They sacrificed oxen among the huts and took their supper. Many ships came from Lemnos bringing wine,

sent by Euneus, son of Jason and Hypsipyle. For Agamemnon and Menelaus alone he sent

a thousand measures of wine. The long-haired Achaeans bought it, some with bronze, some with shining iron, some with hides, some with whole cattle, and some with slaves; they laid out a rich feast. All night the Achaeans feasted, while the Trojans and their allies sat through the city. All night Zeus, the counselor, devised evil for them, thundering terribly; green fear seized them, and they poured wine from their cups upon the ground, unwilling to drink before they had poured a libation to mighty Cronus’ son. Then they slept and received the gift of sleep.

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BOOK 8

First-pass working translation

Dawn spread her saffron robe across the earth, and Zeus, delighting in thunder, called the gods to council on the highest peak of many-ridged Olympus. He spoke, and all the gods listened: “Hear me, every god and goddess, while I say what my heart commands. Let no female or male god attempt to break my word; all together approve it, that I may bring this work to its swift end. If I see any one of you going apart from the others to aid either Trojans or Danaans, he shall return to Olympus beaten and dishonored, or I will seize him and throw him into misty Tartarus, far down, where the iron gates and brazen threshold lie as far beneath Hades as heaven is above the earth. Then you will learn how much I am the strongest of all. “Come, test it, gods, so that you may all know. Hang a golden chain from heaven, and take hold of it, every god and goddess together; you could not drag highest Zeus from heaven to earth, though you labored greatly. But if I wished to pull, I could draw you up with the earth and the sea, bind the chain around the ridge of Olympus, and leave all things suspended. So far do I stand above gods and men.” He spoke, and all sat silent, astonished by the force of his word. At last gray-eyed Athena said: “Our father, son of Cronus, you know that your strength cannot be opposed. Yet we pity the spear-bearing Danaans, who will perish in an evil fate. We will keep away from the war as you command, but we will give the Argives counsel that may help them, lest they all perish beneath your anger.” Cloud-gathering Zeus smiled and answered: “Take courage, Tritogeneia, dear child; I do not speak in anger, but wish to be gentle with you.” He harnessed his bronze-hoofed horses with their golden manes, clothed his body in gold, seized the golden whip, and mounted the chariot. The willing horses flew between earth and the starry heaven. He reached Ida, rich in springs, mother of wild beasts, and Gargarus, where he had a sacred grove, altar, and incense. There the father of gods and men unharnessed the horses, hid them in deep mist, and sat upon the peak in his glory, looking toward the city of Troy and the Achaean ships. The long-haired Achaeans took their meal quickly among the huts and armed themselves; the Trojans armed throughout the city, fewer than before, yet determined by necessity to fight before their children and wives. All the gates opened, and footmen and horsemen rushed out amid a great uproar. When they met in one place, hide struck hide, spear struck spear, and the courage of bronze-clad men collided. The bossed shields

crashed together; cries rose from those who killed and those who died, and the earth ran with blood.

As the sacred day grew, missiles struck both sides and men fell. When the sun stood at mid-heaven, Zeus stretched out his golden scales and set in them the two fates of death, one for the horse-taming Trojans and one for the bronze-clad Achaeans. He lifted the balance at its middle: the Achaeans' day sank toward the earth, while the Trojan fate rose toward the broad heaven. Zeus thundered terribly from Ida and cast a blazing flash among the Achaeans; they were seized by green fear. Neither Idomeneus nor Agamemnon, nor either Ajax, dared remain; only Nestor stayed, not willingly, for an arrow shot by Paris, husband of fair-haired Helen, struck his horse at the top of its head where the first mane grows, the most vulnerable place. The horse sprang in pain; the shaft entered its brain, and it tangled the others in the bronze. While the old man cut the traces with his sword, Hector's swift horses came through the uproar carrying their driver, and the old man would have lost his life had Diomedes not seen him and called loudly to Odysseus.

Hector urged the Trojans: "Fools, who devised this wall, weak and useless!

It will not hold back my strength; our horses will easily leap the trench.

When I reach the hollow ships, remember the fire: I will burn them and kill the Argives beside them, choking in the smoke." He called to his horses—Xanthus, Podargus, Aethon, and divine Lampus—and told them to repay the rich fodder and wine Andromache, daughter of Eetion, had given them in former days. If they drove swiftly, he said, they might seize Nestor's shield, all gold in its hoops and boss, and Diomedes' wrought breastplate, made by Hephaestus; then the Achaeans might board

their ships that very night.

Hera shook her throne in anger and said to Poseidon: "Earth-shaker, do you feel no pity for the dying Danaans, who carry many beautiful gifts to Helice and Aegae? If we who aid the Argives wished, we could drive back the Trojans and hold off Zeus." Poseidon answered: "Bold Hera, what word is this? I would not fight Zeus, who is far stronger than all of us."

Hector's men and horses filled the space between the ships and the trench, penned in by the deep cut ground. Hector, favored by Zeus, would have set fire to the ships, but Hera put a new thought into Agamemnon's mind. He took a great purple cloak, went through the huts and ships, and stood upon Odysseus' black ship, midway between the tents of Ajax and Achilles. With his voice carrying both ways he cried:

"Shame, Argives, beautiful in form but evil in reproach! Where are your boasts, when on Lemnos you claimed that each man could face a hundred or two hundred

Trojans? Now we are not worth even one Hector, who will soon burn the ships. Father Zeus, have you blinded some great king, robbing him of honor? I never passed your beautiful altar with a many-oared ship without burning the fat and thighs of oxen, eager to destroy well-walled Troy. Grant me at least this prayer: let the Argives escape and not perish, though you allow the Trojans to overcome them.” The father pitied him, shedding a tear, and nodded that the people should live and not be destroyed. At once he sent the most perfect of flying birds, an eagle carrying a fawn in its talons. He dropped it beside Zeus’ beautiful altar where the Achaeans made sacrifice. When they saw the bird from Zeus, they leapt more fiercely against the Trojans and remembered their courage.

No one among the many Danaans dared drive his horses from the trench and fight before

Diomedes. He was first to kill a helmeted Trojan, Agelaus son of Phradmon, striking him between the shoulders as he turned his horses; the spear passed through his chest, and his armor rang as he fell. Agamemnon and Menelaus followed, then the two Ajaxes, Idomeneus and Meriones, Eurypylus, and Teucer ninth, drawing his recurved bow. Ajax carried his shield before him; each time Teucer shot and felled a man, he slipped back beneath it like a child beneath its mother. Teucer first killed Orsilochus, Ormenus, Ophleustes, Daitor, Chromius, Lycophontes, Amopaon, and Melanippus. Agamemnon rejoiced and called: “Teucer, beloved head, son of Telamon, lord of the people, shoot so that you become a light to the Danaans and to your father who raised you from childhood, though you were born outside the marriage bed. Give him fame though he is far away; I tell you how it shall be fulfilled.”

Teucer answered: “Most glorious Atrid, why urge me when I am already eager? Since we drove them back toward Ilium I have not stopped, but have killed eight men with my long-tongued arrows. Yet I cannot strike this rabid dog.” He sent another shaft at Hector, but Apollo turned it aside; it struck Archeptolemus, Hector’s brave charioteer, in the chest beside the breast. He fell from the car, and his horses sprang away. Hector grieved terribly for his companion, yet left him lying and told his brother Kebriones to take the reins. Then Hector leapt from the chariot with a dreadful cry, seized a jagged stone, and rushed upon Teucer.

Teucer drew a bitter arrow and bent the bow, but as he pulled it beside the shoulder, where the collarbone guards the neck, Hector struck him with the stone. The cord broke,

his hand went numb, and he fell upon his knees; the bow dropped from him. Ajax did not

forget his brother: he ran around him and covered him with the bright shield, while two faithful companions, Mecisteus and Alastor, lifted the groaning man and carried

him to the hollow ships.

The Olympian roused the Trojans again. They drove the Achaeans straight toward the deep trench, and Hector went first, eyes blazing like Gorgon's and murderous Ares. As a hound pursues a boar or lion from behind, darting at its hips and turning aside from its jaws, so Hector followed the long-haired Achaeans, killing the last man in the line. They crossed the stakes and trench in flight; many Trojans also fell beneath their hands, while the Achaeans held by the ships, calling to one another and lifting their hands to every god.

Hera pitied the Danaans and said to Athena: "Daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, shall we no longer care for the dying Argives, who will perish by one man's assault, while Hector, son of Priam, rages beyond endurance?" Athena answered: "Would that he might lose his strength beneath Argive hands and die in his own land! But my father's mind is mad and cruel, always opposing my will. He remembers nothing of how often I saved his son Heracles from Eurystheus' labors. If I had known this day when he sent Heracles to fetch the hound from Hades, he would never have escaped the steep waters of Styx. Now he hates me, but has fulfilled Thetis' prayer, who kissed his knees and clasped his beard to honor city-sacking Achilles. There will be a day when he calls his gray-eyed daughter dear again. Harness the horses; I will arm in Zeus' house and see whether Hector rejoices when we appear in the fight, or whether his flesh feeds dogs and birds beside the Achaean ships."

Hera harnessed her golden-maned horses, while Athena cast her embroidered robe at her father's feet, clothed herself in Zeus' battle-tunic, and took the great spear with which she breaks the ranks of heroes. Hera urged the team on. The gates of heaven opened of themselves, gates held by the Hours, who open and close the dense cloud over Olympus; through them the goddesses drove. But Zeus saw them from Ida and was fiercely angry. He sent golden-winged Iris with a message: "Go quickly and turn them back. Do not let them come against the battle. I will lame their swift horses beneath the chariot, throw them from the car, and break their chariot; even after ten years their wounds would not heal if struck by my lightning. Then Athena will learn what it means to fight her father. I am less angry with Hera, for she always contradicts whatever I say."

Iris met them at Olympus and said: "Where are you hastening? The son of Cronus does not permit you to aid the Argives. He threatens to lame your horses, throw you from the car, and strike your chariot; even ten years would not heal the wounds. He says he is less angry with Hera, but calls you, Athena, a shameless dog if you dare raise your mighty spear against Zeus."

Hera answered: "Daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, I will no longer let us fight the

father for mortal men. Let one die and another live, whoever happens to meet his fate; let Zeus judge Trojans and Danaans according to his own heart.” She turned the horses back. The Hours unhitched them, tied them beneath ambrosial mists, and leaned the chariot against the shining wall. Hera and Athena sat upon golden chairs among the other gods, hearts wounded.

Zeus drove from Ida to Olympus, where Earth-shaker Poseidon unharnessed his horses and placed the chariot beside the altar. Zeus sat on his golden throne, and Olympus shook beneath his feet. He saw Hera and Athena sitting apart and spoke: “Why are you so grieved? You did not tire of destroying Trojans in the man-making battle. Such is my strength and my unconquered hands that all the gods on Olympus could not turn me. Yet your limbs trembled before you saw war and its terrible work. If I had struck your horses with lightning, you would not have returned to Olympus for ten circling years.”

The goddesses muttered together, devising evil for Troy. Athena sat silent, angry with her father; Hera could not contain her resentment: “Most terrible son of Cronus, we know your strength is not weak. Yet we pity the spear-bearing Danaans, who will perish in an evil fate. We will keep away from the war, if you command, but we will give the Argives counsel, lest they all perish beneath your anger.” Zeus answered: “Tomorrow you will see the mighty Cronus’ son destroy many Argives, if you wish, for strong Hector will not cease from war until swift-footed Peleus’ son rises beside the ships on the day the Achaeans fight around Patroclus’ body. So fate has ordained it. I do not care for your anger, even if you reach the furthest boundaries of earth and sea, where Iapetus and Cronus sit in Tartarus without the sun’s light.” The sun’s bright light sank into Ocean and drew black night across the grain-giving earth. The Trojans, unwilling, lost the day; but the Achaeans welcomed the triple-prayed-for darkness. Hector called the Trojan assembly apart from the ships, beside the swirling river, where the ground was clear of corpses. They climbed down from their horses and listened as Hector leaned upon his eleven-cubit spear, its bronze point shining and its golden socket running around it:

“Hear me, Trojans, Dardanians, and allies. I thought that before night fell we would destroy the ships and return to windy Ilium, but darkness came and saved the Argives and their ships beside the sea. Let us obey the black night. Prepare supper; loose the fair-haired horses and set fodder before them. Bring cattle and fat sheep from the city, and buy honey-sweet wine and bread from the houses; gather much wood, so that all night until early dawn we may burn many fires whose light reaches heaven, lest the long-haired Achaeans attempt flight across the broad sea in darkness.

“Let them not board their ships without a struggle. Let each carry home a wound,

struck by arrow or sharp spear as he leaps aboard, so that every man may dread to bring tearful Ares against horse-taming Troy. Heralds should announce through the city that boys at the edge of manhood and gray-haired elders gather upon the towers built by the gods; let every woman kindle a great fire in her house, and let a firm watch stand, lest an ambush enter while the people are away. Let this speech stand sound for now; at dawn I will address the Trojans again. I hope, praying to Zeus and the other gods, to drive from here those dogs carried by the fates, driven to our ships. Tonight we guard ourselves; at first light we arm and wake sharp Ares beside the hollow ships. Tomorrow I shall learn whether strong Diomedes will drive me from the ships to the wall, or whether I will kill him with bronze and carry away his bloody armor. If only I were immortal and ageless, and honored as Athena and Apollo are honored, as this day has brought evil to the Argives!”

The Trojans shouted in answer. They loosed the sweating horses, tied them beside their chariots, and brought cattle, sheep, wine, bread, and wood swiftly from the city. They made perfect hecatombs to the immortals, but the winds carried the sweet smoke from the plain toward heaven; the blessed gods would not share it, for sacred Ilium, Priam, and Priam’s strong people were hateful to them. The Trojans, confident in the war, sat all night beside their many fires. As stars appear around the bright moon when the sky is windless, and every peak, ridge, and hollow lies visible beneath the opened heaven, so the fires of the Trojans shone between the ships and the streams of Xanthus. A thousand fires burned upon the plain, and beside each sat fifty men in the firelight. Their horses cropped white barley and spelt beside the chariots, waiting for the bright-throned dawn.

Source range: Book 8. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 9

First-pass working translation

The Trojans kept watch, but the Achaeans were held by a terrible companion, chill fear, and every champion lay beneath unbearable grief. As Boreas and Zephyr suddenly stir the fish-filled sea, raising black waves and scattering seaweed along the shore, so the Achaeans' hearts were torn within them. Agamemnon, pierced by great sorrow, called the leaders quietly to assembly and stood weeping like a dark-water spring pouring down a sheer rock:

"Friends, Zeus, son of Cronus, has bound me in ruinous delusion. Once he promised that we would sack well-walled Ilium and return; now he devises a hateful deception and commands me to go dishonored to Argos, having lost so many men. Come, let us obey my word: let us flee with our ships to our dear fatherland. We shall not take broad-streeted Troy."

Diomedes rose: "Atrid, I will oppose you in your folly, as is lawful in assembly. You once reproached my courage before the Danaans, but the young and old Argives know that this was false. Zeus gave you a scepter, honoring you above all, but did not give you the greatest strength. If your heart urges you to go, go: the road is open, and your many ships stand near the sea. Others of us will remain until we have sacked Troy. Sthenelus and I will fight until we find the end of Ilium, for we came here with a god." The Achaeans shouted approval.

Nestor rose: "Son of Tydeus, you are strong in war and best of your peers in counsel; no Achaean will find fault with your speech, but you have not reached its end. You are young enough to be my youngest son, yet you speak wisely to kings. Let us obey the black night, prepare supper, and set guards beside the dug trench. Then, Agamemnon, feast the elders; your huts are full of wine, and men will hear the counsel of whoever offers the best plan. Our enemies burn many fires near the ships; who could be glad? This night will either shatter the army or save it."

The kings obeyed. Agamemnon answered: "Old man, you have not lied in naming my error.

I was blinded, and I do not deny it. I will appease Achilles with measureless ransom: seven tripods, ten talents of gold, twenty shining cauldrons, twelve prize-winning horses, and seven skilled Lesbian women, with Briseis among them. I will swear that I never entered her bed. These shall be ready at once. If we sack Priam's city, Achilles may load his ship with gold and bronze, choose twenty Trojan women next to Helen in beauty, and take one of my three daughters to Peleus' house without bride-

price. I will give him seven cities near the sea, whose people will honor him like a god. Let him submit; Hades is pitiless and unconquerable.”

Nestor, the Gerenian horseman, answered: “Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men, Agamemnon, the gifts are no longer hidden from Achilles.

Come, let us summon the men who will go swiftly to the son of Peleus.

Let Phoenix lead them, dear to Zeus; then great Ajax and shining Odysseus.

Let the heralds Odios and Eurybates go with them. Bring water for their hands, and command a holy silence, so that we may pray to Zeus, son of Cronus, if perhaps he will pity us.” Everyone approved his word.

At once the heralds poured water over their hands. The young men crowned the mixing bowls with wine and served the cups, beginning with the customary offering. When they had poured and drunk as much as their hearts desired, they set out from Agamemnon’s shelter. Nestor gave each man many instructions, but most of all he charged Odysseus to persuade the blameless son of Peleus. They went beside the shore of the loud-roaring sea, praying earnestly to Earth-shaking Poseidon that they might easily bend the great heart of Aeacus’ grandson.

They reached the huts and ships of the Myrmidons and found Achilles delighting his heart with a clear, beautiful, carefully wrought lyre, whose silver bridge he had taken from the spoils when he destroyed Eetion’s city. With it he sang the famous deeds of men. Patroclus alone sat opposite him in silence, waiting for Achilles to finish his song. Odysseus led the others forward. They stood before him, and Achilles sprang up in astonishment, leaving the lyre and the seat where he had been sitting. Patroclus rose as well when he saw the men. Achilles, swift-footed, greeted them: “Welcome. You have come as friends, though I am angry with the Achaeans; you are the dearest of all to me.”

He led them within and seated them on chairs spread with purple rugs. Then he called to Patroclus, who stood nearby: “Set out a larger mixing bowl, son of Menoetius, and mix the wine stronger. These are the dearest men beneath my roof.”

Patroclus obeyed his beloved companion. He set a great chopping block in the glow of the fire, laid upon it the back of a sheep, the fat haunch of a goat, and the richly marbled chine of a well-fed pig. Automedon held the meat, while noble Achilles cut it; Patroclus, a man equal to the gods, kindled the great fire.

When the fire had burned the wood down and the flame faded, he spread the embers, stretched the spits above them, and sprinkled sacred salt. When the meat was roasted, he set it into baskets. Patroclus distributed the bread in handsome baskets, while Achilles portioned the meat. He sat opposite godlike Odysseus against the other wall, and commanded Patroclus to sacrifice the inner portions

to the gods; Patroclus cast them into the fire. The guests reached toward the food laid before them.

When they had put away their desire for food and drink, Ajax nodded to Phoenix, and noble Odysseus understood. He filled the cup, raised it toward Achilles, and spoke: "Hail, Achilles. Your feast is not lacking, whether in Agamemnon's shelter or here, for there is abundant food to share. Yet we cannot give our minds to this lovely meal: a great disaster, heaven-nurtured, stands before our eyes, and we fear whether we shall save our well-benched ships or perish. The proud Trojans and their far-famed allies have camped close beside the ships and wall, lighting many fires. They say they will not stop until they fall upon the black ships. Zeus, son of Cronus, flashes favorable signs for them; Hector, exulting in his great strength, rages terribly, trusting in Zeus. He honors neither men nor gods, and ruinous madness has entered him. He prays for the holy Dawn to appear as quickly as possible, for he boasts that he will cut off the ships' high sterns, burn the ships themselves with consuming fire, and kill the Achaeans beside them as they choke in the smoke. "These threats I dread terribly in my heart, lest the gods fulfill them and it be our appointed fate to perish at Troy, far from horse-pasturing Argos. Rise, then, if you are willing, even now, to rescue the sons of the Achaeans, worn down beneath the Trojans' uproar. Afterwards grief will be yours, and there is no remedy once the evil is done. Consider beforehand how you will ward the evil day from the Danaans. "My dear friend, your father Peleus gave you this charge on the day he sent you from Phthia to Agamemnon: 'My son, Athena and Hera will grant you strength, if they will it; but keep your great-hearted spirit within your breast, for kindly fellowship is better. Abandon the quarrel that breeds evil, so that the Argives, young and old, may honor you more.' Thus the old man charged you, but you forget it. Even now cease, and let go the anger that eats your heart. Agamemnon gives you worthy gifts if you will end your wrath. Hear me, and I will recount all the gifts Agamemnon promised in his shelter: seven tripods never placed upon the fire; ten talents of gold; twenty shining cauldrons; twelve horses that have won prizes with their feet; and seven Lesbian women, skilled in excellent work, whom he took when you captured well-built Lesbos and who surpassed all the tribes of women in beauty. He will give these to you, and with them the girl Briseis whom he took from you. He will swear a great oath that he never climbed into her bed or joined with her, as is the custom between lord and woman.

"All these things will be here at once. If the gods grant us to sack Priam's great city, when we divide the spoil among the Achaeans, you may enter your ship and load it with gold and bronze. You may choose twenty Trojan women, those who are fairest

after Argive Helen. If we reach Achaean Argos, the rich breast of the land, you will be Agamemnon's son-in-law, and he will honor you as he honors Orestes, his beloved son, raised amid abundance. He has three daughters in his well-built house: Chrysothemis, Laodice, and Iphianassa. Whichever you wish, you may lead home to Peleus' house without bride-price, and he will give you wedding gifts such as no man has ever given his daughter. He will also give you seven well-inhabited cities: Cardamyle, Enope, grassy Hire, sacred Pherae, deep-meadowed Antheia, lovely Aipeia, and vine-covered Pedasus. All lie near the sea, at the edge of sandy Pylos; in them live men rich in sheep and cattle, who will honor you like a god with gifts and under your scepter fulfill bright judgments.

"These things he will accomplish for you when you have let go your anger. But if the son of Atreus is hateful to you in your heart, him and his gifts, then pity the other Achaeans, who are suffering throughout the camp and will honor you like a god. You would win immense glory from them now, for you could take Hector, who would come very near you with his deadly madness; he claims that no Danaans brought here in the ships are his equal."

Achilles answered: "Odysseus, sprung from Zeus, son of Laertes, resourceful man, I must answer plainly, just as I think, and just as it will be fulfilled, so that you will not sit beside me murmuring one after another from different directions. That man is hateful to me as the gates of Hades who hides one thought in his heart and speaks another. I will tell you what seems best to me. I do not think I can persuade Agamemnon, son of Atreus, or the other Danaans, since there was no gratitude for my unceasing fight against the enemy. The same portion belongs to the one who stays and the one who fights hardest: coward and brave are held in equal honor, and both die alike, the man who has done nothing and the man who has labored much.

"There is no profit left for me, after I have suffered pain in my heart and always thrown my life into battle. Like a wingless bird that carries food to its fledglings whenever it catches it, and suffers for its labor, so I have spent many sleepless nights and passed bloody days fighting men for their wives. With my ships I have destroyed twelve cities, and on foot I say I have taken eleven in fertile Troy. From all these I carried many beautiful treasures away and gave everything to Agamemnon, son of Atreus. He stayed behind beside the swift ships, received the goods, and distributed only a little; he kept much for himself. He gave the rest as prizes to the best men and the kings, and their portions remain safe. From me alone among the Achaeans he took the woman I loved, and now he keeps her. Let him lie beside her and be glad.

“Why must the Argives fight the Trojans? Why did the son of Atreus gather and lead the army here? Was it not for fair-haired Helen? Are the sons of Atreus the only men who love their wives? Every good and sensible man loves and cares for his own, as I loved her, though I won her by my spear. Now that he has taken my prize from my hands and deceived me, let him not try me again: I know him, and he will not persuade me. Let him, with you and the other kings, devise how to ward the enemy fire from the ships. He has labored greatly without me: he built a wall and drove a broad, deep trench around it, planting stakes within. Yet even that cannot hold Hector, killer of men. While I fought among the Achaeans, Hector would not venture far from the wall, but came only as far as the Skaian Gates and the beech tree, where once he stood alone and barely escaped my attack.

“Now I do not wish to fight glorious Hector. Tomorrow I will sacrifice to Zeus and all the gods, draw my ships well down to the sea, and you will see them, if you care and if it concerns you, sailing at first light upon the fish-filled Hellespont, with men eager at the oars. If the famous Earth-shaker grants a fair voyage, on the third day I should reach fertile Phthia. I have much there, and much that I left behind in my ruinous journey. From here I will carry away gold, red bronze, well-girded women, and gray iron, all the shares I won. But the prize he gave me, Agamemnon, son of Atreus, has taken back again in his arrogance. Tell him this openly, as I command, so that the other Achaeans may also be angry if he hopes to deceive another Danaan, always wrapped in shamelessness. Even if he were as bold as a dog, he would not dare look me in the face. I will neither plan with him nor do any work beside him. He deceived and wronged me; he will not deceive me again with words. Enough for him. Let him go his way; Zeus the counselor has robbed him of his wits.

“His gifts are hateful to me, and I value him at the price of a hair. Even if he gave me ten times, twenty times as much as he possesses now, and as much more as he might acquire—no matter how much flows into Orchomenus or Egyptian Thebes, where the greatest wealth lies in houses, with a hundred gates and two hundred men issuing from each with horses and chariots—even if he offered me as much sand and dust as there are, Agamemnon could not persuade my spirit until he paid back all the painful insult.

“I will not marry a daughter of Agamemnon, son of Atreus, not even if she rivaled golden Aphrodite in beauty and matched bright-eyed Athena in handiwork. Let him choose another Achaean, one suited to him and more kingly. If the gods save me and I reach home, Peleus himself will find me a wife. There are many Achaean women in Hellas and Phthia, daughters of the best men who guard their cities. Whichever I wish, I will make my beloved wife. My proud heart has long urged me to take a fitting bride

and enjoy the possessions the old man Peleus won.

“Nothing is worth my life—not all the wealth they say lies in well-inhabited Ilium, the city that once lived in peace before the sons of Achaeans came, nor all that the stone threshold of Phoebus Apollo encloses in rocky Pytho. Cattle and fat sheep can be driven off; tripods and tawny horses can be acquired. But a man’s life cannot be won back, nor captured, once it has passed through the barrier of his teeth.

My mother, silver-footed Thetis, tells me that two fates carry me toward death.

If I remain here and fight around the city of the Trojans, my homecoming is lost, but my glory will be imperishable. If I return home to my beloved fatherland, my good glory is lost, but my life will be long, and death’s end will not soon overtake me. I would advise the others to sail home as well, since you will not find the end of steep Ilium: Zeus of the wide eyes has stretched his hand above it, and its people have taken courage.

“Go, then, and tell this message to the Achaean leaders—for that is the honor of old men—that they may devise another plan in their hearts, a better one, to save their ships and the Achaean army upon the hollow ships. The plan they conceived while I was angry will not save them. Let Phoenix sleep here beside us, so that he may sail with me tomorrow to my dear fatherland, if he wishes. I will not carry him by force.”

Odysseus returned to the council and told them the answer.

The chiefs sat in grief. Diomedes said: “Let us eat and sleep.

Tomorrow we will fight. A man who trusts his own courage need not beg another’s help.”

Phoenix remained beside Achilles, and the old horseman spoke with tears rising, for he feared the Achaean ships: “If you are set on homecoming, shining Achilles, and will not ward the destructive fire from the swift ships because anger has entered your heart, how could I remain here without you, my dear child? The old horseman Peleus sent me with you on the day he sent you from Phthia to Agamemnon, still a child who knew nothing of equal war or public speech, where distinguished men become leaders. He sent me to teach you all this: to be a speaker of words and a doer of deeds.

“For that reason, dear child, I would not willingly be left behind by you, not even if a god promised to scrape old age from me and make me young again, as I was when I first fled lovely Hellas from quarrels with my father, Amyntor son of Ormenus. He was angry over his fair-haired concubine, whom he loved and dishonored my mother. She begged me by my knees to sleep with the woman, so that the old man might hate her. I obeyed and did it. My father learned of it, cursed me terribly, and called upon the Erinyes never to let a son born from me sit upon his knees. Zeus beneath the earth

and dread Persephoneia fulfilled his curses.

“My heart could no longer bear to remain in my angry father’s house. Friends and cousins tried to restrain me; many fat sheep, twisting-horned cattle, and shining pigs were slaughtered, and much of the old man’s wine was drunk. For nine nights they kept watches around me, with fires never going out in the court and before the bedroom doors. On the tenth dark night I broke through the tightly fitted doors, jumped the courtyard wall, and fled unseen by the guards and serving women. I crossed broad Hellas and came to fertile Phthia, mother of sheep, to King Peleus. He welcomed me freely and loved me as a father loves his only, late-born son among many possessions. He made me rich and gave me a numerous people, and I ruled the Dolopes at the edge of Phthia.

“I loved you from my heart, godlike Achilles, and raised you so that you would never go to a feast or eat in the halls with another before I had seated you on my knees, cut the meat, and poured the wine. Often you drenched the tunic on my breast, spilling wine in your painful childhood. For you I suffered much and labored much, thinking that the gods had not granted me a child of my own; I made you my son, godlike Achilles, so that you might one day ward an unseemly doom from me.

“But tame your great spirit, Achilles; you must not keep a pitiless heart. The gods themselves can bend, though their strength, honor, and power are greater. Human beings

turn them with sacrifices, gentle vows, libations, and the savor of offerings, begging when someone has transgressed or gone astray. Prayers are daughters of great Zeus: they are lame and wrinkled, and look sideways; yet they follow afterward, caring for ruin. Whoever respects them when they draw near is greatly helped, and they hear him when he prays. Whoever rejects them and stubbornly refuses them, they go to Zeus and ask that ruin follow him, so that, harmed, he may pay the price.

“Achilles, grant the daughters of Zeus their honor; they bend the minds of other good men as well. If Agamemnon were not bringing gifts and promising more later, but always

remained fiercely angry, I would not ask you to cast off your wrath and defend the Argives, desperate though they are. But now he gives much at once and has promised much

for later, and he has sent the best men in all the Achaean army, men who are dearest to you. Do not reject their words or despise their feet. It was not wrong to be angry before. We have heard the fame of men of old who were turned by great anger, with gifts and words.

“I remember an ancient deed, and I will tell it among you all. The Curetes and the great-hearted Aetolians fought around lovely Calydon, killing one another. Artemis,

golden-throned, sent evil upon them because Oineus failed to sacrifice first-fruits to her, though the other gods feasted upon hecatombs. Whether he forgot or failed to notice, he was deeply mistaken. The archer goddess, enraged, sent a wild boar with white tusks that ravaged Oineus' orchards, throwing great trees to the ground, roots, blossoms, and fruit together.

"Meleager, Oineus' son, killed it after gathering hunters and hounds from many cities; it was too great to be brought down by a few mortals, and it sent many to the painful pyre. Artemis raised a loud quarrel over the boar's head and shaggy hide between the Curetes and the proud Aetolians. While Meleager fought, the Curetes suffered and could

not remain outside the walls, though they were many. But when anger entered Meleager—

the anger that swells even in the breast of a thoughtful man—he lay beside his lovely wife Cleopatra, nursing the wrath caused by his mother Althaea's curses. She had prayed to Hades and dread Persephoneia for her brother's death, beating the nourishing earth with her hands and kneeling in tears; the Erinyes heard her from Erebus, with her pitiless heart.

"Soon the clash and din rose around the gates as towers were struck down. The elders of the Aetolians begged Meleager and sent their best priests, promising a great gift: in the richest plain of Calydon he might choose a beautiful fifty-ploughland estate, half planted in vines and half open for the plow. His father Oineus begged him from the threshold, shaking the fitted doors on his knees; his sisters and queenly mother begged him, and his closest companions as well. But they could not move his heart until the Curetes were already upon the chamber and burning the great city.

"Then his well-girded wife came weeping and told him all the evils that befall people when a city is taken: the men are killed, the city is burned, and strangers carry off the children and deep-girdled women. His spirit was stirred when he heard of these deeds. He rose, put on his radiant armor, and warded the evil day from the Aetolians, yielding to his own heart. Yet they did not fulfill the many beautiful gifts they had promised; he warded the evil without them.

"Do not let your mind turn toward this, Achilles; do not let some god lead you there. It would be worse to ward the evil only when the ships are burning. Go toward the gifts: the Achaeans will honor you like a god. If you enter the man-killing battle without gifts, you will not have equal honor, even though you drive war away."

Achilles answered: "Old Phoenix, father dear, you have said all this from love; but I do not need this honor. I think I am honored by Zeus' decree, and that honor will remain with me beside my curved ships as long as breath stays in my breast and

my knees move. I tell you this: do not trouble my heart, grieving and mourning for the sake of Agamemnon. You should not love him, lest you become hateful to me while you are dear to me. It is good to care for the one who cares for me. Rule beside me as an equal and share half my honor. These men will carry the message; you remain here and sleep on a soft bed. At dawn we will consider whether to return home or stay.” He nodded silently to Patroclus, who spread a thick bed for Phoenix, so that the old man might decide whether to sail home with him. Great Ajax, son of Telamon, then spoke: “Resourceful Odysseus, son of Laertes, let us go. I do not think our mission will be completed by this road. We must report the message quickly, even though it is bad, to the Danaans who now sit waiting. Achilles has set a wild, great-hearted spirit in his breast. He is pitiless and does not turn from the love of his companions, by which we honored him above all beside the ships. A man accepts compensation for a murdered brother or son, and once he receives the price, his heart and proud spirit are restrained. But the gods have put an unending, evil temper in your breast because of a single woman. We offer you seven excellent women and many other things besides. Put a gracious spirit in yourself and respect your own roof; we are beneath it, chosen from all the Danaans, and we wish to be your dearest and most beloved companions among the Achaeans.”

Achilles, swift-footed, answered: “Ajax, son of Telamon, lord of the people, you have spoken all according to my heart. But my heart swells with anger whenever I remember how Agamemnon treated me before the Argives, as though I were some dishonored wanderer.

Go, then, and report my message. I will not concern myself with bloody war until Hector, Priam’s wise son, reaches the huts and ships of the Myrmidons, killing Argives and burning the ships. Around my hut and black ship, I think, Hector, eager for battle, will be stopped.”

So he spoke. Each man took the two-handled cup, poured a libation beside the ships, and went back; Odysseus led them. Patroclus ordered his companions and the serving women to spread a thick bed for Phoenix at once. They obeyed, laying fleeces, a rug, and a fine linen covering. There the old man lay waiting for bright Dawn. Achilles slept in the innermost part of the well-built shelter; beside him lay Diomedes, the beautiful daughter of Phorbas, whom he had brought from Lesbos. Patroclus lay on the other side, and beside him lay well-girded Iphidamas, whom Achilles had given him after capturing steep Scyros, Enyalios’ city.

When the embassy reached Agamemnon’s shelter, the sons of the Achaeans welcomed them

with golden cups, rising one after another and asking what they had found. First

Agamemnon, lord of men, asked: “Tell me, renowned Odysseus, great glory of the Achaeans:

does he wish to ward the enemy fire from the ships, or has he refused, and does anger still hold his great-hearted spirit?”

The much-enduring godlike Odysseus answered: “Most glorious son of Atreus, Agamemnon,

lord of men, he does not wish to extinguish his anger; it burns in him still more.

He rejects you and your gifts. He tells you to devise among the Argives how you may save the ships and the Achaeans. He himself threatened that, when bright Dawn appears, he will drag his well-benched ships into the sea. He advised the others to sail home, since you will not find the end of steep Ilium: Zeus of the wide eyes has stretched his hand above it, and its people have taken courage. Ajax and both wise heralds, who followed me, can say the same. Phoenix has lain down, as Achilles commanded, so that he may sail with him tomorrow to his beloved fatherland, if he wishes; he will not carry him by force.”

He spoke, and all were silent, astonished at the force of the answer. For a long time the sons of the Achaeans sat in sorrow. At last Diomedes, loud in battle, said:

“Most glorious son of Atreus, Agamemnon, lord of men, you should never have begged the

blameless son of Peleus with countless gifts. He is proud enough without them, and now you have driven him deeper into pride. Let us leave him, whether he goes or stays; he will fight again whenever his heart commands and a god rouses him. Come, let us do as I say: sleep now, having satisfied the heart with food and wine, for these give strength and courage. When fair, rose-fingered Dawn appears, quickly marshal the men and horses before the ships, urge them on, and fight yourself among the foremost.”

All the kings praised the speech of horse-taming Diomedes. They poured libations and went each to his shelter, where they slept and received the gift of sleep.

Source range: Book 9. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 10

First-pass working translation

The other chiefs, the best of all the Achaeans, slept beside the ships, overcome by gentle sleep. But Agamemnon, shepherd of the people, was not held by sweet sleep, for many thoughts drove through his mind. As the husband of Hera, fair-haired queen, flashes lightning while he prepares immeasurable rain, hail, or snow, or opens the great mouth of war, so Agamemnon groaned deeply from his heart, and his thoughts trembled within him. Whenever he looked toward the Trojan plain, he marveled at the many fires burning before Ilium, and at the sound of flutes, pipes, and the tumult of men. Whenever he looked toward the ships and the Achaean army, he tore great locks from his head for Zeus above and groaned from his victorious heart.

At last the best plan seemed to him to go first to Nestor, son of Neleus, and see whether together they might shape some blameless counsel that could ward disaster from all the Danaans. He rose, put on his tunic, bound his fine sandals beneath his shining feet, wrapped himself in the red hide of a great tawny lion that fell to his heels, and took his spear. Menelaus was seized by the same trembling; sleep would not settle upon his eyelids, for he feared that the Argives might suffer harm, having crossed the sea to Troy for his sake and entered the bold war. He first covered his broad back with a dappled leopard skin, lifted a bronze helmet upon his head, and took a spear in his powerful hand. He went to rouse his brother, who ruled all the Argives and was honored among the people like a god.

He found Agamemnon fitting his beautiful armor beside the stern of the ship, and was welcome when he came. Menelaus spoke first: “Why are you arming yourself like this, brother? Are you going to send one of your companions as a spy among the Trojans? I greatly fear no one will undertake this work alone, to scout hostile men through the immortal night, unless he has an exceptionally bold heart.”

Agamemnon answered: “We need a profitable plan, you and I, dear Menelaus, one that may rescue and save the Argives and their ships, now that Zeus’ mind has turned.

He has set his heart more strongly upon Hector than before. I have never seen or heard of one man devising so many grievous deeds in a single day as Hector, dear to Zeus, has wrought against the sons of Achaeans—neither son of a goddess nor favorite of a god. He has done things that I say will long trouble the Argives; so many evils has he planned for them. Go now, run swiftly to Ajax and Idomeneus beside the ships. I will go to noble Nestor and urge him to rise and come to the

holy watch, and to give the orders. They will obey him most readily, since his son commands among the guards, as does Meriones, Idomeneus' companion; we entrusted the watch chiefly to them."

Menelaus asked: "What do you command me to do? Should I wait here among them until

you return, or run back to you after I have given them your orders?"

Agamemnon answered: "Remain here, so that we do not miss one another among the many

paths through the camp. Call loudly wherever you go, waking each man by his father's name and honoring them all. Do not carry yourself proudly; let us labor ourselves as well. Zeus is surely sending this heavy evil upon us."

He sent his brother away with careful instructions and went to Nestor, shepherd of the people. He found the old man beside his hut and black ship, lying on a soft bed; near him lay his figured shield, two shining spears, and a bright, many-colored belt with which the old man armed himself whenever he led the people into man-destroying war, refusing to yield to grievous old age.

Nestor raised his head on his elbow and asked: "Who are you, walking alone through the camp and the dark night, when other mortals sleep? Are you seeking one of the watchmen, or one of your companions? Speak; do not approach me silently. What do you need?"

Agamemnon answered: "You will recognize me, Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of the Achaeans: Agamemnon, whom Zeus has set among unending labors until breath remains

in my breast and my knees move. I wander because gentle sleep does not settle upon my eyes; war and the cares of the Achaeans consume me. I dread terribly for the Danaans; my heart is not steady, I am shaken, my heart leaps from my breast, and my bright limbs tremble. If you have any plan—for sleep does not visit you either—let us go down among the guards and see that fatigue and sleep have not overcome them so that they have entirely forgotten the watch. The enemy lies close by, and we do not know whether they might even be eager to fight through the night."

Nestor, the Gerenian horseman, replied: "Most glorious son of Atreus, lord of men, Agamemnon, Zeus the counselor will not fulfill every thought Hector now expects.

I think he will suffer still more trouble if Achilles turns his dear heart away from his bitter anger. I will follow you, and we will rouse Tydeus' famous son, Odysseus, swift Ajax, and the brave son of Phyleus. Let someone also go call the godlike Ajax and lord Idomeneus, since their ships are farthest away. I will rebuke Menelaus, dear though he is and worthy of respect, and I will not hide that he sleeps while he has left you alone to labor. He should have worked among all the best men,

begging them, for the need has become intolerable.”

Agamemnon answered: “Old man, at other times I would tell you to blame him; often he gives way and does not wish to labor, neither from cowardice nor from dullness, but watching me and awaiting my impulse. Now he woke before me and came to me first.

I sent him to call those whom you name. Let us go; we will find them before the gates among the guards, where I told them to gather.”

Nestor said: “No Argive will resent or disobey him when he urges and commands.”

He dressed, bound his sandals, fastened a long double crimson cloak with its thick nap, and took a powerful spear sharpened with bronze. He went through the ships of the bronze-clad Achaeans.

First Nestor woke Odysseus, equal in counsel to Zeus. His voice quickly reached the hero’s mind, and Odysseus came out of his shelter, asking: “Why do you wander alone through the ships and the immortal night? What urgent need has come upon you?”

Nestor answered: “Do not be angry, resourceful son of Laertes. Such grief has fallen upon the Achaeans. Come with us, and let us wake another man suited to counsel, whether we must flee or fight.”

Odysseus went into his shelter, slung his patterned shield over his shoulders, and followed them. They came to Diomedes, son of Tydeus, and found him outside his hut with his armor on. His companions slept around him, their shields beneath their heads and their spears planted upright in the butt, the bronze flashing far off like the lightning of father Zeus. The hero slept upon the hide of a field-ox, with a bright rug spread beneath his head.

Nestor stood beside him, nudged him with his foot, and roused and rebuked him: “Wake, son of Tydeus. Why do you waste the whole night in sleep? Do you not hear that the Trojans are camped on the rise of the plain close beside the ships, and that only a little space holds them back?”

Diomedes sprang up quickly and said: “Old man, you are relentless; you never stop working. Are there not younger sons of the Achaeans who could go among the kings and wake each one in turn? You are impossible, old man.”

Nestor answered: “Yes, dear friend, you have spoken rightly. I have blameless sons, and many people, and one of them could go calling. But a great need has fallen upon the Achaeans: now all stand upon a razor’s edge, between grievous death and life.

Go and rouse swift Ajax and the son of Phyleus; you are younger, if you pity me.”

Diomedes wrapped the hide of a great tawny lion around his shoulders, took his spear, and went to rouse them. He led them to the gathered guards. They did not find the leaders of the watch asleep: all sat awake in their armor. As dogs around a sheepfold

lose sleep when they hear a fierce beast moving through the hills, with a great tumult of men and dogs rising against it, so the sweet sleep had vanished from the eyes of the guards as they watched through the evil night, always turning their faces toward the plain whenever they heard the Trojans advancing.

The old man rejoiced when he saw them, encouraged them with his words, and said: “Guard the camp faithfully, dear children; let sleep seize no one, lest we become a joy to our enemies.” He crossed the trench, and the kings of the Argives who had been summoned to council followed him. Meriones and Nestor’s shining son joined them,

for the kings themselves had called them to share the counsel. They crossed the dug trench and sat in a clear place where the ground showed the bodies of those who had fallen, the place from which mighty Hector had turned back, killing Argives, when night first covered the field.

There they sat and spoke among themselves. Nestor began: “Friends, is there some man who trusts his own brave spirit enough to go among the proud Trojans and seize one of the enemy stragglers, or learn some word among the Trojans—what they are planning, whether they intend to remain by the ships away from the city, or withdraw into the city now that they have defeated the Achaeans? If he learned all this and returned unharmed, he would win great fame beneath the sky among all men, and an excellent reward. Every one of the best men who command the ships would give him a black ewe, with a suckling lamb at her side; no possession would equal it, and it would always be present at feasts and banquets.”

All fell silent. Then Diomedes, loud in battle, spoke: “Nestor, my heart and proud spirit urge me to enter the enemy camp, since the hostile men are close. But if some other man would accompany me, the work would be easier and more confident. When two

go together, one sees before the other and finds the advantage; a solitary man, even if he has thought deeply, is slower to discover and weaker in counsel.”

There they sat, and Nestor asked whether some man trusted his own brave heart enough to enter the proud Trojans’ camp, seize an enemy straggler, or learn what the Trojans planned—whether they meant to remain by the ships or withdraw into the city now that they had defeated the Achaeans. If he learned everything and returned unharmed, he would win great fame beneath the sky and a fine reward: each of the best ship-commanders would give him a black ewe with a suckling lamb, a prize that would always attend his feasts and banquets.

All were silent. Diomedes spoke: “Nestor, my heart and proud spirit urge me to enter the enemy camp, since the hostile men are close. But if another man would

come with me, the work would be warmer and more secure. When two go together, one sees first what is to be done; a solitary man, even if he has thought deeply, has a narrower mind and a thinner counsel.”

Many wished to follow him: both Ajaxes, servants of Ares; Meriones; Nestor’s son; Menelaus, famous with the spear; and enduring Odysseus, whose spirit always dared to plunge into the Trojan crowd. Agamemnon answered: “Son of Tydeus, Diomedes, dear to my heart, choose whichever companion you wish, the best of those who have offered themselves. Do not leave the better man behind out of respect for birth, and take the worse because he is more kingly.”

Diomedes answered: “If you command me to choose a companion, how could I forget godlike Odysseus? His heart and proud spirit are ready for every labor, and Pallas Athena loves him. With him beside me we could return even from burning fire, for he understands how to discover a path.”

Odysseus replied: “Do not praise or rebuke me too much; these things are already known among the Argives. Let us go: night is passing, dawn is near, the stars have advanced, more than two parts of the night are gone, and the third alone remains.” They clothed themselves in terrible armor. Thrasymedes gave Diomedes a two-edged sword, since his own had been left beside the ship, and a shield; he set upon his head a bull-hide helmet without boss or crest, called a skull-cap, which protects the heads of young men. Meriones gave Odysseus a bow, quiver, and sword, and set upon his head a helmet made of hide, strengthened inside by many straps and bristling outside with the closely set white teeth of a boar. Autolycus had once taken it from the house of Amyntor son of Ormenus and given it to Amphidamas of Cythera; Amphidamas gave it as a guest-gift to Molus, and Molus gave it to Meriones. Now Meriones gave it to Odysseus, and it covered his head securely.

When they had put on the dreadful armor, they set out, leaving all the best men behind. Pallas Athena sent a heron close beside their road on the right, but they could not see it through the dark; they heard only its cry. Odysseus rejoiced and prayed: “Hear me, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, who stand beside me in every labor and never escape my notice when I am moved. Be with me now above all, and grant that we return to the famous ships after doing a great deed that will trouble the Trojans.”

Diomedes prayed in turn: “Hear me, daughter of Zeus, unconquered Athena. Come with me as when you followed my noble father Tydeus to Thebes, when he went as messenger before the Achaeans. He left the bronze-clad Achaeans beside Asopus and carried a gentle message to the Cadmeans, but on his return he devised terrible deeds with you beside him, divine goddess, standing freely at his side. Stand with me now and

guard me. I will sacrifice to you a broad-browed yearling heifer, unbroken and never brought beneath a man's yoke; I will pour gold over her horns and offer her to you."

So they prayed, and Pallas Athena heard them. They set out like two lions through the black night, through slaughter, among corpses, armor, and dark blood.

Hector did not let the bold Trojans sleep either. He summoned all the leaders and masters of the people and devised a careful plan: "Who will promise to perform this work for a great gift? His reward will be sufficient. I will give a chariot and two long-necked horses, the best beside the swift ships of the Achaeans, to the man who dares approach the ships, learn whether they are guarded as before, or whether, defeated by our hands, the Achaeans are planning flight and do not wish to watch through this terrible fatigue-filled night."

All fell silent. But among the Trojans was Dolon, son of the herald Eumedes, a man rich in gold and bronze, ugly in appearance but swift of foot, the only son among five sisters. He spoke to the Trojans and Hector: "Hector, my heart and proud spirit urge me to approach the swift ships and learn what is there. Raise the scepter for me and swear that you will give me the horses and decorated chariot that carry the blameless son of Peleus. I will not be a useless spy for you; I will go straight through the army until I reach Agamemnon's ship, where the best men are likely now deliberating whether to flee or fight."

Hector took the scepter in his hands and swore: "Let Zeus himself, loud-thundering husband of Hera, witness that no other Trojan will mount those horses; I say you alone will have the glory of them." He swore falsely and roused Dolon. At once Dolon slung his curved bow around his shoulders, wrapped himself in the hide of a gray wolf, set a marten-skin cap upon his head, took a sharp spear, and went from the camp toward the ships. He would not return from the ships to carry his message to Hector.

When he had left the horses and men behind and gone some distance, godlike Odysseus saw him approaching and said to Diomedes: "There is a man coming from the camp. I do not know whether he is a spy for our ships or a plunderer of the dead. Let us first let him pass a little way across the plain; then we can spring upon him and seize him. If his feet outrun us, drive him from the camp toward the ships with your spear, so that he cannot escape toward the city."

They spoke and crouched beside the road among the corpses. Dolon ran past them in reckless haste. When he had gone as far as the tails of mules, which are better than oxen at dragging a well-made plow through deep fallow, the two sprang out. Hearing the noise, he stopped, thinking his companions were returning from the Trojans at Hector's command. But when they were a spear's cast or less away, he recognized hostile men, and his swift knees carried him into flight.

As two sharp-toothed dogs, trained for the hunt, chase a fawn or hare without rest through a wooded place while the creature runs before them crying, so the son of Tydeus and city-sacking Odysseus pursued him without cease. When he was nearly about

to reach the guards fleeing toward the ships, Athena put strength into Diomedes, so that no other bronze-clad Achaean might strike first and claim the glory, leaving him second. Diomedes sprang with his spear and called: “Stop, or I will reach you with my spear; you will not long escape a steep death from my hand.” He threw and deliberately missed. The spear’s polished point passed over Dolon’s right shoulder and fixed itself in the ground. Dolon stopped, struck with terror, his teeth chattering, his skin pale with fear. The two panting men reached him and seized his hands.

Dolon cried through his tears: “Take me alive, and I will ransom myself. At home I have bronze, gold, and much-worked iron; my father would give you an immeasurable ransom if he heard that I was alive among the Achaean ships.”

Resourceful Odysseus answered: “Take courage; let death not be in your heart. Tell me plainly: why have you come alone toward the ships through the dark night, when other mortals sleep? Were you plundering the corpses, or did Hector send you to spy out everything among the hollow ships, or did your own spirit drive you?”

“Hector led me here,” Dolon said, his limbs trembling. “He promised to give me the single-hoofed horses of the great son of Peleus and the chariot worked with bronze. He ordered me to go quickly through the black night to the hostile men and learn whether the swift ships were still guarded as before, or whether the Achaeans, overcome by terrible fatigue and defeated by our hands, were planning flight and did not wish to watch through the night.”

Odysseus smiled: “So your heart was reaching after great gifts—the horses of the warrior Aeacides? They are difficult for mortal men to master or drive, except for Achilles, whose mother is immortal. Now tell us plainly: where did you leave Hector, shepherd of the people? Where are his armor and horses? How are the other Trojans’ guards and beds arranged? What do they plan among themselves—will they remain here by the ships, away from the city, or withdraw into the city after defeating the Achaeans?”

Dolon answered: “I will tell you all of this exactly. Hector is among the counselors, deliberating beside the sacred tomb of Ilus, far from the uproar. The guards you ask about are not assigned and set apart to protect the army. The Trojans whose fires are burning must keep awake and urge one another to watch. But the far-called allies sleep; they have handed the guard to the Trojans, for their children and wives are not close by.”

Odysseus asked: “How do they sleep—mixed among the horse-taming Trojans or apart? Tell me, so that I may know.”

Dolon answered: “Toward the sea lie the Carians, Paeonians with bent bows, Leleges, Caucones, and godlike Pelasgians. Toward Thymbra are the Lycians, haughty Mysians, horse-fighting Phrygians, and Maeonians with their horses. But why do you question me about each one? If you intend to enter the Trojan crowd, the Thracians lie apart, newly arrived and farthest from the others. Their king is Rhesus, son of Eioneus. I saw his horses: the fairest and largest, whiter than snow and swift as the winds. His chariot is beautifully worked in gold and silver, and he brought golden armor, immense and a wonder to behold—not armor for mortal men, but armor that seemed fit for immortal gods. Now take me to the swift ships, or bind me here in a pitiless bond until you return and test whether I have spoken truly.”

Diomedes looked at him grimly: “Do not put flight into your heart, Dolon, though you have brought good news and fallen into our hands. If we released you now, you could come again to the swift ships to spy or fight against us. But if you lose your life under my hands, you will no longer be a trouble to the Argives.”

Dolon reached toward Diomedes’ beard to beg, but Diomedes sprang and struck the middle of his neck with his sword, severing both tendons. Dolon’s head fell into the dust while he was still speaking. Odysseus and Diomedes took from him the marten-skin cap, wolf-hide, back-bent bow, and long spear. Odysseus lifted them high in his hand to Athena, the goddess of spoil: “Hail, goddess. We will give these first among all the immortals in Olympus; but now send us again to the horses and beds of the Thracian men.”

He raised the spoils and placed them upon a tamarisk, marking the place with broken reeds and flowering branches, so that they would not miss it when they returned through the black night. They went onward through armor and dark blood and quickly reached the end of the Thracian men. The Thracians slept, overcome by fatigue; their beautiful weapons lay in order beside them, three ranks deep, and each man had a pair of horses beside him. Rhesus slept in the middle, and his swift horses were tied at the outer edge of his chariot by the reins.

Odysseus saw him first and pointed him out to Diomedes: “There is the man, Diomedes, and there are the horses Dolon told us about. Do not stand here uselessly in your armor. Loosen the horses—or kill the men, and I will attend to the horses.”

Athena, bright-eyed, breathed strength into Diomedes. He struck among the sleeping men, and an ugly groan rose from those cut down; the ground reddened with blood. As a lion leaps upon unwatched sheep or goats with evil intent, so the son of Tydeus went through the Thracians until he had killed twelve. Odysseus, standing behind him,

dragged each man struck by Diomedes aside by the foot, thinking that the horses with their beautiful manes might pass easily and not grow afraid when they trampled the dead, since they were not yet used to the slaughter.

When Diomedes reached the king, he took away his sweet life as he gasped for breath; a bad dream had stood above him through the night, sent by Athena's counsel. Odysseus loosed the horses from the chariot and tied them together with the reins. He did not drive them out of the camp, fearing that, unaccustomed to the dead, they might shy. While Odysseus was loosening the single-hoofed horses, gathering them with the reins, and driving them out of the crowd by flicking his bow because he had not thought to take the bright whip from the decorated chariot, Diomedes stood wondering what bold deed he should do next—drag away the chariot where the beautiful armor lay, or lift it high and carry it out, or take the lives of still more Thracians.

As he considered, Athena stood close beside him and spoke: "Remember the return, son of great-hearted Tydeus, to the hollow ships, lest another god awaken the Trojans and you come back in fear." Diomedes understood the goddess' voice, quickly mounted the horses, and Odysseus struck them with his bow. They flew toward the swift ships. Apollo, god of the silver bow, saw Athena following the son of Tydeus and, angered, plunged among the Trojan crowd and roused Hippocoon, a noble cousin of Rhesus. When

he sprang from sleep and saw the deserted place where the swift horses had stood and the men dying in the harsh slaughter, he groaned and called his companion by name. Then clamor and measureless uproar rose among the Trojans as they rushed together, marveling at the terrible deed those men had done before going to the hollow ships. When the two reached the place where they had killed Hector's spy, Odysseus halted the swift horses. Diomedes leaped to the ground, placed the bloody spoils in Odysseus' hands, mounted again, and lashed the horses. They flew willingly toward the hollow ships, for that was dear to their hearts.

Before the words were finished, Nestor heard the thunder of swift horses and called: "Friends, leaders and masters of the Argives, shall I tell a falsehood or speak the truth? My ears are struck by the pounding of swift-footed horses. If only Odysseus and mighty Diomedes were driving horses from the Trojans in this way! Yet I fear terribly that the best of the Argives have suffered beneath the Trojan uproar."

Before he could finish, the men themselves arrived. They climbed down from the horses, and the chiefs greeted them with right hands and gentle words. Nestor first asked renowned Odysseus, great glory of the Achaeans: "Tell me how you took these horses. Did you enter the Trojan crowd and take them, or did some god meet you and give them to you? They shine like rays of the sun. I mingle with the Trojans often,

though I am an old warrior and do not remain idle beside the ships, but I have never seen or imagined horses like these. I think a god gave them to you on meeting you, for Zeus the cloud-gatherer loves you both, and so does Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus.”

Resourceful Odysseus answered: “A god who wished it could easily give even better horses, old man, for these are far superior. These are Thracian horses newly arrived; the good Diomedes killed their king and twelve of his best companions. The thirteenth was the spy near the ships, the man whom Hector and the other splendid Trojans sent to scout our army.”

With that he drove the single-hoofed horses across the trench, laughing aloud, and the other rejoicing Achaeans followed. When they reached Diomedes’ well-built hut, they tied the horses with carefully cut straps at the manger where Diomedes’ swift horses stood eating tender wheat. Odysseus placed Dolon’s bloody spoils in the stern of the ship, intending to prepare them as a sacred offering for Athena. They stepped into the sea and washed the sweat from their legs, shoulders, and thighs. When the sea’s wave had cleansed their heavy sweat and cooled their hearts, they entered the polished bathing tubs, washed, and anointed themselves richly with oil. Then they sat down to supper, and from a full mixing bowl they poured sweet wine as a libation to Athena.

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BOOK II

First-pass working translation

Dawn rose from the bed of noble Tithonus, bringing light to immortals and mortals. But Zeus sent Strife to the swift ships of the Achaeans, a sign of war holding its violence in both hands. She stood upon Odysseus' great black ship, midway between the stations of Ajax son of Telamon and Achilles, whose ships lay at the two ends, trusting in their courage and strength. There she cried aloud, a great and terrible cry, and put unwearied strength for battle into every Achaean heart. War became sweeter to them than sailing home in the hollow ships to their beloved fatherland. Agamemnon shouted and ordered the Argives to arm. He himself clothed his body in bright bronze. First he fastened beautiful greaves with silver ankle-pieces around his shins; then he put on the breastplate that Cinyras had given him as a guest-gift. Cinyras had heard in Cyprus that the Achaeans would sail to Troy, and had given it to please the king. Ten dark-blue bands ran around it, twelve of gold, and twenty of tin; three dark-blue serpents rose toward the neck on either side, like rainbows that the son of Cronus sets in a cloud as a sign to mortals.

Around his shoulders he hung a sword with golden nails and a silver scabbard held by golden straps. He took a great shield, elaborate and terrible, with ten bronze rings around it and twenty white bosses of tin, a dark-blue boss at the center. Upon it was the grim-eyed Gorgon, and around her were Deimos and Phobos; a silver strap held it, and a dark-blue serpent twisted along it, with three heads growing from one neck. He set upon his head a four-bossed, horse-haired helmet with a dreadful crest, and took two powerful spears sharpened with bronze. The bronze flashed toward heaven,

while Athena and Hera thundered in honor of the king of golden Mycenae.

Each man instructed his charioteer to hold the horses in good order by the trench; the foot soldiers, armed in their armor, surged forward, and an unquenchable cry rose before morning. The chariots reached the trench first; the horsemen followed a little behind. From above Zeus sent a bloody mist of dew from the clear air, because many strong heads were destined to be sent to Hades.

On the other side, the Trojans gathered around great Hector, blameless Polydamas, Aeneas, honored among the Trojans like a god, and the three sons of Antenor—Polybus, shining Agenor, and Acamas, like the immortals. Hector carried a shield even on all sides, appearing at times among the foremost like a baleful star that shines out from a cloud and at times sinks again into shadow. So he appeared in the front ranks

and then at the rear, giving orders; all his bronze flashed like the lightning of aegis-bearing Zeus.

Trojans and Achaeans rushed upon one another like reapers driving their rows against each other through the field of a wealthy man, cutting wheat or barley, while the dense handfuls fall. They slaughtered one another, and neither side remembered ruinous flight. The battle held equal heads, and the fighters rushed like wolves. Strife alone rejoiced as she watched; none of the other gods came among them, but sat at ease in their own halls on Olympus. All blamed dark-clouded Cronus' son because he meant to give glory to the Trojans. The father did not care; he sat apart, rejoicing in his power, watching the city of Troy and the ships of the Achaeans, the flash of bronze, the killing and the killed.

While morning lasted and the sacred day grew strong, missiles struck both sides and men fell. But when a woodcutter has prepared his meal among the mountain valleys, his hands tired from cutting tall trees and his desire for food has come upon him, then the Danaans, calling to their companions rank by rank, broke the battalions. Agamemnon sprang first. He killed Bienor, shepherd of the people, who leapt from his horses and stood against him; Agamemnon drove his spear straight through his forehead, and the heavy bronze passed through the bone and scattered his brains. Then he struck Oileus, the horse-driver, as he came upon him, and left both men there, their shining breastplates stripped.

He went on to kill Isus and Antiphus, two sons of Priam in one chariot, one illegitimate and the other born in wedlock. Achilles had once found them tending sheep on Ida, bound them with willow and released them for ransom. Now Agamemnon struck Isus in the chest and Antiphus beside the ear with his sword, casting him from the horses.

He hurried to strip their beautiful armor, recognizing it from the time Achilles had brought them from Ida. As a lion easily seizes the tender young of a swift deer when it finds the hidden lair, while the mother flees trembling through the dense wood, so no one could save the Trojans; they themselves fled before the Argives.

Agamemnon then seized Pisander and strong Hippolochus, sons of warlike Antimachus, who had received splendid gold from Alexander and refused to let fair-haired Menelaus have Helen returned. The king took both in one chariot; their horses fled from their hands, and they, bewildered, fell to their knees before him: "Take us alive, son of Atreus, and accept a worthy ransom. Many treasures lie in the house of Antimachus—bronze, gold, and much-worked iron. Our father would give you immeasurable ransom if

he heard that we were alive among the Achaean ships."

Agamemnon answered without mercy: “If you are the sons of Antimachus, who once urged the Trojans in their assembly to kill Menelaus and godlike Odysseus when they came as messengers, then you shall now pay your father’s shame.” He struck Pisander in the chest and threw him from the horses; Hippolochus sprang down, and he cut off his hands and neck and sent his body rolling through the crowd like a stone from a hill. He left them and rushed wherever the ranks were thickest, with the other bronze-clad Achaeans. Footmen killed fleeing footmen, horsemen killed horsemen; dust rose beneath the pounding hooves as bronze dealt death, while Agamemnon followed always, shouting and urging the Argives.

As an irresistible fire runs through a dry forest when a wind drives it everywhere and the shrubs fall root and branch before its force, so Trojan heads fell under Agamemnon, and many high-necked horses rattled their empty chariots through the battle, longing for their blameless drivers. The men lay on the ground, dearer to the vultures than to their wives.

Zeus drew Hector away from the spears, the dust, the slaughter, and the blood. But Agamemnon pressed hard after the Danaans, shouting and commanding them. They raced

across the plain beside the ancient tomb of Dardanian Ilus and the fig tree, eager for the city; Hector followed crying out, his hands stained with blood. When they reached the Skaian Gates and the beech tree, the Trojans halted and gathered their lines, while many still fled through the middle of the plain like cattle a lion has terrified in the darkness; he catches one by the neck and first breaks it with his powerful teeth, then devours its blood and entrails. So Agamemnon pursued the last of them, always killing, and the Trojans fled.

When the army was about to reach the city and its steep wall, Zeus, father of men and gods, sat upon the heights of Ida, having come down from heaven, holding the thunderbolt. He sent Iris of the golden wings with a message to Hector: “Go, swift Iris, and tell Hector this: while he sees Agamemnon, shepherd of the people, raging among the foremost and cutting the ranks of men, let him withdraw and order the rest of the army to fight in the strong battle. But when Agamemnon is struck with a spear or an arrow and leaps into his horses, then I will give Hector the strength to kill until he reaches the well-benched ships, until the sun goes down and holy darkness arrives.”

Swift, wind-footed Iris obeyed and went down from Ida to holy Ilium. She found Hector, son of Priam, standing among his horses and joined chariots, and spoke near him: “Hector, son of Priam, equal in counsel to Zeus, father Zeus sent me to tell you:

while you see Agamemnon raging among the foremost and cutting the ranks of men, yield before the battle and command the rest to fight the enemy in the strong clash. But when he is struck with spear or arrow and leaps into his horses, then Zeus will give you power to kill until you reach the ships, until the sun goes down and holy darkness comes.”

Hector leapt from his chariot, shook his sharp spears, and went everywhere through the army urging battle, raising the hateful fight. The ranks wheeled and stood opposite one another, while the Argives strengthened their own lines. The battle was set, and Agamemnon sprang first, eager to fight far before all the rest.

Tell me now, Muses who hold the halls of Olympus, who first came against Agamemnon,

whether Trojan or famous ally. It was Iphidamas, son of Antenor, noble and great, raised in fertile Thrace, mother of sheep. His mother’s father Cisseus had brought him up in his house when he was small; when he reached glorious manhood, Cisseus kept him there and gave him his daughter. After marrying her, Iphidamas came from the bridal chamber with fame, bringing twelve curved ships; he left them at Perkote and had come on foot to Ilium. He now faced Agamemnon.

When they came close, Agamemnon’s spear missed and turned aside, but Iphidamas struck

below the belt of the breastplate and leaned his weight upon the blow. The spear did not pierce the many-colored belt; it turned like lead against silver. Agamemnon seized it with his broad hand, tugged like a lion, and pulled it from Iphidamas’ grasp; then he struck his neck with the sword and loosened his limbs. Iphidamas fell there and slept the bronze sleep, far from his bride, for whom he had given much and received no joy: first a hundred cattle, then a thousand goats and sheep, which he promised to her father’s household.

Agamemnon stripped his armor and carried it through the Achaean crowd. But when Coon, eldest son of Antenor and distinguished among men, saw his brother fall, grief covered his eyes. He stood beside Agamemnon unseen and struck him in the middle of the arm below the elbow; the spear point passed through. The lord of men shuddered, but did not leave the battle. He rushed upon Coon with his wind-raised spear, while Coon dragged his brother Iphidamas by the foot and called to all the best men. As he dragged him beneath the bossed shield, Agamemnon struck him with the bronze spear and

loosened his limbs; then he stood beside him and cut off his head. Thus the two sons of Antenor fulfilled their fate beneath the hand of the son of Atreus and entered the house of Hades.

Agamemnon moved through the other ranks with spear, sword, and great stones, while the blood still rose warm from his wound. But when the wound dried and the blood stopped, sharp pains entered the king's strength, like the pain a woman in labor feels when the daughters of Hera, the harsh birth-powers, send the cutting pangs. The pain entered Agamemnon's strength. He leapt into his chariot and ordered his driver to take him toward the hollow ships, for his heart was troubled. He called aloud to the Danaans: "Friends, leaders and masters of the Argives, now defend the seafaring ships against this hateful battle. Zeus the counselor has not allowed me to fight the Trojans all day." His driver lashed the long-maned horses; they flew willingly toward the ships, foam on their chests and dust beneath them, carrying the king away from the battle, exhausted by war.

When Hector saw Agamemnon leaving, he called loudly to Trojans, Lycians, and Dardanians

who fight at close quarters: "Be men, my friends, and remember your warlike strength. The best man has gone; Zeus the son of Cronus has given me great glory. Drive your single-hoofed horses straight against the strong Danaans and win a greater glory."

He roused the spirit of each man, and rushed upon the Achaeans like a hunter setting white-toothed dogs against a wild boar or lion. Hector, son of Priam, equal to deadly Ares, drove the great-hearted Trojans upon the Achaeans. He himself went among the foremost, falling upon the battle like a fierce wind that leaps upon the violet sea and stirs it up.

The battle broke over the Achaeans. Hector drove them toward the wall.

Diomedes struck Agastrophus, but Paris wounded him in the foot with an arrow. Diomedes cried to Odysseus, and they stood together.

Odysseus was left alone when the men around him fell. He fought until Socus pierced his shield and tore his side. Odysseus killed Socus, but blood ran down his body. He called for help, and the Ajaxes came. Nestor carried Machaon away from the battle. Achilles saw the chariot and sent Patroclus to ask who was wounded. Nestor said:

"Machaon is hurt. Bring him to your tent, and let the healer tend him. The army is collapsing. Achilles remains apart, though we need him. Perhaps you could persuade him to return, or enter the fight yourself wearing his armor, so the Trojans may fear the sight."

Patroclus ran back. He passed the wounded Eurypylus, who begged:

"Take me to your tent. Draw the arrow from my thigh, wash the blood, and bind me with medicine. I learned from Achilles how to heal."

Patroclus obeyed, while Hector drove the Argives to their ships.

The dust rose, and the sea shone behind the fleeing men.
The wounded commanders gathered in their shelters: Agamemnon,
Diomedes, and Odysseus. They were unable to fight, but still gave counsel.
Agamemnon said: "Our wall has not held. The ships are in danger.
Call Achilles, if he will listen."
The Achaeans formed again by the ditch. Ajax held the front,
while Hector sought a way through. Zeus watched from Ida,
and sent terror into the hearts of the Argives.
Patroclus returned to Achilles' tent. He found Eurypylus bleeding,
and cut out the arrow, washed the wound with warm water,
and laid bitter herbs upon it. The herbs stopped the blood,
but Eurypylus' pain did not cease.
Achilles saw Patroclus' tears and asked: "Why do you weep?
You look like a girl running beside her mother, begging to be held.
Do not hide it. Tell me what the army suffers."
Patroclus answered: "Achilles, you have a cruel heart. The wounded
fill the ships. Agamemnon, Diomedes, and Odysseus cannot fight.
Machaon is hurt, and Eurypylus lies bleeding here. I wish you would
return. If not, let me wear your armor, and lead the Myrmidons.
The Trojans may mistake me for you, and the army may breathe again."
Achilles replied: "I am not yet ready to forgive Agamemnon.
But take the armor, and lead the men only as far as the ships.
Do not pursue the Trojans to the wall. If you go farther,
you will win me honor but bring death upon yourself."
He watched the battle through the tent's opening. The armor lay ready,
and Patroclus' request began to move the story toward its catastrophe.

Source range: Book 11. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 12

First-pass working translation

While Patroclus was tending the wounded, Hector led the Trojans against the wall. It had been built to protect the ships, but the gods had not ordained that it endure forever.

Polydamas spoke: "Hector, our horses cannot cross the trench. It is deep and sharp with stakes. Let us leave the chariots behind, and send the footmen forward in close ranks. If we scatter, the Achaeans will cut us down."

Hector agreed, and ordered the chariots to remain. Five companies moved toward the wall. As a lion enters a fold and the shepherds flee, so the Trojans came on, each man trusting the strength of his neighbor. At the wall, Sarpedon urged Glaucus: "Why do they honor us in Lycia? Why do we receive the best portions and the full cups of wine? Because we must stand in the foremost ranks. Let us show our people that their kings are not only great in name."

They advanced. Sarpedon tore away the battlement stone; the wall opened before him. Glaucus was wounded in the arm, but Apollo eased the pain when he prayed. The Lycian ranks followed. Ajax and Teucer defended the gate. Ajax called to his brother: "Hold the bow and shoot the captains. I will carry the shield. If the Trojans reach the ships, our return is gone."

Teucer shot Cleobulus and Lycophron, then struck Orsilochus. Hector came against him and shattered his bow with a stone. Ajax covered Teucer as the brothers withdrew.

The Trojan companies pressed at the wall. As a woodcutter's axe cuts through an oak, so a great stone broke the battlement. The Greeks defended every opening, but the Trojans climbed. Polydamas saw a hawk carrying a serpent. The snake twisted and struck the bird; blood fell from the hawk's breast, and it dropped the serpent among the warriors. Polydamas said:

"This is a sign. We may enter the wall, but we will not leave safely. The snake will make us suffer, even if the hawk carries us forward." Hector answered: "You are always afraid of omens. One sign is not the will of Zeus. I know what I must do. Follow me, and do not delay."

Hector lifted a massive boulder. Two men could scarcely carry it, but he raised it alone, and hurled it at the gate. The hinges broke. The doors swung inward, and the Trojans entered like a storm. The Achaeans fled from the wall. Hector shouted to the Trojans: “Bring fire to the ships. We have reached the first defense. Now the Argives must choose between the sea and the spear.” The dust rose around the broken gate. The wall that had promised protection became a passage for the enemy. The Achaeans held at the ships, and Hector’s voice carried toward the sea.

Source range: Book 12. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 13

First-pass working translation

When Zeus turned his eyes toward Troy, Poseidon saw the Achaeans driven hard against the ships. He pitied them, and went from Samothrace to the plain, taking the form of Calchas. He moved among the leaders, calling them to stand: “The wall has fallen, but the army has not. Hold the line at the ships, and the Trojans will not break you.” Ajax answered first, and Idomeneus joined him. Meriones brought men from Crete. The two Ajaxes held the foremost place, like two boars turning upon hounds. They drove back the Trojans and recovered bodies. Hector came against them, leading the ranks. Deiphobus cast his spear at Idomeneus, but missed and killed Ascalaphus. Idomeneus killed Deiphobus' charioteer. The armies closed around the dead. Meriones struck Acamas. Idomeneus killed Othryoneus, who had promised to drive the Achaeans away and marry Cassandra without a bride-price. Idomeneus mocked him: “Let the ground be your wedding bed.” The battle spread. Antilochus killed the son of Hicetaon; Hector killed a companion of Ajax. Aeneas and Idomeneus met like lions over a carcass. Neither yielded, and the dust rose between them. Poseidon moved through the Achaean ranks in secret. He touched the hearts of the leaders, reminding each man of his courage. The Argives returned to the fight. They stood around the ships in a wall of shields. Hector urged the Trojans: “Do not scatter. Break the ranks at the ships. If one man falls, another must stand over him. Zeus has promised us victory.” Polydamas warned him: “The lines are confused. Call the leaders together, and do not drive the men beyond their strength.” Hector answered: “You always counsel delay. The time for words has passed.” The Trojans struck the Achaean shields. Ajax killed Caletor; Hector threw a stone and broke the spear of Ajax. The Trojans pressed, but Ajax shouted: “Friends, remember your fathers. If we flee, the ships will burn, and our children will have no home.” The Achaeans tightened their line. As a wall stands before the sea, so the shield-wall stood. The spear points flashed, and men fell between the benches of the ships. The battle moved from open ground into the narrow place where a ship's hull became a soldier's shelter.

Hector and Ajax met again. Hector struck Ajax's shield; Ajax struck Hector's breastplate. They separated, but the struggle did not end. Zeus kept his mind on Hector, and Poseidon strengthened the Argives. The Trojans drew back briefly. The Achaeans carried their dead away. But Hector gathered the men, and the fighting returned before the ships. The sea thundered behind the line, and the Achaeans fought as men who have nowhere left to retreat.

Source range: Book 13. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 14

First-pass working translation

Nestor came from the battle, carrying the wounded Machaon.
He met Diomedes and Odysseus, and told them the ships were threatened.
Agamemnon said: "Our wall has failed. We must launch and flee."
Odysseus rebuked him: "Your mind is broken by fear. Do not send
the army to the sea. Stand among them, and we may still prevail."
Agamemnon took heart, and the three went back toward the fight.
Hera saw Zeus watching the field from Ida. She desired to distract him,
that Poseidon might aid the Achaeans. She went to Aphrodite:
"Give me the girdle of desire, where every charm is woven—love,
longing, and speech that makes the hardest heart yield."
Aphrodite gave it. Hera visited Sleep and promised him a golden throne
if he would cast Zeus into slumber. He feared the god's anger,
but accepted. Hera crossed to Ida, perfumed and crowned, and Zeus saw her.
He asked: "Why have you come? You have never looked more beautiful.
Desire has seized me more strongly than in the first hour we loved."
She answered: "I am going to Oceanus, to visit the parents who raised me.
You are free to sleep beside me if you wish."
Zeus embraced her. Golden cloud covered them, and the earth bloomed.
Sleep stood behind him and touched his eyes. Zeus slept deeply.
Poseidon entered the Achaean ranks. He cried: "Now is the hour.
The Argives have not forgotten courage. Let every man hold his place."
The Trojans fell back. Ajax struck Hector with a stone in the chest.
Hector fell, gasping, and the Trojans carried him away.
The Achaeans surged like a wave. Ajax called: "Bring fire to the ships?
No—let the Trojans meet us at the wall they broke." The Trojans turned,
and many died beneath the spear. Hector lay outside the battle,
breathing hard while the lines moved around him.
Apollo came to him, and gave him strength. He cried:
"Rise. Zeus has not abandoned Troy." He drove terror into the Argives,
and the Trojans returned. Ajax and Hector met again, but the god's aid
made Hector terrible. The Achaeans gave ground toward the sea.
Zeus woke. He saw the Trojans driven back and knew Hera's deceit.
He called Iris: "Go to Poseidon. Tell him to leave the battle."

Tell Apollo to strengthen Hector. The day will belong to Troy.”

Poseidon answered Iris: “Zeus is not my master alone. The three brothers share the world. Yet he is older, and I will not throw heaven into war.”

He withdrew to the sea, angry but obedient.

Apollo entered the fight openly. He carried the aegis, and the Achaeans shrank before it. Hector raised his spear and broke the wall's gate.

The Trojans poured through. The ships stood exposed, and fire was near.

Source range: Book 14. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 15

First-pass working translation

Zeus woke on Ida and saw the Trojans pressed toward the ships.
He understood Hera's deception. He spoke to her in anger:
"You have done this, and Poseidon has entered the battle.
But the hour has come for the Argives to suffer. Send Iris to him;
let Apollo restore Hector's courage and drive the army forward.
The Trojans will reach the ships, and Patroclus will be moved to act."
Hera descended from Ida and returned to Olympus. Zeus sent Iris
to the sea. Poseidon answered: "I will not resist the elder's will.
But remember: we share the world, and my anger will remain."
Apollo found Hector beyond the battle, still weak from Ajax's blow.
He stood before him and covered him with a mist. Hector rose,
and Apollo gave him the aegis. The Achaeans saw it and fled.
Apollo struck down the wall before Hector. The stones fell,
and the Trojans poured through. Hector called to the men:
"Let the ships be our prize. Bring fire; do not stop for armor.
If one man turns aside, let the next kill him."
Ajax stood upon the deck of a ship, calling to the Achaeans:
"Do not retreat. Keep the fire from the vessels. Hector is strong,
but we are many. Stand with me." He struck the Trojans with a pole,
and the ship's deck became a fortress.
Hector seized a stone and shattered the gates of a ship. The Trojans
carried torches. The Argives defended the hulls with spears and axes.
Ajax killed many men, but Hector kept coming like a storm.
The fire reached the ship of Protesilaus. Hector threw a torch
upon the stern, and the flame ran through the dry timbers.
Patroclus saw it from Achilles' tent, and struck his thigh:
"Achilles, the ships are burning. If we wait, we will have no camp.
Let me take the Myrmidons. Give me your armor, so the Trojans
will think you have returned. I will drive them from the ships,
but I will obey your command and not approach the city."
Achilles answered: "Go. The army needs you. Tell the men to fight.
I will pray for your return. Do not chase them beyond the wall."
Patroclus armed the Myrmidons. He gave his father's armor to the heralds,

and they carried it out. The men looked upon it and rejoiced.
The horses stamped, and the troops formed beneath the borrowed sign.
Hector and Ajax fought around the burning ship. The Trojans shouted,
but the sight of Achilles' armor turned their hearts. They believed
the terrible man had entered the battle again. The Achaeans advanced.
The fire was beaten down. Hector's courage faltered, but he called
the Trojans to follow. Patroclus drove them from the ships,
and the battle rolled across the plain. The day had turned,
but the fate of the borrowed armor was already moving toward death.

Source range: Book 15. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 16

First-pass working translation

Patroclus came to Achilles in tears. “You are like a father who refuses his child. Let me wear your armor. The Trojans will think you have returned, and the Achaeans will breathe. I will drive them from the ships, but I will not approach the wall.”

Achilles answered: “I do not refuse you from anger. Take the armor, and take the Myrmidons. When the fire is gone from the ships, return. Do not chase glory beyond what I have commanded.”

He armed Patroclus in the shining armor. The horses stamped; Automedon took the reins. Achilles stood before the troops:

“Remember your strength. Do not fight like children. Patroclus will lead. When the Trojans see this armor, they will flee from the ships.”

Patroclus prayed to Zeus, and the Myrmidons came out like wolves.

Achilles watched them march, wishing the gods would grant their return.

Patroclus drove toward the ships. The Trojans saw Achilles' armor and fell back. The fire was beaten down. Ajax and his men rejoiced.

Patroclus killed Pyraechmes and drove the Trojans from the hulls.

Apollo warned Hector: “Do not meet Patroclus yet. The hour is not ready.”

Hector left the battle, but the Trojan ranks broke. Sarpedon saw them flee and called Glaucus: “We must stand for Lycia. Let us defend our people.”

Patroclus and Sarpedon met. Sarpedon threw first and missed;

Patroclus struck Thrasymelus, his companion. Sarpedon cast again, but Patroclus pierced him beneath the ribs. He fell like an oak.

He called to Glaucus: “Do not leave me. Call the Lycians to defend my body. If they strip my armor, the disgrace will be greater than death.”

Glaucus prayed to Apollo, and the god healed his wound. He rallied the Lycians, while Zeus looked at his son and considered saving him.

Hera warned Zeus: “If you rescue Sarpedon, the other gods will demand the same. Let his fate stand. Send Sleep and Death to carry him home.”

Zeus sent Apollo. The god washed Sarpedon and gave him to the twins, who bore him to Lycia. The armies fought over his armor.

Patroclus drove the Trojans toward the city. Achilles' warning faded behind the noise of battle. He killed Cebriones, Hector's charioteer, and mocked Hector over the body. Hector seized a spear, but Patroclus

escaped the throw. They fought like fire and wind.
Apollo struck Patroclus from behind, knocked away his helmet,
and broke the spear in his hands. Euphorbus wounded him;
Hector came and drove the final spear beneath his belly.
Patroclus said: "Hector, you are proud of my death. But Achilles
will kill you. He is near, and your day is short."
Hector answered: "You are no longer protected by Achilles. He is far away,
and I have taken your life." He stripped the armor from Patroclus.
Patroclus fell. The Achaeans and Trojans fought over his body.
Menelaus stood first, killing Euphorbus. Hector wore Achilles' armor,
but Zeus had already marked the day when it would betray him.

Source range: Book 16. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 17

First-pass working translation

Menelaus stood over Patroclus and killed Euphorbus,
the first man to wound him. He stripped the bright armor,
but Hector saw him and came across the field. Menelaus withdrew,
calling Ajax to guard the body. The Trojans and Achaeans closed around it.
Hector wore Achilles' armor, shining like a star. He drove toward
Patroclus, wanting both the body and the name that came with the armor.
Ajax cried to Menelaus: "Stand beside me. We must not let the Trojans
carry him away. The dead man is our friend, and his body is our shame."
The battle became a storm around Patroclus. Hector seized the horses,
but Automedon drove them away. The Achaeans dragged the body backward;
the Trojans pulled it forward. Neither side could gain ground.
Glaucus rebuked Hector: "You have forgotten Sarpedon.
We guarded his body, but you wear the armor of Achilles
and leave Patroclus for others. Call the Trojans back."
Hector answered: "Do not accuse me. I will take the body,
and Zeus may grant me strength." He called Aeneas and the sons of Priam.
The Achaeans defended the corpse. Menelaus sent Antilochus to tell
Achilles that Patroclus had fallen. Ajax and Meriones lifted the body;
Ajax carried the weight on his shoulders while Meriones fought behind.
Hector rushed them. Ajax turned, and Hector retreated. The dust rose,
and Zeus darkened the day. The Trojans saw Patroclus almost within reach.
Automedon could not control the horses, which had belonged to Achilles.
They stood still, grieving for Patroclus. Zeus considered giving them
to Hector, but Hera held them back. Automedon called Alcimedon,
who mounted beside him. They returned to battle.
Hector pursued them and tried to seize the chariot. Automedon killed
Hector's companion, and the Trojans drew back. The Achaeans renewed
their defense of the body.
Apollo entered the fight, wearing the shape of a warrior. He struck
Menelaus, then urged Hector onward. The Trojans came like a dark wave.
Ajax and Menelaus stood together, but the gods turned the balance.
Menelaus sent Antilochus again to Achilles. Antilochus ran through
the ranks and cried: "Patroclus is dead. Hector wears your armor."

The Trojans fight for the body. Come, or we cannot hold him.”
Achilles' horses mourned. Thetis had given them to her son,
and they knew the death that had come beneath borrowed arms.
Zeus spoke to them: “Why did I give you to a mortal king?
No horse is more sorrowful than you. The man you carried is gone.”
He made them swift again. They carried Automedon and the chariot
back to the fight, while Zeus sent a cloud over the battlefield.
Night approached, but the struggle did not cease. The Trojans pulled
at Patroclus, and the Achaeans resisted. The body was like a wall
between the armies, and every man who touched it entered the war's center.
At last the Achaeans carried Patroclus from the field.
Hector and the Trojans kept Achilles' armor, believing victory had come.
But the armor was not a man, and its brightness would not save Hector
when Achilles returned.

Source range: Book 17. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 18

First-pass working translation

Antilochus came to Achilles and told him that Patroclus was dead. Achilles' knees failed. He seized dust in both hands and poured it over his head. His dark hair was soiled, and he lay upon the ground, tearing his face. His mother had once given him that hair for the river; now he offered it to Patroclus.

Thetis heard him beneath the sea and came with her sisters.

Achilles said: "Mother, Patroclus is dead. Hector wears my armor.

I was not there. I sent him out, and he will never return.

I have no reason to live if I cannot punish Hector."

Thetis answered: "You know what follows. If you kill Hector, your own death will come soon after. Stay, and you may live."

Achilles replied: "Let it come. I cannot remain while my friend lies unburied. I will go now, though I have no armor. Perhaps the sight of me will make the Trojans release the body."

The Achaeans mourned Patroclus. Iris came from Hera and told Achilles:

"Do not enter the battle unarmed. Athena will cover you with fire.

Stand by the trench and show yourself."

Achilles went to the wall. Athena set a golden cloud around his head and made a flame rise from him. He cried three times. The Trojans heard and terror seized them; horses broke their lines, and the dead were left.

The Achaeans recovered Patroclus' body and carried him to the tent.

Hector called a council. Polydamas said: "Let us return to Troy.

Achilles will enter the battle. We cannot stand before him."

Hector answered: "You counsel fear. We will remain in the field."

The Trojans ate and kept watch. The Achaeans gathered around Patroclus.

Achilles ordered that no one wash his body yet. He cut the throat of a bull and placed the dead man's hair upon the bier. He promised Patroclus:

"I will not bury you until I bring Hector's head and armor here."

Thetis went to Olympus and asked Hephaestus to make new armor.

He forged a shield vast as the moon, and upon it placed the earth, the sea, the sky, the sun, moon, and all the stars.

He made two cities. In one, weddings and dances filled the streets; flutes sounded, and torches led the brides from their chambers.

But outside the walls two men disputed a blood-price. Elders sat
 upon polished stones, and a herald held the scepter as each spoke.
 In the other city an army lay in ambush. The attackers drove cattle
 from the fields; shepherds and dogs defended them. War broke out
 beside the river, and a dark fate stood over the men.
 He made a fallow field, rich and dark, where plowmen turned the earth.
 They looked back as they reached the boundary, and a steward gave them wine.
 He made a king's estate where reapers cut the wheat; young men bound it,
 and a woman served them food beneath an oak.
 He made a vineyard heavy with grapes. Boys carried baskets;
 a child played a lyre, and the harvesters sang. He made a herd of cattle,
 with a bull leading them. Lions attacked; dogs and herdsmen pursued,
 but the lions tore the bull and drank its blood.
 He made a sheepfold in a beautiful valley. He made a dancing floor,
 where youths and maidens moved in circles, and the people watched.
 Around the rim he set Oceanus, the river that encircles the world.
 He gave the armor to Thetis. She descended like a hawk and brought it
 to Achilles. The bronze shone before the Achaeans. All feared its beauty.
 Achilles called an assembly: "Agamemnon, let our anger end.
 Briseis and the gifts may return. I thought only of Patroclus.
 Now my heart is set upon battle."
 Agamemnon answered: "I was blinded. Zeus and Delusion deceived me.
 Let the gifts be brought. Briseis is untouched. I swear it."
 The gifts came, and Briseis saw Patroclus on the bier. She wept:
 "You were kind to me when Achilles took me from my city.
 You promised that I would become his wife. Now both hope and kindness
 are gone." The women mourned with her.
 Achilles would not eat. Zeus sent Athena to fill his heart with nectar,
 so hunger would not weaken him. He mounted his chariot and called:
 "Xanthus and Balius, bring me back from battle. Do not leave me there
 as you left Patroclus." The immortal horse answered:
 "We will carry you, but a god and fate will kill you."
 Achilles entered the field, wearing the armor that would lead him
 to Hector and then to his own appointed death.

Source range: Book 18. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 19

First-pass working translation

Dawn rose from the sea, and Achilles called the Achaeans to assembly.
He stood beside the ships and said: “Let our anger end. Agamemnon,
return Briseis. The dead have made all private quarrels small.”
Agamemnon answered: “I was blinded by Ate, the power that misleads.
Zeus himself has been deceived by her. I will return the girl,
and give the gifts promised before. Let the heralds bring them.”
The gifts came: tripods, gold, cauldrons, cities' treasure,
and Briseis. She entered Achilles' tent and saw Patroclus dead.
She wept: “You were kind to me, though Achilles took me from my home.
I thought I would become his wife. Now I mourn you, and the man who fell.”
Achilles did not eat. He looked toward the battle and said:
“Patroclus, you will not go unavenged. Hector's life will pay for yours.”
Zeus sent Athena to strengthen him with nectar and ambrosia,
so hunger would not weaken his limbs. The army armed itself.
Menelaus asked whether the Achaeans should eat before battle.
Achilles answered: “No food can enter me while my friend lies dead.
Let the others eat. I will fight until Hector falls.”
Agamemnon and Achilles stood before the people. They clasped hands,
but did not embrace. Agamemnon swore Briseis remained untouched.
The army returned to its ranks, eager for the field.
Achilles put on the armor Hephaestus had made. The greaves clasped
his legs; the corselet covered his chest; the helmet shone like a star.
He lifted the shield whose surface held the whole world.
His horses trembled. Achilles spoke to them: “Do not leave me dead
as you left Patroclus.” The horse Xanthus answered in human speech:
“We will carry you swiftly, but a god and fate will take your life.
It is not our fault; the deathless power will bring you down.”
Achilles replied: “I know. I will not turn back. Let us meet Hector.”
He drove into the battle, and the Achaeans followed him.

Source range: Book 19. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 20

First-pass working translation

Zeus called the gods to council. “The mortal Achilles has entered battle.
If he meets Hector, Troy will fall before its time. Let each god choose
his side. We will not hold back any longer.”

The gods descended. Apollo stood beside the Trojans; Athena beside the Greeks.
Poseidon, Hera, Hermes, and Hephaestus gathered around the Achaeans;
Ares and Aphrodite joined Apollo. The earth shook as they took their places.
Achilles sought Hector, but Apollo hid the Trojan hero in mist.
Aeneas came forward, urged by Apollo. He said: “Why do you threaten me?
We have fought before. I will not retreat.”

Achilles answered: “Do not stand against me. I have no mercy today.
Patroclus has fallen, and I will not let you escape.”

Aeneas cast his spear. Achilles' shield stopped it. Achilles threw,
but Poseidon carried the spear away and saved Aeneas, for his fate was
not to die there. Aeneas struck a stone, and Achilles rushed toward him.
Poseidon lifted Aeneas from the field, and the two heroes were separated.
Achilles killed many Trojans. Apollo stirred them forward, but the men
could not remain before him. Hector alone held his ground until Apollo
called him away. The battle rolled toward the river.

The gods contended among themselves, while the mortals fought below.
Athena challenged Ares, and Hera restrained Aphrodite. Hermes avoided
Poseidon, saying: “I will not fight the lord of the sea.” Hephaestus
faced the river, and fire answered water.

Achilles met Polydorus, Priam's youngest son, who ran swiftly before him.
Achilles pierced him from behind. Hector saw his brother fall and came
against Achilles. He threw, but Athena blew the spear back to him.
Achilles cast again. Hector vanished beneath Apollo's cloud.
Achilles turned to kill more men, but Hector was already carried away.
The river ran red, and the Trojan army fled toward the gates.

Source range: Book 20. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 21

First-pass working translation

Achilles drove the Trojans toward the river Scamander. He cut their ranks like a fire through reeds. Twelve young men he took alive from the river, to pay for Patroclus at the pyre. He bound them and sent them back. Lycaon's son met him, the man Achilles had once captured and sold. Lycaon begged: "Do not kill me. I am not the son of Hector's mother. I have returned from Lemnos only twelve days ago. A man is not made twice; you killed me once and now my fate has brought me back." Achilles answered: "Do not speak of mercy. Patroclus is dead. You too must die. My own death is near. No man can turn it away." He struck Lycaon and cast him into the river. Asteropaeus came from the Paeonians, born beside the Axios. He threw two spears, but Achilles wounded his arm and took his life. Achilles stripped him, while the river carried the body downstream. Scamander spoke in anger: "Achilles, you have filled my waters with corpses. Leave the banks. Kill men upon the plain, not within my stream." Achilles answered: "I will not stop until Hector falls." The river rose against him. It covered the plain and swept dead men through its channels. Achilles was thrown from his feet. He climbed an elm, but the tree fell; he swam and called to Zeus: "No god has suffered as I do. If the river kills me, I will have died without honor. Better a man kill me than water carry me nameless." Hera heard him and sent Hephaestus. Fire spread along the bank. It dried the bodies and burned the reeds. Scamander cried: "Stop, Hephaestus. I will no longer oppose Achilles." The fire and river ceased. The gods fought among themselves. Athena struck Ares; Hera mocked Artemis and seized her bow; Hermes refused to fight Leto. Poseidon and Apollo held back, waiting for the day when Troy's fate could no longer be deferred. Achilles returned to the plain. Hector alone remained before the gates. The Trojans fled into the city. Agenor stood, but Apollo hid him and drew Achilles away. Achilles chased a phantom of Agenor, while the army passed through the wall. Apollo revealed himself and said: "Why pursue a god? The day of Hector

has not yet come.” Achilles answered: “You have cheated me again,
but I will take vengeance on the Trojans when I return.”

He went toward the city, and the gods withdrew from the field.

Scamander ran clean again, but the dead remained along his banks.

Source range: Book 21. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 22

First-pass working translation

The Trojans fled into the city. Hector remained outside the gates.
Priam saw Achilles approaching and called:
“Come inside, my child. Do not stand alone before him. He is stronger.
You will leave me without a son, and the city will fall. I have lost
many sons already. Do not make your father and mother mourn you.”
Hecuba tore her robe and cried: “Have pity. Come behind the wall.
Achilles killed your brothers and will not spare you.”
Hector would not enter. Shame held him there. He had sent the army out;
he could not hide while others died. Yet he thought of approaching Achilles
with gifts: Helen and her wealth, and half the city's treasure.
Achilles came. Hector fled. They ran around Troy's walls three times,
like two men racing for a prize. The gods watched. Zeus lifted the scales;
Hector's fate sank. Athena came beside Achilles, wearing Deiphobus' form.
Hector stopped and said to Achilles: “I will no longer flee.
Let us fight. If I kill you, I will return your armor, but not your body.
If you kill me, return my body to Troy.”
Achilles answered: “Do not speak of oaths. There can be no friendship
between lion and man, nor between wolves and sheep. You killed Patroclus.
No ransom will save you.”
Hector cast his spear. Athena turned it aside. He called Deiphobus,
but the brother had vanished. Hector knew the gods had deceived him.
He drew his sword and rushed forward.
Achilles watched the armor, seeking the place where Hector could die.
Hector struck, but the spear glanced from the shield. Achilles' spear
entered Hector's throat. He fell in the dust.
Hector said: “I beg you by your life and parents: return my body.
Let my father and mother ransom me. Do not give me to the dogs.”
Achilles answered: “Do not ask. I wish I could cut your flesh and eat it.
No man can keep the dogs from you. Your body will lie beside Patroclus.”
Hector's spirit left him. Achilles stripped the armor. The Achaeans came,
and each struck the dead man. Achilles pierced the feet, tied them to his
chariot, and dragged Hector behind the horses. The dust rose over his head.
Andromache heard the cries from the wall. She ran out and saw her husband

dragged beneath the chariot. Her knees failed. She tore her veil and said:
“Hector, you have died and left us. Our child will have no protector.
The city will be destroyed, and the women carried away. I too will go,
and my son will be taken from me. You were father and husband to me.”
Hecuba and Helen mourned. Helen said: “You alone were kind to me.
Your brothers and sisters hated me, but you defended me. Now I hear
your death and know there is no friend left in Troy.”
Priam and Hecuba tried to stop the people from leaving the gates,
for Achilles' anger still moved around the corpse. The Achaeans returned
to the ships, while Hector's body lay in the dust beneath the wall.

Source range: Book 22. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 23

First-pass working translation

The Achaeans returned to the ships, but Achilles did not eat.
He remembered Patroclus, and sleep would not come. At dawn he ordered
the men to carry wood and build the pyre. They cut their hair and laid it
upon the body. Achilles placed a lock of his own hair in Patroclus' hands.
He called the winds and prayed for fire. The pyre burned through the night.
Achilles slaughtered sheep, cattle, and horses; he killed twelve Trojan
young men beside the fire. Patroclus' spirit appeared in a dream:
“Do not forget me. Bury me quickly, so I may pass the gates of Hades.
Let our bones lie in one urn, as we grew together in your house.”
Achilles woke and told the men to continue the funeral. They quenched
the fire with wine, gathered the white bones, and placed them in a golden urn.
They raised a mound and marked the place, though a greater tomb would come.
Achilles called the army to games in Patroclus' honor. He brought out
tripods, cauldrons, gold, women, cattle, and iron as prizes.
First came the chariots. Eumelus drove well, but Athena broke his yoke;
Diomedes won, and gave the second prize to Antilochus. Menelaus protested
that Antilochus had cut across him. Antilochus apologized, and Menelaus
returned part of the prize, honoring both skill and restraint.
Achilles awarded Eumelus a special prize, though he had not finished;
“He would have won if the goddess had not harmed him.”
In the boxing, Epeius defeated Euryalus. Odysseus and Ajax wrestled,
but neither could throw the other. Ajax won the foot race, though Athena
made Odysseus slip in dung. The Achaeans laughed; Achilles still grieved.
Diomedes won the spear contest; Meriones won the archery. Teucer missed
the bird, and Meriones struck it. The final contest was the heavy stone.
Polypoetes threw farthest, and the games ended near sunset.
Achilles gave the prizes, remembering Patroclus as each man competed.
The games made the army's grief public; after them, the men returned
to the ships, while Achilles still watched the tomb.

Source range: Book 23. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 24

First-pass working translation

The games ended, and the Achaeans returned to their ships.
Achilles still dragged Hector behind his chariot, circling Patroclus'
tomb. The gods pitied the dead man. Apollo protected his body,
keeping the dust from his skin and the wounds from decay.
The immortals argued. Hera and Athena would not forgive Troy,
but Zeus said: "The gods honor Hector, and his family will ransom him.
Send Thetis to Achilles, and Iris to Priam."
Iris went to the old king: "Go to Achilles' tent. Take gifts,
and clasp his knees. He will remember his own father. Go alone,
with one herald and a wagon. Do not fear."
Priam entered his house and called his sons. He ordered a wagon,
and loaded it with robes, gold, tripods, and a mixing bowl.
He prepared twelve garments for Hector, and gifts for Achilles.
Hecuba begged him not to go. Priam answered:
"I will go. If Zeus has sent the sign, I will trust it.
I cannot lie in this house while my son remains unburied."
Hermes came in the shape of a young man and guided Priam through
the Achaean camp. He put the guards to sleep and led the wagon
past the trenches. They reached Achilles' shelter unseen.
Priam entered and clasped Achilles' knees. He kissed the hands
that had killed his sons, and said:
"Remember your father, Achilles, like me an old man near death.
He too may hear that enemies surround him, and no one protects him.
But I am more pitiful: I have done what no other mortal has done.
I have brought my lips to the hands of the man who killed my child.
Give me Hector. Let me take him home. Accept the ransom.
You too have a father. If he lives, his heart rejoices in you.
I have no Hector. He was my only protector, and you have killed him."
Achilles looked at the old man and thought of Peleus. He wept;
Priam wept for Hector, while Achilles remembered Patroclus.
The tent filled with grief shared by enemies.
Achilles said: "You have come bravely. No man could have entered.
Let us not provoke one another. The gods have given you Hector's body."

Take him. You have moved my heart.”

He raised Hector from the bier and placed him upon the wagon.

The women in the tent washed him and wrapped him in clean cloth,
so that Achilles would not see the wounds he had made.

Achilles asked: “How many days do you need to bury him?”

Priam answered: “Nine days to mourn, on the tenth to burn him,
on the eleventh to raise the mound, and on the twelfth to fight again.”

Achilles granted the truce.

Priam slept in the shelter, but Hermes woke him before dawn:

“Rise. If Agamemnon sees you, he will demand to know why you remain.”

Priam loaded Hector and left. Achilles watched in silence.

At Troy, Cassandra saw the wagon and cried from the wall:

“Here comes Hector, carried home. Come out and mourn him.”

The people gathered. Andromache held his head and lamented:

“Hector, you have died young, and left your wife and child. The city will fall.”

Hecuba mourned her son, and Helen spoke:

“You alone were kind to me. The others looked at me with hatred.

Now I have no friend left in Troy.”

They built the pyre, brought wood, and burned Hector. At dawn
they gathered the bones, wrapped them in purple, and placed them
in a golden chest. They raised a mound. The people returned to Troy,
still grieving, while the poem's anger came to rest beside the dead.

Source range: Book 24. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.